# F. O. B. DETROIT

WESSEL SMITTER

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BY

WESSEL SMITTER

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*I Dedicate This Book*

*to*

*FAITH W. SMITTER*

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# CHAPTER I

THE FIRST TIME I SAW HIM HE WAS STANDING THERE NEAR THE HIGH, NARROW GATE IN front of the employment office. The top buttons of his Mackinaw were open and the fine rain slanted down into his face and he acted as if he didn't mind getting his chest wet at all. Kidding the guard, he was, in a way that was sort of confidential and yet half amusement. He had a crooked smile around one side of his mouth that you couldn't hardly tell what it meant, and quiet, black eyes that didn't seem to notice anything special and yet took in everything. The minute I saw him I said to myself, "That guy's never been in the inside of an automobile factory."

There were thirty or forty fellows lined up, trying to get in, but he wasn't standing in line with the others.

The guard filled the whole narrow gate with his shoulders. In his hand he had a piece of black hose that he kept slapping against the side of his leg.

"You guys will have to get in one line," he said, "or they won't none of you fellows get in."

Then I saw what had happened. There were two lines: one of colored fellows and one of whites and neither line would give up its place to the other. It made a fine chance for an argument in a place where arguments are plenty easy to start.

I went up to the guard.

"They hiring anybody?" I said.

"Yesterday we put on a few. Got a paper?"

"No."

"Had a paper I might let you in. All these fellows ain't got no papers either."

I knew what he meant. It was a paper showing that you had bought a new car. It had to be a Holt car, of course. And if it showed that you had bought the car from Mr. Holt's cousin, who was a Holt dealer, so much the better. That way it sort of evens things up. You buy the car and Mr. Holt gives you a job. It's like Mr. Holt says—"What is good for the manufacturer is good for the worker." But if you can't make the down payment, the system don't work.

Across the road was a big parking field full of cars. Ninety acres of cars. They were all Holts. And if you came to work driving some other kind of car, the parking men were liable to not let you in. You had to park on the other side of the railroad tracks where they charged you ten cents a day. It was a long ways to walk. You almost had to take the street car back to the main gate.

I talked some more with the guard.

"If you was to let me in," I said, "they would give me a job. I hear they are starting work on the new model. I've got a good record in there. I've put in five years in motor assembly. I'm a helper. Ain't a job on the line I can't handle."

"How's come," he said, "you ain't got a badge?"

"I turned it in to get the deposit," I said. "I got down pretty low. Five bucks is big dough when you're down to doughnuts and coffee."

It was no good. He told me to line up with the others. But I didn't; I went over to where the big fellow stood. He spoke to me.

"Russ's my name," he said. "What's yours?"

"Mine's Bennie," I said.

"I heard you tell him," he said, "that you've worked here before. You ought to know the ropes."

"Sure," I said. "Only—there's nothing to it. Main thing is to get in. You've got a good chance of being hired if you can get through the gate. They don't ask many questions. Give you a physical examination. They want to see if you're healthy. A good workman ought to be healthy. You look healthy."

"I'm healthy, all right, but I've got no trade. I don't know what the inside of an automobile factory looks like."

"You don't have to have a trade," I said. "If a man's got a trade he's liable to have a lot of wrong ideas. They've got their own ways for doing things in there. If a man's got a trade, he's liable to think his own ways are the best."

"Maybe they are—for him."

"Maybe," I said. "And then again—maybe not. It depends on how you look at it. Getting the job done—that's what counts."

He made a motion and we walked a few steps away from the gate so the guard would not hear us.

"Listen to me," he said. "The main thing is to get in, ain't it? I've been hanging around here five hours. When I got here this morning there were already six colored fellows standing in line and that big mouser told me to line up behind 'em. 'Listen, buddy,' I said to him, 'I'm not used to lining up behind niggers.' So I started a line of my own. Some Arkansawyers come along and I had 'em fall in behind me and then some more fellows came and I stepped out. Now there's two lines—one white and one niggers."

"Yeh," I said, "what about it? If a call comes for a bunch to go in there's liable to be an argument."

"That's it," he said. "That's the way I figured. And when the argument starts—the big fellow will get scrambled up in the fight and we walk in."

"That fellow's husky," I said. "He's an ex-prize fighter. When he starts swinging that piece of hose somebody'll get hurt plenty."

"Don't worry. When I walk in, you follow."

"Sounds easy," I said.

"It is easy," he said. "He's going to let in a fellow first from one line and then from the other. You know what'll happen, don't you?"

"What?"

"Somebody's liable to stick out his foot and trip up a nigger. Somebody'll be standing there—maybe me—right next to the gate, looking innocent. That'll start it. He'll begin swinging that piece of hose and then somebody'll reach over and plant a haymaker right on the side of his jaw. That's when you follow me in."

I don't like that way of getting a job but it's like Mr. Holt says in his book—"There is something sacred about a man's job." And I didn't have any.

It was noon and the guard and the fellows standing in line began eating their lunches. Russ and I didn't have anything to eat so we walked down the line a half mile to where there was a lunch cart near the main gate. Walking along he told me a few things about himself. He'd come down from upper Wisconsin and all his life he'd trapped and worked in the lumber camps. And now he'd come down to Detroit to work in Mr. Holt's factory because he'd heard the wages were good and his idea was to save money and go into business and the business he wanted to go into was clamming. Clamming, he said, was the most independent life that any man could get into. And there was a chance to make money because the shells were worth fifty dollars a ton and you sold the meats to the farmers to feed to their pigs. And then there was always a chance of finding a pearl. But the thing that appealed to him was that you were your own boss. If you wanted to go to work at four o'clock in the morning before the fog lifted off the water, you could. Or, if you felt like laying around in camp all day and taking it easy, there was no one to tell you you couldn't. He'd done a little of everything. In the lumber woods he had run a donkey engine, where, he said, he'd got to be pretty slick with the levers, One summer he'd been an engineer on a steam thresher. But a clammer is what he wanted to be and he'd come down to Detroit to earn money to buy an outboard motor, a boat, and an old automobile to haul his stuff around in. He'd never worked in a factory and when I said something about "the line" he didn't know what I meant.

I tried to give him a little advice.

"When you get in there," I said, "they'll give you a job. Mostly, you take what you get. If it's production, it's doing the same thing over and over all day, like putting in a screw or a gasket. The

stuff you work on moves past you on a track, or a belt. You've got so many seconds. There's lots of different lines," I said, "and they're all fast, but some are faster than others. There's 'blue mass'—that's final assembly—and the motor line, for instance. They're fast. I worked on the motor assembly line. I was a helper. I helped to break in new men and stood in for fellows when they wanted to go to the toilets. A helper has got to be an all-around good man. But there're other jobs."

"What are they?"

"Well, they's sweepers."

"Yeh, sweepers. Fellows that go around and sweep up the floors."

"I don't wanna sweep floors. I can't see myself going around with a broom and a dustpan picking up other fellows' dirt."

"It pays the same money," I said. "It's not line work and the bosses don't push you. You saw those fellows lined up. About half the white fellows are farmers. The other half are auto workers. You can tell the auto workers. No overcoats, most of 'em; patent leather shoes with cracks in 'em, and no rubbers. They've been in there before. About half of 'em will try to get on as sweepers. If they can't make it the first time, they'll go out, line up and try it again. Some of them won't have a job on the line. Some of 'em can't take it. They get nervous and first thing you know, they're all tied up in a knot. I've seen it happen. When the bell rings there'll be a kind of dumb look on their faces and they'll start walking off in the wrong direction. It'll be a minute or two before they'll come to."

He laughed.

"Listen, partner," he said, "you don't have to worry about me. I want a job that'll give me a chance to show what I'm worth. In the woods—I've always been able to hold up my end along with the rest of 'em."

"That's me, too," I said. "I'm trying to work my way up. Some day I'm gonna be a straw boss in motor assembly. But right now, I'd take any job they got for me."

We got us something to eat—a bottle of milk each and a paper carton of beans dished out with a scoop, and while eating we kidded the girl. I had seen her before. I had tried to make a date with her once but never got to first base. She was good-looking, in a cute sort of way. Lots of black hair and snappy eyes. A boy's cap made her look smart and sassy. She made fun of Russ' boots and the way he had his pants tucked into them and when we turned in our milk bottles and were ready to leave, she said:

"All alone in the big city?"

"How did you guess it?" he asked.

"Oh—I been around some," she said. "Been places and seen things and stuff."

"And stuff, mostly, I guess. Where I come from," he said, "kids like you are still taking things outa bottles."

"They do here, too," she said, "if you get what I mean."

"Tough, eh?"

"No—just dynamic. That's our slogan, you know. You'll see it if you keep your eyes open. 'Dynamic Deroit.'"

"What's it mean," he asked, "dynamic?"

"Oh—I don't know. I guess maybe it means we go places and do things."

She gave him a card and he looked at it. On it there was the name and address of a taxi-dance place over a store on Woodward Avenue.

"Come up and see me sometime, big boy," she said. "I'll show you how to do the Big Apple. Ask for Rita."

He bent the card between his thumb and forefinger and snapped it out into the street.

"I don't like to climb stairs," he said. It was easy to see he could be a heller with women if he wanted to.

We started back but before we got there the rumpus began and we made it back to the gate in just about nothing flat. The whites and niggers were piling into each other. Half the fellows were down, the others on top. It was just a heap with arms and legs sticking out—pounding and kicking. But the guard was not in it. He had his back to the gate and reached out with his hose whenever he got a chance to get in a crack. This big fellow—Russ—was itching to get in a poke at the guard.

Then a colored fellow crawled out of the heap and got a clout with the hose that made him let out a bellow. He made a dive for the guard, wrapped his arms around the guard's legs, and they were down in the heap. A farmer with a bloody nose broke loose from the pile, ran to the emergency alarm on the curb and turned in a riot call.

"Come on—" said Russ; "now or never. They'll be here in a minute."

We ducked through the gate, ran through the narrow lane between the steel fences, and stepped into the office. There were thirty or forty fellows in the bull pen, sitting on benches. The clerks were still out to lunch. We took seats and in a minute we heard the sirens. Some of the fellows wondered what the excitement was all about and tried to look out of the high windows.

After ten minutes, or so, the clerks began drifting back into the office. One of them went into his cage and came out with a piece of paper.

"Any of you fellows here ever run a manipulator?" he asked.

Not a man answered.

"What's a manipulator?" Russ whispered.

"A kind of derrick," I said. "Used for handling hunks of hot steel."

"Let's grab it," he said.

"Wait a minute—" I warned him. "You don't know what you're getting into."

"If it's a machine," he said, "I can run it."

The clerk looked the men over. He noticed Russ.

"Anybody here," he said, "that's had experience running electric cranes?"

"That manipulator job—" said Russ, "I'll take it. I'd like this man here to swamp for me."

"Ever run one?" the clerk asked.

"No, but I've run donkey engines and loaders. I'm a good learner. It won't take me long to get what I don't know."

The fellow scratched his head for a minute.

"All right," he said. "We'll give you a try. Where's your helper?"

"Right here." And he pointed to me.

I had a job. It all happened so quick I didn't know whether to be glad or not. A colored fellow sitting next to me said they were hiring men for the foundry. Work there ain't what it's cracked up to be. I decided to stick with the big fellow. If I didn't like it I could put in later for a transfer.

We went up and filled out our cards. Then we sat down again and waited for a bunch of other fellows that were going up to the plant hospital for examinations.

"What's the matter?" said Russ. "You look disgusted. You think I stuck my foot into something, don't you?"

"Not your foot," I said. "Your neck. You got any sort of idea the kind of job you grabbed off for us?"

"No. You?"

"No. All I know—I've seen it a couple of times on my way through the drop forge. They use it handling big steel. It's so complicated they have to get a factory man on the job every time it breaks down."

"Swell," he said. "We're going to have fun. We're going to learn something."

"If we don't get fired."

"We didn't pay anything to get the job. Why not try something that's interesting? Those line jobs don't sound good to me. If they fire us—all we've lost is a job that didn't cost us anything."

"But that outfit's complicated," I said. "More gears and levers than you ever saw. Got an iron claw that picks up ten-ton billets of steel and sticks em into the furnaces. Pulls 'em out when they get hot and holds 'em under steam hammers as high as a two-story building. I'd be scared to climb up on it. Suppose the thing got out of control. Then what?"

"They give a man a chance to learn, don't they? They don't expect him to get up there and run it the first day, do they?"

"Oh, sure. They let you learn. Even if you could run it, they wouldn't let you, the first day. They've got their own way of doing things."

"Q-keh," he said. "That's all that matters. I don't know yet what kind of outfit it is. All I know is, if it's meant to be run, we'll run it. All a man needs on any job is brains and a fair chance to learn. We've got the brains. If we didn't . . . we'd still be out there in the street."

"Or in the cooler," I said.

I had to admire his nerve. He had a lot of respect for himself—more than most of the fellows I know that have worked in the Holt plant a long time.

# CHAPTER II

EARLY THE NEXT MORNING I WAS IN THE DROP FORGE, NEAR THE TIME CLOCK, WAITING FOR Russ. The night shift was still on and the heavy production machinery was running full blast. Rows of furnaces were shooting out flames and smoke around the door; hammers and presses were pounding out front axles, gear blanks and such. The floor of the building covered five or six acres and the ground trembled and shook.

Over in a far corner of the building the top of the manipulator loomed up through the smoke like a battleship's turret, the big boom, or arm, sticking out like a ship's gun. There everything was still dark and silent. No production there—no working on small parts for the car—no night shift. Our work would be during the hours of daylight with big machines getting out big dies used in forming fenders and body panels, forging out pieces of steel too heavy to handle by hand. I knew that much already.

Russ came in and we went up to the machine. It was as big as a locomotive, and higher—mounted on a carriage that ran over steel rails, wide apart, laid in the concrete floor. On the carriage were other rails that ran crosswise and the superstructure ran on these so that the machine could run in four directions. From the upper part of the machine a big arm, or boom, projected that turned with the superstructure. The arm could be raised or lowered, shortened or made longer, turned or pivoted in any direction and on the end there was a claw with two curved iron fingers big enough to go around a bass drum. Steel ladders ran up the sides of the machine and from where we stood we could see the tops of two rows of brass control levers. I think the machine weighed sixty tons.

"That's her," I said. "Still want to run it?"

"Oh, sure," he said. "She's a honey. I think we're gonna get along swell. There's room here, room to work."

At the end of the long floor were piles of cold steel, all sizes and shapes. Along one side were the furnaces, some of them under slow heat, grumbling and purring. On the other side were the heavy presses and hammers reaching up into the smoky heights of the building. Over-head, forty-

fifty feet above the floor, a traveling bridge crane rumbled back and forth, carrying bundles of steel in cable slings to the production machines. The operator stuck his head out of the steel cage as he rode past and looked us over.

The name of the day superintendent was Riley and we went up to his desk and the place swarmed with timekeeps, foremen, and clerks, and everybody was talking loud to make himself heard above the noise of the machines, waving papers and getting tangled up in telephone cords like they always do in Mr. Holt's factory between shifts. A timekeep gave us our cards and our badges and told us where to punch in and then let out a yell for Johnson, our straw boss. Johnson came up and he was short and the skin on his face was like leather. He had no eyebrows and he looked at us a minute with smoke-colored eyes and said:

"Gotcha cards?"

"Yeh."

"Gotcha badges?"

"Yeh."

"Follow me."

The three of us walked over to the floor where the machine stood and here Johnson had a little desk on high legs, but no stool. A lot of blue prints were stuck in a wall cabinet and he pulled out one and began looking at it and the skin on his forehead wrinkled as though it hurt him to think. Russ had started walking off towards the machine when Johnson raised up and said:

"Hey! Stick around here, will you?"

He studied the blue prints again and I motioned to Russ to take it easy and wait and we stood there watching the men drifting in. And then the bell rang and a couple of fellows started oiling the machines; the steam was turned on in the hammers and the big pistons began warming up—sliding up and down in long easy strokes, not quite touching the anvils below. Some little colored lights over the furnaces changed from green to orange and then to red; the flames back-fired a couple of times and then settled down to a steady roar.

Johnson raised up again.

"I don't know if I tol-ya," he said, "but I don't put up with no smoking; no sitting down and no standing with hands in your pockets. It looks bad for fellas that's on production; it's against the rules, and besides—I don't stand for it."

"Well—you'll notice," said Russ, "we didn't bring any cigars and armchairs."

Johnson's eyes snapped open.

"And anodda t'ing," he said; "I don't stand for no loafing in toilets. Between heats—when there's no steel to work—I expect you fellas to keep your machine clean."

He called for one of the fellows working on the machine to come over. The man wasn't dressed like a Holt worker. He had on a good suit with a pair of coveralls over it and he had a temporary badge.

"Barney, here," said Johnson, "is from the factory. He'll break you fellas in. Ride around with him," he said to Russ. "Keep your eyes open and don't be afraid to ask questions. I don't expect you'll try to handle no jobs the first coupla weeks."

"And this man," he said, pointing to me, "will take Hank's place. Introjuice 'em togedda and let Hank show him the work."

"Q-keh," said Barney. "And what's the schedule?"

"Load five and six. I'll mark some steel pretty soon. An 'en we'll pull number three and work it up under number one hammer."

The three of us went to the machine. I got introduced to Hank.

"If I was you," said Hank, "I'd go to the tool crib and get me some rags. We'll swipe off some of this grease."

I could see that he wasn't a smart nigger like some that's been in the factory a long time, drawing big wages and working alongside of whites.

After a while Barney finished his oiling, threw in the master switch on the wall, and then he and Russ climbed up on the rig and they rolled down the wide tracks to the end of the bay. In a minute or two they came back, electric horn blowing, and in the big claw sticking out ahead of the rig, there was a billet of cold steel that weighed maybe four-five tons. They stopped in front of number five furnace; Barney maneuvered into position; aimed for the door and gave Hank a signal. Hank cut off the air; pressed a button and the heavy door of the furnace slid up towards the ceiling. Barney's hands fairly played a tune on the levers. The long arm reached in with its load—the claw opened and the steel was laid on the furnace floor. The arm retracted and as Hank pressed another button that closed the door, the flames curled and twisted around the steel like snakes getting ready to swallow a gopher.

"Always cut off the air befo' opening the furnace," said Hank. "If you was to forget—the flames might shoot out and singe the hair off yo buddy. I sho don't like this job. Half the time I'm trying to remember if I forgot to do something I should—the rest of the time I'm worried les' I did something I shouldn't. I'll be mighty glad when you gets this job learnt and I can go back to the foundry. There I knock sand out of molds. Don't have to wrack and ruin my brains about nothin'."

There wasn't much to his job. Opening and closing the doors; watching to see that the track was kept clear; cutting out the switch in emergencies, and a few things like that.

Barney and Russ loaded the furnaces and then they rolled up to number one and got ready to do some forging. I had an idea what it was like, having watched the machines work before. It was one of those jobs like tapping a blast furnace, or discharging a coke oven, that was worth watching; worth stopping a minute to see, even though the bell had rung and you were in a hurry to get home. The biggest steam hammer in the factory was there—a pair of shears that had a bite of a thousand tons. What they did to the big billets was liable to give you an idea that steel is about as

tough and hard as new cheese, which is all wrong, even when it's been in the fire a long time and is up to white heat.

Barney pulled the hot billet of steel out of the furnace, got a firm hold, and swung the boom around in front of the hammer. There were experts on the job, now. Johnson, who directed the work and made all signals; the hammer man, who controlled the force of the giant blows; and Barney, who ran the manipulator. His job was to get the steel up on the anvil; to turn it and tip it —to hold it in position while the hammer got in its work.

Johnson signalled to get the steel up on the anvil. The hammer got into motion. Not striking, yet—but getting ready. Warming up for the signal. That up-and-down motion of the hammer between the smooth slides, that oily flow of movement, gave you an idea of what steam could do: of the power that was held in reserve behind the long piston, of the kind of blows that would come when Johnson gave the signal and the hammer man came down hard on the throttle.

The hammer stopped, poised to strike, and the job was all Barney's. The white hot billet had to be just so on the anvil—had to be just right for the hammer. A slight turn—a little to the right —a little back, maybe. Slight movements, these were, that had to be done quickly. No time to fool around, no time to waste, because the steel was all the time losing heat. Five tons of hot steel is not like a piece of cold stuff that you can come up to and sit on; it's something alive, something vicious, waiting for a chance to strike you, if you lose control.

Barney was clever, all right. He knew the job, knew the machine, knew the signals. And the last was not the least part of the business. Johnson made them all with his right thumb; mysterious little jerks and twitches—jabs over his shoulder—past his ear—downwards. The brass levers snapped back and forth, switches flashed, circuit breakers popped out and slammed back into place, rheostats smoked. I wondered what Russ was thinking about standing up there next to Barney. Plenty—I guessed.

The steel was battered and pounded; was dropped to the floor; turned over. The iron claw grabbed a new hold and slammed it back on the anvil for more. The hammer crashed down in full strokes. Fire sprayed out in a circular shower and rained to the floor. The ground shook. Not light shakes—heavy and deep—transmitted through a foundation of solid concrete, sixty feet down.

They were unable to finish the work in one heat and the steel was put back into the furnace. Afterwards, Russ and Barney came down for a drink. Their shirts were soaked.

"How's she going?" I asked Russ.

"Fine and dandy," he said.

"Be a long two weeks for you," I said. "Riding around up there, doing nothing."

"Don't worry," he said. "In a week I'll be runnin' the thing. See if I won't. Only thing hard to learn is the signals."

"Johnson's?"

"Yeh."

"What's hard about them?"

"They're not plain. You'd think it was some kind of secret code. That he didn't want the man on the rig to catch on."

"Why don't you tell him?"

"No use. Can't educate him none. He ain't the type. He's the kind that never lets you forget he's the big boss."

The bell rang and we stopped for lunch, and while eating, Russ asked Barney a lot of questions about the job and the rig. About back-lash and over-loads; dynamic brakes and magnetic clutches. Barney answered the questions, but not with any great show of enthusiasm. He was a traveling mechanic for the company that made the machine and he'd been around quite a bit and he was full of talk about the towns he'd been in. But mostly, he was interested in women and when Russ asked a question, he answered short and then swung the talk around to girls he'd met in Pittsburgh, Fort Worth, or Birmingham. His company paid him twelve dollars a day and all traveling expenses and that was argument enough to convince him that he could afford to be independent.

He was telling about a girl in Cincinnati who never warmed up right satisfactory unless she was riding around on a steamboat with a band playing, when Russ interrupted again.

"If one of the rheostats burned out," he asked, "how would you go about to fix it?"

"Now listen," said Barney, "it's lunch time. It's time off. They're not paying you now for asking questions. Let's wait till the bell rings."

"I know, but if you don't mind —"

"All you have to learn is how to punch those levers. If the rheostat breaks down—they'll get the electricians to fix it. If you get drunk and bust up the rig—like the other fellow did—they'll send for me." .

"I savvy. But just the same, I want to know."

"All right, then. You've got two weeks to learn. You don't need two weeks. In two days I could turn the job over to you—if I wanted to. You're the kind that learns quick. But what's the use? Make the thing look easy, and they'll figure anybody can run it. Then how you gonna hold 'em up for a raise? Tell me that."

"I hadn't thought about that."

"Hadn't thought about it?"

"Not yet."

"Well, now's the time to be thinking about it. Look at the job you'll be handling! Look at the responsibility! Ruin one of these blocks and it's five hundred bucks. Wreck the machine, and it's thousands. Kill a guy—and you're washed up. They've taken the seat off the rig so you can't sit. They won't let you smoke a cigarette to steady your nerves. And what do you get? Five bucks. Five lousy bucks. They's sweepers here in this outfit gets more'n that."

"The time to think about all those things," said Russ, "fs later. Right now I'm trying to get the job learnt."

The bell rang and we went back to work.

# CHAPTER III

At the end of the week Russ took over the controls. Barney rode around on the machine a couple of days doing nothing; hung around on the floor a couple more, and then left for Cleveland. By the end of the third week Russ was pretty good—good enough to coast along on the job and take it easy, if he'd wanted to. But that wasn't his idea. He kept learning—kept digging into the machine to see what made the wheels go around—kept trying to work up more speed—more speed, all the time. When he didn't get a job done and it had to go back in the fire he took it as a personal grief and felt bad about it the whole day.

We'd moved into the same boarding house and one night, up in the room while fiddling around with his guitar but not really playing, he got an idea.

"Listen," he said, "a pianist doesn't stop to look for the keys when he's playing. What's to hinder a man learning to run that rig the same way? Learning to work the levers without looking at them? There's only a dozen."

"What's your idea?" I said. "Take a little nap now and then?"

"No. Keep my eyes on the steel. On Johnson. Wouldn't have to stop to look for the controls, for positions."

"Could be done, I guess. Only thing is —"

"Sure it could be done. Dog-gone —"

"Only thing is there's a slight difference between playing a piano and running that rig. When the pianist hits the wrong key there's a sour note but no one gets hurt. You hit the wrong control —you may accidentally drop a hunk of steel on somebody's head."

What I said didn't discourage him none. The idea stuck. He hauled a couple of two-by-fours up in the room and rigged up a contraption with two rows of sticks the size and shape of the levers. They were spaced accurately and like the controls on the rig could be moved back and forth into various positions. Blindfolded, he practiced night after night. That was all right with me, except that I lost some sleep. But when he started practicing on the rig, I watched my step and gave him plenty of clearance. It was hard enough to figure why a smooth hunk of steel the size of a cow

didn't slip out of the claw under normal conditions. With him looking off into space and paying no attention to what lever he struck, I gave it up. However, no one got really killed and the building wasn't wrecked and things went along as before, except that not so many jobs were going back into the fire. But still there were some and these continued to bother him something fierce.

"Where we're losing motion," he said to me one night, walking back and forth between the door and his bed, "is in the re-heats. Think of the time we'd be saving if we could finish every job in one heat—if we never had to put a single piece back in the fire. Besides, we'd be running more stuff through the furnaces."

"Sure," I said, "anybody can see that. But what's holding the jobs up? Who's handling the stuff?"

There was no harm in kidding him a little. He was good and he knew it. He was so good that if Barney had come back he would have made him look like an amateur.

"Here's how it could be done."

"What done?"

"Jobs speeded up," he said.

"How?"

"Not wait for signals. Know all about a job before starting. Go over the blue prints with Johnson. Even now—lotsa times—I know before he signals, what he wants me to do. But I can't move, can't move a lever till he gives me the signal, till he twitches that thumb. And all the time we're losing the heat."

"That's true. But don't forget—there's Johnson."

"Yeh," he said, slumping down on the bed, "and there's Johnson's idea of Johnson."

"You've got it figured out," I said. "That ought to show you the idea won't work."

"Just the same, I'm going to try it. Put it up to him easy, be diplomatic."

And he did, a couple of days later. But he wasn't diplomatic—not diplomatic enough. And it got Johnson pretty hostile, which I knew that it would.

"What's the matta?" he said. "Don't you like the way I'm handlin' my job? You want me to trade you?"

"That's not it," said Russ. "But if I had a look at those blue prints before we started a job, I'd know what was coming. Know how to work with you better. Get the idea of what you were trying to forge out. Give you better cooperation."

"Oh—" said Johnson, "that's it. You wanna get your hands on those blue prints. You wanna make it look to Riley like you was runnin' the floor. Why doncha see Riley? Tell 'im you don't need me no more. Tell 'im you'll run the whole shebang by yourself."

"Listen, Johnson. I'm not after your job. Don't get sore. I'm only trying to speed up the work."

"Well I'm tellin' ya somethin': I'm gettin' paid for looking at those blue prints. See? I can do all the looking that has to be done. And when I can't do it—when my job gets so big I can't handle it—I'll let you know. I'll ask ya to please help me out. See?"

For the rest of the afternoon Russ was madder than seven boiled owls. He took it out on the ingots. There was a close connection between Russ—the way he was feeling, and the way the rig worked. I could always tell by the way the machine worked, how he felt. When the machine dragged, I knew Russ was tired. When it moved sharp and quick, I knew he was full of pep. That afternoon there was a snap to the rig. Nothing gentle and easy about the way it acted. The big claw bit into the ingots like it was going to bite them in two, swung them across the floor like a bulldog shaking a cat in a wide alley. Blue flashes played over the switchbox; things moved with a bang and I kept myself plenty well in the clear.

That night, up in the room, he was still feeling meaner than a wet traffic cop.

"With a guy like that Swede over us," he said, "we're stuck, Bennie. All he thinks about is his own measly job. When I'm up there on that rig—feel all that power at the tips of my fingers—all that static in the brass levers—I get to thinking. I get to feeling how easy it would be to reach out there and nip off his head. Or, if you should accidentally leave a furnace door open some time, how easy it would be to pick him up and stick him head first into the fire before he could let out a pip."

"What are you crabbing about," I said. "You're drawing your wages."

"A man's got a right to get something out of a job besides wages," he said.

"Besides wages? What else would he get? A Congressional medal?"

"He's got a right to get some satisfaction."

"Satisfaction?"

"Yes—satisfaction. A feeling that he's worth something. That his work counts. That what he's trying to do amounts to something."

"That's a new one," I said. "You didn't pick up that idea in no auto factory. Forget about Johnson. You don't have to pal around with him, you and him don't have to be buddies. What do you care if you don't get to be general manager? You're going clamming, ain't you?"

"In a year. Maybe two years if I don't get a raise. I'll need three hundred bucks. Takes time to lay up that much."

"Well, put in your time and be satisfied with drawing your wages—same as the others."

"I don't work that way," he said. "If it was two days instead of two years, I still wouldn't—unless I had to. It's no fun. It'll be no fun either for the fellow that has to dig up my wages if all the time I have to buck Johnson."

He sat there on the edge of the bed for a while, thinking, and then he said:

"Bennie, why don't you make up your mind to pull out and go clamming with me? We'll be partners." Just like that, out of a clear sky.

"Cripes—" I said. "Russ, I don't know nothing about clams. I've always worked in Detroit—in Mr. Holt's factory. I don't know nothing else."

"You don't have to," he said. "I'll show you. I'll explain everything to you that you have to know. You could work around camp—cut the wood and fix up the grub. I'd go out on the river and drag bottom. With the both of us saving our money, we could pull out of this dump in six or eight months. We'd go fifty-fifty. Make as much in one summer as we could here in two years."

"Maybe. You're not sure. It's a gamble."

"So's this. So's everything. Suppose we get laid off tomorrow? Suppose Mr. Holt figures he's made enough automobiles for a while and shuts down? Besides—look at the fun we'd be having. Out in the open, lots of fresh game and fish. No cards to punch, no straw bosses playing Napoleon over us. We'd work hard and have fun at the same time."

"It wouldn't be like having a steady job."

"How do you know? You've never had one. You get laid off every time they change models and then you don't have any job. And all the time you've got to spend money. Clamming you practically don't need money. You trade clam meats to the farmers for grub. Cut your own wood, dip your water out of a spring. Here even the water you drink has to be paid for; the air you breathe if you're sitting in a movie and they're running it through a strainer to take out the street dirt and smoke.

"What bothers me," I said, "is the nights. There'd be nothing to do—way out in the sticks. No movies, no women—no nothing."

"You'd forget about the movies," he said. "You'd find you didn't need 'em. You'd get along without newspapers, too, and you'd find that all the newspaper reading that you've done has left you just where you started. After supper we'd make a fire and talk about things. The frogs would be singing. Maybe there'd be a big moon coming up over the river, and, way off somewhere, there'd be 2 whippoorwill or an owl. Maybe a farmer would come down and bring us a jug of buttermilk and some Red Astrakan apples and we'd sit around the fire a while a-talking and telling stories. There'd be the smell of new clover hay and cornflowers in the air and by'n'by the fire would get low and go out and you'd see the fireflies making little trails of light over the grass where it's high, and the mist forming along the edge of the water, and way off somewhere—t'hell 'n gone over the river—you'd hear a cowbell. That kind of life does something to you, Bennie. You get so, pretty soon, you lose all your bad habits. You forget about women; you don't think about booze; and after a couple of months you get so that you can't stand the stink of a cigarette. You get out an old pipe that's caked up like a cement mixer and you fill 'er up and light her with a coal that you scrape up from the fire and you enjoy the smell of good honest tobacco without dope in it."

"Dog-gone, Russ," I said, "you sound like a poet. Blamed if I don't think I'll try it. I've always thought I'd like to do something like that."

"Why don't you?"

"Will you learn me how to play the guitar?"

"Sure," he said. "It's a go. From now on—we're partners."

We talked about clamming some more, and, then, pretty soon it got late and we turned in. And then I got to thinking, laying there under the blankets, I got to thinking maybe I was letting myself into something. What did I know about clamming? Suppose they didn't bite? Suppose the government should put down an embargo—or a closed season—or whatever it is they do when they're feeling mean about something? Then what? I had a good job in Mr. Holt's factory. Times had been bad in Detroit; weren't so good yet. And if they got bad again, I knew my way around—knew where I could get a hand-out in restaurants. Knew where I could pick up things in alleys behind stores. There are ways of getting by in a town like Detroit if you know how. But out in the country with nothing but cows and mosquitoes, and not knowing how to get along with either, I'd be lost. It was all right to sit there by the fire listening to whippoorwills and drinking buttermilk, but if it's raining black cats a yard long, I'd rather have a drink of straight rye and be listening to the click of billiard balls in Jim's Place. It was all right, too, to say that I'd lose my bad habits—that I'd forget all about women. But suppose I didn't? Suppose sometime in a weak moment I'd want to tear off to 418314 North Hastings Street and couldn't? Then what? Yeh—then what? Then what? Then what? I said to myself.

The next morning I didn't have the nerve to tell Russ that I'd changed my mind. I thought I'd let it ride for a while and not tell him. I thought he might change his mind, too, if he got along all right in the factory, got a raise after while and didn't stir up any more arguments with Johnson.

# CHAPTER IV

It wasn't long before the white-collars up front began taking notice of what was going on on the floor. You'd see one of them hurrying along down the aisle as though he was late to a circus, and then he'd see Russ up there on the rig handling steel as though it was cordwood, and he'd slow down, come to a stop near a pillar and clean forget what he'd been in such a bloody hurry about. The way Russ got to handling that rig when he had a tough job up in the anvil was something to watch through the flying red sparks and the smoke. And then, one day, they changed the routing of the gangs of tourists that came through the factory and had them all bother us. It gave a man a headache to try and keep them off the track where they were all hell-bent on standing. There were all sorts and sizes of tourists. Flocks of schoolteachers; Rotary fellows, with little red flags and yellow buttons in their coats; Holstein breeders and members of the United Brotherhood of Bartenders. While I tried to herd them off the track and back into the aisle again, the guide would go into a spiel that sounded good but was all wrong, as a matter of fact, and Russ would shoot up and down as though it was just my hard luck and not his if he flattened out a couple of Masons or Elks on the tracks. One thing was sure—it wouldn't be the Company's, because every man, woman and child had to sign cards saying that it was their own fault, if, while going through the factory, they lost a leg or an arm or got slightly killed.

If it happened that Russ was handling a piece of steel under the big hammer—they saw something. It gave them something to take home and remember and tell the brother Masons about when they got back to Sioux Center or Oshkosh.

One time there was a lady in the crowd who had a pair of glasses on the end of a stick and carried a dog. It was a small dog, hardly big enough to support more than one or two fleas; white as a snowflake, and bangs down over the front of its eyes. At the very first crack of the hammer he let out a yip, jumped to the ground and scampered under the manipulator. The lady threw a high-toned conniption fit. We were stymied—couldn't turn a wheel.

"Oh, my Da-die—my Dadie!" she screamed. "He'll get hurt—he'll get killed! Somebody save him! Oh! Please! Won't somebody save him!"

Russ swung down the ladder in one flying leap.

"What's the matter?" he said. "Somebody get hurt?"

"No—no—o—o—" she moaned in a husky voice. "My dog—my Dadie! He's under there. Can't you see? Can't you see—e—e ——"

"My gosh," he said. "That's serious. What's he doing under there? Call him out, can't you?"

She stooped down and called. Begged him to come out, pleaded. But he had his mind made up to stay where he was.

"He won't come," she said. "He won't mind me. Poor dear thing, he's scared. He's scared to death. He's been sulky all morning. Didn't like the noise, didn't like the smell of the dirty old factory. He'll think I've been mean; he'll never forget it."

Half the crowd were on their knees calling. The other half were getting primed with suggestions. A man in gray spats suggested getting a big dog to haul the little dog out. A schoolteacherish looking lady said that animal magnetism would do the trick and went about from one to the other asking if there was anyone in the crowd that was "dog-minded." Johnson came up, sputtering, full of original ideas.

"Start the rig up," he said to Russ. "Scrape a couple of gears; throw a scare into 'im. He'll come out a-fluting."

"Don't you dare!" she exploded. "I'll have you reported; I'll have you fined. He's too scared, now. That's what's the matter, that's why he won't come."

Russ had the good sense to back out and leave the field clear for Johnson.

"Lady," said Johnson, "that dog a yours is holdin' us up. It's costin' us money."

"Can I help it? It's your men, your noise, that frightened him. Please—tell the others to stop calling. It merely confuses—makes him worse."

"Maybe," said Johnson, "if you had somethin' to eat for 'im. Maybe one of the boys has got a sandwich —"

"That's ridiculous. He never eats, except at mealtimes. It's doctor's orders."

"But, lady, we gotta do somethin'. We got a job on the iron. It's gettin' cold."

She tried calling again. And such a line of ga-ga the hard-boiled scalers never listened to before in their lives. It was "bad mans" this and "'b'es ee's itty heart" that and "Mommie's sweet Dadie doggy. Won't um tum out. Oh pease. Won't um tum out." It was the stickiest line of baby-talk you ever heard. She did her best. You half expected the nuts and washers to back off and come rolling out. But Dadie didn't.

"It's no use," she moaned. "He's too nervous. He's lost confidence in me—in his own Mommie. He won't come until he changes his mood—until he loves me again."

"How long you tink it will take?" asked Johnson.

"Oh, I don't know. He hardly looked at me—then. Shut off those terrible machines back there that keep hammering, keep pounding so! They're making him nervous. I know."

"Can't do it, lady. They're on production. Have to shut down the whole factory."

"Then take this thing apart. Get your men here. How long will it take?"

"Can't do that either. We gotta use it. We gotta get going. Listen, lady. If we start it up—make a little noise maybe—not much —"

"NO-NO! It would frighten him. Make him worse —"

"I t'ink he'd come out a ki-yi-ing, if you ask me. If he didn't I'd see the company got you anodda white pup. It'll cost a couple hundred if we can't get to work."

"A couple of hundred! What's that? Would you kill my precious for that? You're brutal! You're not fit to live in the same world with animals."

She left Johnson cold and turned to the guide.

In the meantime, Russ had dragged up an air hose and was giving directions to one of the scalers. The scaler stuck the hose under the rig, on the far side; Russ stood on the other.

"If Doctor Anson were here," she said to the guide, "he'd know a way out. He has such a way with my Dadie—such understanding. Where's the nearest telephone—long distance? I've got to talk to him. New York."

The scaler had his thumb on the valve. Russ gave the signal. There was a mighty blast as a hundred and fifty pounds of air were cut loose: an upheaval of dirt, cinders, coal dust, and iron scales rose from the floor, and one or two of us who didn't have our eyes shut saw a greasy white streak about the size and shape of a dirty dishrag skid over the floor.

When the dust settled, there was Russ holding the pup, trying to keep the dog from licking the grime off his face.

"My Dadie!" she cried. "My darling! The man saved you! My snookie—um—u—m—m—ums —." They clinched.

The steel was cold. We had to stick it back in the fire. And when Russ picked it off the anvil and rolled down the track with the rig, Joe, the sweeper, raised an eyebrow and wrinkled his nose and looked through an imaginary pair of glasses at the end of a stick down at the floor. The pup had left a mess for him to clean up.

# CHAPTER V

YOU WOULD HAVE THOUGHT WHAT WITH ALL THE ADMIRATION HE GOT FROM THE CROWDS, and the guides laying it on plenty thick that he would have started swelling up like a poisoned pup. But such wasn't the case. He gave most of the credit to the rig and began getting fussy about it, calling it pet names like "Betsy" and "Old Ironsides," and even others more sentimental, I expect, when I wasn't near. Night after night, after work, we'd go down to the factory with a bottle of polish and shine up the brasses, he doing most of the work; me listening to his odd line of chatter.

"I tell you, Bennie," he'd say, "it gives a man a great feeling to get up there when the power is on and get his hands on those levers and feel the static go tingling up and down your fingers and arms. It's the same as though you had two hundred horsepower added to your own strength. To be able to handle power like that and make it mind you—make it do your will, with the delicate touch of a lever—I tell you it makes a bigger man outa you."

"It sure does," I said, "unless you was to get too much of that static and it sat you down on your seater."

He got so he made all his own adjustments, and after setting up a brake or a clutch, he'd throw on the juice and see how it worked. I'd set a milk bottle full of water down on the floor and he'd try to pick it up and empty it without breaking the glass. We fooled around so much in the factory at night the night watch got suspicious and we got orders to stay out.

One time Herman, who ran the overhead crane and chewed tobacco, spit down from his cage and hit the claw on the machine. Russ was carrying a piece of cold steel. He stopped the rig, lowered the boom, and got Herman's shirt from the cabinet and swiped off the rig.

That night, at the clock, they had some words. Not much—but sharp. It left bad feelings in both.

A day or two later Herman started being careless with his loads—swinging in close, as he went over the rig. Russ got up on his ear.

"Tell your man up there," he said to Herman's helper, "if he does that again I'll reach up there and pull him down to the floor."

"Take it easy," I said. "No use getting him sore at you. There's some big jobs coming up. You're going to need his help."

What we called a big job was anything over ten tons, which was the limit capacity of the rig. Anything over, Russ couldn't handle alone and Herman helped. A sling was wrapped around the steel and Herman let down his hook and tied onto it, easing some of the strain off the rig. Cooperation between the two had to be smooth; it was no job for a couple of soreheads to work on together.

The bell rang and Herman came down for lunch. Russ went up to him and made himself plain.

"Listen here," he said, "throw another load of steel over my head—and you and I are going to tangle. One of us is going to the hospital. Understand?"

Herman never opened his mouth. It had some effect on him. For a few days he kept his loads in the clear, and then he began swinging them in close again. Not close enough so that Russ could get down to business and do something about it, but still close enough to make him uncomfortable. He spoke to Johnson about it.

"TI t'ot you tol him," said Johnson. "He tol me you was givin' him orders what to do. He don't need two bosses."

"I did tell him," said Russ. "Now I'm telling you. If he drops something—hits me—don't try to tell 'em up there it was an accident. See? Because Bennie, here, will be there to prove what I said. What I'm telling you now."

"What's a matta—" said Johnson, "you getting nervous or somethin'? For eight years he's been slinging steel ova guys hets. He's neva hit nobody yet."

"That's a great argument, Johnson."

"Well—it's an argument, ain't it?"

"The kind you'd put up. But you'll have to think of another. You'll have to talk to Herman, get him lined up. Or I'll get him lined up without talking."

They had no love for each other, them two. Johnson would have fired him in a minute if he thought that he could have got away with it. In the old days straw bosses fired men right and left, but Mr. Holt had put a stop to it. Besides, Russ had made himself pretty valuable and Johnson knew it, and he knew that some of the white-collars up front knew it, too. And it was no secret to Russ.

That night, after supper, Russ went out, and when he came back he had an outboard motor. It was a great bargain, he said. Only been run just a little. Two cylinders. A hundred and ten bucks is what he had to give for it and he paid forty dollars down.

He lugged it up into the room and began taking it apart. In a short time he had it spread all over the floor. He hadn't talked to me about clamming for a month and I was beginning to think that he had got the idea out of his system. Now he was all hepped up on it again.

"Now, all we need," he said, "is a boat. A boat and some sort of old jaloppie to get around in. And I've been thinkin'—if we had a trailer, we wouldn't need a tent."

"Love of Mike," I said, "let's not buy no more stuff till we get ready to start."

I was thinking of the fifty-five bucks—my share—I'd have to shell out for the outboard.

"What's the matter," he said, "you gettin' cold feet?"

"Why no, Russ, I'm not gettin' cold feet. Only thing is—we've got us a couple good jobs now. Things are going along nice; times are hard yet and there are a lot of fellows around on the streets looking for work. If they give you a raise, you might change your mind."

"Not me," he said. "Never."

"I've seen it happen—lotsa times. A fellow wants to earn a little money; wants to get himself set up in some little business or something; wants to buy a little garage, maybe, and doesn't have quite enough cash. Goes in and gets himself a job on the line. He's only gonna work just a coupla months—half a year, maybe. Then he's gonna pull out and go in for himself. What happens? He gets a raise and forgets all about the garage. I've seen it happen. Not once—lotsa times. He likes it after he's been there a while."

"That's where you're wrong," he said. "He doesn't like it. He gets married, maybe, or his wife gets a kid. He's afraid they'll starve if he misses a pay check—afraid the loan sharks will get his car—afraid he might not make a go of the garage. He loses his nerve and fear keeps his nose to the grindstone. It's bad, but he gets used to it. Everybody else is in the same fix and pretty soon he gets to thinking, 'there's nothing funny about me—nothing unusual. It's just life. Life as she's lived.' And he's right. It is life—in Detroit."

"But we can't pull out till warm weather."

"That's right. We'll put in the winter and the spring in the factory. Save our money. About June we'll start. In June the black bass will be biting."

"Yeh?"

"And I know a place where there're mushrooms the shape of strawberries and as big as your fist."

"But the nights. What are we gonna do in the long nights?"

"At night we'll sit around the fire and light up our pipes. I know some stories I learned in the woods—about a fellow by the name of Paul Bunyan. Couldn't tell them here; here they'd sound like a pack of plain lies. The surroundings have to be right. There has to be the smell of wood smoke in the air; the sound of crickets; or way off—a coyote. A bucket of spring water at your elbow. I'd show you how to pick out some tunes on the guitar and after you'd learned to play we'd get in the boat and drift out onto the river and we'd have us some music. The air would be still and

the water smooth as a table and sky soft as blue velvet. It wouldn't be grand opera, maybe, but it would be fun. And being on the water, it'd sound twice as good as it really was. How'd you like that?"

"Dog-gone it, Russ, when you get to talking like that —"

"Makes you feel like you're rarin' to go, don't it? I know, Bennie. I'm the same way when the air is warm and damp and soft in the spring and the geese are flying. Sometimes, in the morning, when the air is like that I can hardly make myself go back to the factory."

It was midnight and he had the motor together again and he wrapped it up in a piece of burlap and shoved it under the bed. We turned in. "Oh, well," I said to myself, "itll be six months till summer and a lot of things can happen in six months to make him change his mind. And if he doesn't, and Mr. Holt should decide to change models about that time and lay everybody off, it would be fun to get out in the sticks, for a while, lay around on the grass, go sputtering up and down a nice river, and every morning have frog-legs for breakfast. At the end of a couple of weeks I'd sell my interest in the outboard and go back to town."

# CHAPTER VI

WHEN WE GOT OFF THE STREET CAR THERE WAS A MOB AT NUMBER TWO GATE.

"Come on, Russ," I said; "let's get over there. Looks like a fight!"

I ran across the wide street. Whether Russ ran or not, I don't know. Maybe he got held up by the traffic. All I know is that I got over there, pushed my way through the crowd, and got into a fight so quick that I don't know yet how it happened. There was the lunch cart, and it was Rita's and she stood on a box behind the cart, and a little runt of a wop was shaking his fist and calling her names in bad sounding Italian. She called him a liar in plain English, and one or two other things besides, and he came for her in the face of a barrage of ripe bananas and candy bars, and jumped up on the edge of the cart like a monkey. I grabbed him. Right away some big guy in the crowd yelled out, "Back up! Make room—they're gonna fight. The little guy's gonna clean up on the Eye-talyan!"

"Dee-sa guy? Dee-sa guy gonna fight me? Me—Tony?" said the Italian. "I keel ——"

Before I could argue the point somebody gave me a push and the Italian lit into me. I squared off and landed one alongside his head. He backed off and came at me—drove his head into the pit of my stomach. Before I got straightened up he was at me again. This time he missed. I swung, but he wasn't there. He was like a rooster; he didn't know how to fight. He jumped in and out and kept dodging around like a wild man. We clinched and I slugged him two on the nose, but not hard—not hard enough. I needed more room—room to swing—to get in some good licks with steam behind them. We pulled away and he landed a kick on my shin that hurt—I mean really hurt. He landed a wallop on the side of my jaw. I was getting the worst of it by a lot. I was taking more than I was handing out. One hit me square in the eye and the fellows let out a roar. That got me mad and I came for him, fanning the breeze with my fists. He came in again like a goat. I swung and just scraped his ear. Again we clinched—milling around and around—trying to get at each other. I remembered that kick; watched his foot; but now he was clawing at me, digging his nails into my neck. Trying, for all I knew, to bite off my ear. Teeth clinched, he hissed like a leaky air hose.

He tried to kick me again and I tripped him up and we went down together, kicking and biting and scratching. I was on top but he was too slick. I couldn't hold him. Then he was on top, pounding my face and my shoulders. I flipped over, got my face down. He had me but I had my face to the ground.

In that split part of a second, when I flipped around, I saw the legs of the fellows—millions of legs, all around me—legs like a forest; and I wondered if Russ was there. I remember thinking—if he's there, why doesn't he do something? Why doesn't he help me? Why doesn't he pull this wop off? And then I thought—what if he's not there? And I got a sick feeling in the pit of my stomach. Oh Lordy, I thought, what if he's not there to help me out of this mess.

The wop was still on me, trying to get at my face. But I hardly noticed the blows—I was numb, but my brain was still clear. And then, in a flash, my whole life came up before me; things that Mr. Holt is against, that he writes about in his book: fooling around with women—labor unions—gambling with wages—drinking and smoking cigarettes in toilets. I thought of his book and the golden text popped into my head: "Work hard and behave yourself." And here I was in a fight—and getting the worst of it—might even get killed. "Oh, Mr. Holt—" I dug the words out of myself— "Please get me out of this mess. Amen."

Some one reached over and took the wop by the seat of the pants and lifted him up as though he had been a sack of potatoes. It was Russ. I got up. Russ had the wop by the collar.

"What's the matter," he said to the wop, "can't you fight fair?"

"I no wanna fight; hee's a wanna fight me. I wanna fight joost mine own—a familee—joost me an' she—joosta leetle fight. Me, I'm too old makka fight eferybod-dee."

"It look to me," said Russ, "as though you were just going to pull a knife."

"Non—non —"

"Let's see 'f you got one."

He reached into the wop's pocket and pulled out a jack-knife.

"There you are," said Russ, snapping the blade open. "A regular toad-stabber of a thing. What do you carry a thing like that for? Look at the size of that blade."

A couple of cops bulled their way through.

"What's going on here?" they asked.

"This little Dago, here," said Russ, "got into a scrap. I took his knife."

"Did he pull it?"

The little wop jabbered a streak.

"I tell-a you I no wanna fight. Dees-a guy wanna fight. Me—I'm too old. Joost-a mine own familee —

"Shut up," said the cop.

The girl pushed her way through.

"He's my father," she said. "He tried to slap me. But it doesn't matter. Please let him go."

That reminded the wop of the first argument, and he got riled again and began edging off towards the girl.

"She's-a no gudde," he said. "She's-a alla time crazy for man. De whole night she's texi-dencing —texi-dencing—texi-dencing. I say—no; she say yes. She go joosta same I say notting. She's-a no gudde I tella you. She's —"

"Aw shut up," said the cops. "What we want to know—" they asked Russ, "did he pull this knife. If he did he goes in."

"Don't ask me," said Russ. "Ask her. Looks like this was just a friendly little family affair. I'm out of it."

They looked at her.

"No—he didn't," she said. "He didn't even have it open. Some smart guy—standing here in the crowd took it out of his pocket."

"All right—" said the cops. "Scatter. All you guys scatter. Get outa here!"

Nearly all the fellows beat it. Russ and I stood there a minute.

The old man's hat lay on the ground. The girl picked it up and put it back on his head. She brushed the dirt from his clothes; took the knife from the cops and put it back in his pocket.

"Musn't lose your temper like that, Pa," she said to him. "It's bad. Besides, if the H.P.'s see you —you'll lose your job." The H.P.'s were the Holt Police.

She took a box lunch from the cart and gave it to him. "Better hurry," she said, "you'll be late."

Russ and I walked off together.

"Looks like you jumped into something with both feet," he said to me. "What was the idea?"

"How did I know it was a family affair? It looked like he was going to climb over the cart, pull out her hair."

"And you were gonna rescue the poor maiden and live happily ever after ——"

"Where was you?" I asked him. "Why didn't you do something when you saw he was beating me up?"

"You quit," he said. "You didn't try. You could have handled him—easy. If that gang had been a bunch of lumber-jacks you would have got the pants razzed off of you."

He was always dragging the lumber-jacks into his arguments.

"The wop had me pinned. He was pounding the tar outa me."

"So I noticed. Why didn't you pound the tar outa him? You stuck your nose into it. It was your fight."

It was late.

"You can't go in," he said. "Your eye's a mess. Better go home and put a piece of raw beef on it."

He went in and I turned to cross the wide street. A black river of men, the graveyard shift, streamed out of the factory and across the wide, overhead pass. Below, the street was all clear. A

Holt truck with a string of soup carts came rattling down the wide concrete; stopped, hooked the girl's cart on behind, and went on. On the other side of the fence the factory was running full blast. Locomotives ran back and forth over acres of tracks; a steel car full of white hot coals from the coke ovens ran into the quenching tower and as the cold water let go, a white cloud rose up into the gray Michigan sky. The Cooper-Hewitts were burning and the factory looked like a monster with a million green eyes. A piece of paper from somebody's lunch blew down the street in a little flurry of coal dust and cinders and caught against the steel fence.

The girl stood with her back braced against the cold wind off the lake, waiting for a bus. She had on brown slacks and a black coat and a boy's cap and the wind blew her bobbed hair past her eyes. I thought of some lines I'd once heard a long-haired fellow with a banjo recite to the crowd one night near the gates:

*When the last moonshiner buys his radio,*
*And the last wild rabbit of a girl,*
*Is civilized by a mail-order dress —*

That's all I remembered.

"It's you," she said when I came up. "Where are you going with that black eye?"

"Home," I said.

Whenever I get around a good-looking woman I get to acting as if I was feeling sad about something. I can't help it. With Russ it's just the opposite. He can always think of a wise-crack to make and he acts as though every dame owed him a compliment for his good looks.

"You should have stayed out of it," she said.

"How did I know it was just a friendly little squabble?" I said. "I thought he was going to tear you apart. You don't look sorry exactly."

"What do you expect me to do?" she said. "Hold your head in my lap and bathe your brow?"

"I'll bet you enjoyed seeing him get the best of me."

"Well, there's the Rettinelli reputation, you know. Us Rettinellis are all fighters, quick-tempered. And after all, he's my father, and you didn't put up much of a fight. What did you expect me to do—cheer for you?"

"I didn't start in to lick him," I said. "He was mad —"

"And you were scared. I've got a kid brother at home I'll bet could lick you."

"I'm not a fighter," I said.

"I don't think so, either, and I'm sorry you got into it. I really am, because you didn't have it coming. Where's your boy friend?" she asked.

"In there."

"Where does he work?"

"In the drop forge."

"I'll bet he's a straw boss, or something. I'll bet he draws down big wages?"

"I get the same as he does. We work together. What do you care where he works, what he gets? What's he got that I haven't?"

"Put it the other way around," she said. "It wouldn't take so long to answer." -

"What have I got, then, that he hasn't?"

"Well—a black eye. And it's getting worse. Better go home and do something about it."

"I can tell you one thing," he said. "In case you don't remember what he did with your card —"

"What?"

"He's not interested in skirts."

"That's what you think. I'll bet you're spoofing me—about where he works."

"I'm not. He works in the drop forge department. He runs a big machine there; handles big pieces of red-hot steel. I'm his helper."

"One of these days I'm going through the place—find out for myself. See if you're telling the truth."

"You'd have a sweet chance," I said, "getting past the guards."

"Not like this," she said, meaning her slacks. "I'd put on a dress, wear a hat. I'd get a ticket, make believe I'm a visitor from out of town. I'd go through with the crowd."

"You wouldn't have to do that," I said. "Not a good-looker like you. You could tell 'em you were a movie star—Greta Garbo. They'd give you a special guide—maybe two, let you go through in style."

Her bus slowed up to the curb.

"Maybe I will," she said, swinging on like a kid. "Tell your boy friend to be on the look."

"She's-a all time craz-zy for man," her Old Man had said. He had her figured out to a T—I could see that plain as day.

# CHAPTER VII

A couple of days later Johnson lined out a job for us that looked tough right from the start. It was a piece of steel half as big as a Holt car and marked "experimental." It was a die job and was the lower block of a set of dies that together would weigh thirty tons. They were to be used for stamping out from a single piece of metal the whole top and a part of the sides of the two-door car body.

Getting it into the furnace was a job for both rigs. Easing it off the floor Herman helped and took most of the strain; Russ steadied. The eight steel lines coming down from the drums on Herman's rig were as stiff as iron rods with the tension. Herman had most of the load; Russ had the responsibility. Herman could raise and lower and move the load in four different directions; Russ had control over every motion that a man has in his shoulder, elbow and wrist. It was nice team-work. Smooth and steady the load was raised from the floor and moved up the bay to number one furnace. And then came the ticklish job of getting the steel through the door without wrecking the furnace. Herman got into position—cut off his power, and went dead. "All yours," Johnson signalled to Russ. He eased her in, his hands stroking the levers. Herman still had a dead-gravity load. Russ pushed her gently, easing her in; there wasn't one inch to spare. The front end of the steel touched the floor of the furnace. Herman dropped off and Russ gave her a clean push through the door. He pulled out.

It was nice work, but the hard part—the work under the hammer—was still to come. Johnson spoke to Russ. "Betta check your rig over, right afta dinner. I want everything to go extra smooth —see? Once I sta't flat-tennin' her out you'll never get her back through that door. We gotta do it all in one heat and there's plenty of forge work on that baby before she sta'ts freezing."

Anything that wasn't red hot to Johnson was cold. A piece of steel that didn't lick the grease off the floor wasn't even warm to the touch.

"I never let a job down yet," said Russ. "Guess I won't this one. Better talk to Herman."

"Herman's doing all right, ain't he?"

"So far," said Russ.

All the forenoon the steel soaked in the furnace. It took up a lot of heat even before starting to turn red, and after that a lot more.

We had lunch and then Russ and I worked on the machine. I swiped while he oiled and checked over camshafts and gears. His big, gentle hands slid over the journals; the way he felt of the bearings was like a caress. "We'll sling her up there," he said. "We'll twist her tail any old way the Swede says. We'll make her behave."

I didn't say anything. He acted as if he was talking to me, but I knew he wasn't. Other things he said I couldn't hear, but I knew what they were—a lot of sweet jabberings that a man usually don't say to nobody except his sweetheart or wife.

About two-thirty Johnson said he was ready. We took the hooks off Herman's crane and rigged on a sling. The big hammer was cut in on the high pressure steam and began warming up. Johnson cleared space for action and gave Russ right-of-way on the floor. Russ put on his green goggles, sloshed water on the front of his shirt, and climbed up on the rig. We were ready to start.

A cold piece of steel is one thing; a hot piece of steel is something else. Cold steel is like a wild animal that is dead; hot steel is like one that is alive and dangerous—there is energy in it. Energy to make the breath stick in your throat—to scorch the inside of your lungs if you breathe through your mouth—to lick the grease and chips off the floor and to send you to the hospital if you get close. Yet you have to work close or you lose control.

Russ dragged the steel halfway out of the furnace and clasped on. We wrapped the sling around and even with long irons the job was too hot to be fun. Herman picked up his share of the load and they swung her across the floor to the hammer. A minute later they had her up on the iron and the anvil took Herman's load. Russ had it all.

Johnson's signals were fast: "Left turn—a little—lower the front end a hair—a bit more—too much—o-keh—hold her."

The hammer rapped out ten or fifteen blows. Fire sprayed; the ground trembled and an empty milk bottle that someone had left on a switch-box crashed to the floor. One end, the upper side, was beveled off, fairly smooth.

A new position. "Shove her up," Johnson signalled. Herman picked up the load for a minute; Russ pushed her over; once again there were signals. Russ's eyes were on Johnson; his hands on the levers was a sight that was beautiful to see. His shirt was steaming and the red light from the steel was on his face.

Once more the hammer—the upper right side was beveled. Once more a quick change; the hammer again—the left side was finished. And then Johnson signalled: "Pull her off—reverse end positions."

"Judast priest," I said, "that's gonna make the job tough."

A string of visitors came in and lined up to watch. The guide started his spiel and began telling the crowd all about steel, the number of kinds used in making a car, the cost of the rig. Every week

it went up a thousand dollars or more.

We lowered off to the floor, switched ends and shifted Herman's rigging while Johnson snapped some measurements with long-handled calipers and the scalers cleaned off the anvil.

"Pick her up!" Johnson signalled. And it was then Herman started his monkey business. He lit into his load with a snap. Russ lost his bite and was helpless.

"What's a madda!" Johnson bellered. "Can't you fellas come up togedda? Take it easy!"

Herman couldn't have heard what he said. Russ kept his mouth shut and worked out a new hold. The job was harder for him, now; he had the end that was beveled. There were no corners—no rough surfaces to bite into.

"Easy now," Johnson signaled. "Bring her up —"

This time they got her off the floor—were starting to raise her—when Herman jerked. Once more Russ lost his hold. He was beginning to get sore. He motioned for Johnson to come up but Johnson ignored him.

"Get it up there!" he signalled. "Stop horsin' around—she's gettin' cold!" That time they both jerked. She slipped clean out of Herman's sling and rolled to the floor.

Johnson was burnt up. Russ slid down the ladder and went up to him.

"Pull him off," he said. "Give me the floor. I can't work with that fellow—he's trying to queer me."

"You're crazy," said Johnson. "You can't handle 'er."

"I'll handle her," said Russ. "Get him out-a here. I'll shorten my boom—get leverage."

"And burn yourself up."

"What-a you care? We're losing our heat. She's getting cold."

"O-keh," said Johnson. "She's yours—you asked for it."

He waved Herman off the floor.

Russ passed me.

"Keep everybody off the track behind me," he snapped. "I'm gonna move—shoot in and grab—back out for air. Throw me a spray when I come past." He swung up.

There was action without waiting for signals from Johnson. Russ shortened his boom a full quarter. The steel lay on its side. He bit into it—slammed it over—backed away—came from another angle and turned it again. He was after a good hold and got it. He shortened the boom another foot. He could have spit on the steel.

"What's 'e tryin' to do," said Johnson, "get 'er up in his lap?"

Russ began raising the load. Slowly, it came up from the floor. There was no singing of gears—no easy purring of motors. The gears growled; the motors groaned with resentment. Circuit breakers popped out with the sound of explosions and were sent back with a flash. Switches snapped and gave off little corkscrews of blue smoke. The machine responded against a gigantic re-

sistance but you felt that it was not the electrical current that turned the wheels and raised the steel—it was the strength, the speed, and the expert control of those powerful hands on the levers.

He got it up on the anvil and the fancy work started. Johnson stepped in again and for once his signals were clear. There was no sling to worry about now—no clumsy helper. Russ crouched low behind the controls. The heat must have been something fierce, and when the heavy blows fell he was in the red rain of hot iron.

The guide stood in line with his gang—forgot his spiel and looked on. The scalers, better able to appreciate what they saw, stopped work and rubbered as hard as the others. Three times he got the steel in position; three times the hammer battered and pounded. Then he balanced the steel on the anvil, unclamped, and shot back for a breath of cool air.

The paint on the forward end of the machine was beginning to blister. The oil on the open gears smoked and the steel ladder was hot to the touch. I handed him a clean pair of goggles and one of the scalers threw up some gloves.

"It won't get you nowhere," I hollered, "if you burn yourself up."

"Don't worry," he said. "This time we'll finish her off."

He rolled in again. Johnson signalled. There was a high spot near the center to work down.

This time it was even more difficult to hold. It was beveled all the way around. He got it, but the first light blow of the hammer loosened it up. It was a struggle again to get the right hold and all the time the steel was up there on the anvil. He turned and tilted and once or twice it threatened to get away and slide to the floor. But he got it, and the hammer did its last work.

"O-keh—" Johnson signaled. "All done."

The crowd broke out and applauded. Some high school kids in the bunch let out a football yell.

Russ backed away and climbed down. He was wiping his face with a towel when Rita, the girl, stepped out from the crowd and came up. This time she was dressed like a lady. No slacks, no cap pulled down over one ear, but street clothes like the others. You couldn't have told her from one of the girls in the high school bunch except that she had them all beat for looks.

"Gee—" she said, "you were swell."

"Did you like it?" he asked.

"I sure did," she said. "The way you handled those levers—made the machine do what you wanted-. If you hadn't won I would have felt terrible. It was like watching a fight. I got a thrill."

"I thought you would," he kidded. "I put in a few extra frills for your special benefit—just to make it ood."

"Really? Did you know I was there?"

"Oh, sure. I could tell by the static."

She gave him a questioning look. The fellows began noticing that Russ was talking to a good-looking dame. She wore a straw hat that sat on the back of her head and when she looked up at

him it framed her face like a picture. Not many of the fellows there realized that she was the same girl who dressed in boy's overalls or slacks and sold box-lunches outside the gate. The guide had started and the crowd straggled out loosely behind.

"It's against the rules for visitors to kid us workers during hours," said Russ. "If you wanna talk to us you'll have to get a permit from Old Sourpuss, the boss."

"How's that?"

"Safety engineers don't allow it—been too many accidents."

"Why's that? Tell me about it."

"Well, a gal in a sun-suit came through one time and started talking to Bennie, here, and he near lost an eye. He came pretty near getting compensation out of it."

"I should think he would have," she said. "I should think it would be compensation enough just to have gotten a smile, if she was pretty."

"Oh, she was pretty," said Russ. "But good looks and nice shapes don't mean nothing to us. When we talk about compensations we mean dough—real dough, and nothing else but."

"How about the workers kidding the visitors?" she asked.

"Oh, that's all right—after hours."

"Well," she said, "after hours I'm still working in that taxi-dance place."

"And after hours," he said, "I still don't like to climb stairs."

The guide was a block down the aisle and she hurried along after the others.

"No soap, eh?" I said.

"No soap," he answered. "When I'm clamming I like to catch my own clams. I don't like to have 'em come up outa the water and start climbing in over the sides of the boat."

# CHAPTER VIII

One Saturday night, a week or two later, Russ and I were walking up Woodward Avenue, coming home from a movie. We stopped in a beer joint and took on a few beers and a little farther on up the street we came to a place where there was dancing upstairs. It was a taxi-dance place and there were pictures of girls in low-necked dresses behind a big window and a sign that read:

*One Hundred Beautiful Girls*
*A Dime a Dance.*

It was one of those places where the house furnished the girls and the girls and the house each get half of your dough.

"Let's see what it's like," said Russ. "I feel like dancing after those beers."

"Let's not," I said. "Let's get to bed. All they're after up there is your dough. It's a racket.' "

"It's only ten cents a dance."

"Dances only last two minutes. That's three bucks an hour—figure it out for yourself."

"Well—let's see what the women are like."

"What do you think they're like?" I asked.

"All virgins," he said with a laugh.

He had his mind made up and we climbed the stairs. We checked our hats and coats and he laid out a buck for a string of ten tickets. I didn't buy any.

"What's the idea?" he said.

"Go ahead and dance," I said. "I'll sit and watch. I can think of other ways for getting rid of my money."

We walked out to the edge of the floor and looked over the lay-out. Thirty or forty couples were dancing; a bunch of fellows sat near the wall on chairs and sofas and about twenty girls stood along a white line on the floor waiting for partners. Some of them shook their hips in time with

the music; some swayed and shimmied and a couple of them gave us a "I'll-give-you-a-good-time-honey" look. Russ picked out a tall blond and they . waltzed out onto the floor.

It was warm in the building; the pink lights were low so that you couldn't see the wrinkles on some of the old biddies that were no longer spring chickens and the whole place had a smell like a gents' barber shop in the colored district. The players were dressed like waiters; the girls wore evening gowns that came to the floor, while the men who'd come to dance were in street clothes.

While sitting there, who should I see but Rita, dancing with a dark-skinned little fellow about twice her own age. She saw me and came in off the floor, sort of trailing the little gent behind her like an old Holt car with the rear axle gone. She introduced us and his name was Louie and I could see in a minute that he wasn't interested in anything very much except her. She asked about Russ in an indirect sort of way, wanting to know whether I'd come up alone, and she was still chewing the rag—marking time—when Russ also came in off the floor; parked the blond, and came over. He got down to business at once and asked her to dance.

"I'm verr sor-r-rie," said Louie. "Is tree more tickets I got. Dees lady she is dance with me."

"I'm asking the lady," said Russ. "I'm up here on her invitation. I think I'll dance with her now."

The musicians were playing. Russ took her hand.

"I'm verr sor-rie—" said Louie, "dees lady is mine. Is tree more ticket —"

Russ ignored him. "Come on, baby—" he said to Rita, "Jet's you and me dance. Never mind him."

She jerked her hand out of his and stood rigid.

"I'm sorry," she said, "you'll have to wait your turn."

"It's my turn now," he said. "He's had his."

"He asked me first. As long as his tickets hold out ——"

"Holy Mackinaw," he said. "I've got tickets, if that's what you want."

The wop took her arm. He tried to lead her away. Russ held her. Put his arm around her waist.

"Come on," he said. "Cut out the foolishness—. dance!"

She leaned back and slapped him a hard one alongside the face. Her eyes blazed like a cat's.

"Just because you've blowed yourself for a few tickets," she said, "don't get the idea you own me. I'm a taxi-dancer but that doesn't mean I'm your slave. You can wait for me or go home. A little rest might do you good—after climbing those stairs." She went off with Louie.

"The little hell-cat," said Russ. "I could break a box-car in two."

"Now, if you know your women," I said, "you'll get your hat and coat and we'll get outa here. Hang around here and wait until she gets good and ready to give you a dance—you're a sap. Let's beat it."

"Beat it nothing," he said. "I'm onto their racket, now. I'm going to get her away from that wop and when I do—she's gonna dance with me till they turn the lights out. I'm gonna get me a

string of tickets a yard long." And he did. He got five dollars worth.

And then he waited until this guy Louie had danced out his three tickets and he grabbed her before the wop could go to the window and plank down his money for more.

I watched them dance for a while. Russ was no slouch—he moved easily and carried himself well on the floor—but she was better. She was streamlined in a dress of black stuff like velvet that came low on her back and shoulders and was tight at the hips and made her look like a mermaid. She wore long earrings that sparkled like diamonds; small slippers the color of silver, and a sparkling thing on the side of her hair that shimmered like the top-notch on the head of a peacock.

At first they were sort of stand-offish and cold and danced like a couple of high school kids under the eyes of their mothers. After the third or fourth dance they had made up and began kidding and talking and she showed him some new steps and after that she danced hot-cha and close. It was easy to see that she knew all the tricks that women practice and men fall for on the dance floor.

Poor Russ! I wouldn't have minded having had her myself for the night but Russ was the kind of fellow that was liable to take a dance like this serious. With a taxi-dancer it's one fellow tonight and another tomorrow—all they're after is a man's dough. But Russ had a kind of old-fashioned idea about women and any young girl, to him, was a starry-eyed virgin who reminded him of his old maid sister who was a county teacher and used to scold kids for writing four-letter words on the rear wall of the school.

There was an intermission and Russ and the girl came in off the floor and he bought a couple of cold drinks at the counter. The Italian went up to them and I guess he wanted the girl but Russ waved a fistful of tickets in the wop's face and sent him away. The music started again and they began dancing and it wasn't long after this guy Louie came up to me—bellyaching.

"Beeg fella—'e's you fran," he said.

"Yeh."

"You tell-a 'eem—leave-a my gurl lone."

"She works here—she's anybody's girl. That's the way I figure it."

"She's-a my gurl I tell-a you. She's-a not like dose oddas. She's E-tali-yan. Me—I'm E-tali-yan, too. You tell-a 'eem—that beeg-a fella—leave my gurl lone."

"Aw, climb a tree," I said. "I can't help you're both wops." With that I walked away. But he kept following me, kept hanging around, kept making me nervous. He was serious.

"Betta you tell 'eem," he said. "She's-a my gurl; he's-a you fran. You tell 'eem."

"Lay off me," I said. "Quit following me around. If there's anything you want told—tell it yourself."

"Non—non," he said. "Eez more betta you tell, 'E's you fran. Me—I mek-a 'eem mad. 'Ee's mek-a fight me."

I went to the opposite end of the room where they served the drinks; ordered a ginger ale and sat down at a small table. Before I'd finished, there he was again—right at me.

"I like-a," he said, "tell-a you sumpt'ing. 'Ee's you fran, eez not so? She's-a my gurl. Las' night I take-a she home. Las' night ——"

"Love of Mike," I said, "lay off of me. What do I care if you took her home? What do I care if you jump in the river? Lay off—can't you?"

I was fed up on him. I was fed up on a lot of things. I got my coat and hat and got out of the place as fast as I could.

Outside, it was snowing—fine, hard snow that filled the air like a dust storm. Traffic on Woodward Avenue had thinned out and was fast so that it was a wicked job getting across the wide street. Every car raked up a little blizzard of white, powdery dust as it passed. Half ; the street lights were turned off for the night, and in the dark of the alleys behind the stores, men with flashlights, and coat-collars turned up, were raiding the cans. Some carried sticks with which to beat off the rats that had got so bold during the hard times that they stood up on their hind legs and fought for choice bits of garbage. In a vacant lot filled with left-over Christmas trees some bums had a fire and a place to sleep and were arguing with a couple of cops who wanted to take the bums in.

"We're working," said one of the bums. "You can't take us in. We got all dees trees to sell yet."

They had a rough sign up that read:

*Bargains in Christmas Trees*
*Big Sale.*

"What are you tryin' to give us?" said one of the cops. "Christmas was two weeks ago. You can't sell these trees."

"Oh, yeah? We're runnin' a sale on 'em. See? We got de price so low dey can't help but sell. I'm tellin' ya, officer, yer losin' money, if yer don't take one home for de kids."

"Aw—cut it out. You fellows just squatted here. You're just trying to get away with something —that's what you're doing. You know it."

"Naw—honest to gosh, officers. We're doin' business. Look at dis fine tree. Ain't it a beauty? Was a dollar; I'll letcher have it for a dime—cash and carry. I'll even put it in de car for you."

They were still arguing when I left. I couldn't stand there all night, waiting to see how it would end up.

For no reason that I can remember I walked past the library, a white building set well back from the street, surrounded by high elms. "Trees in captivity," Russ had called them once, when he had first come to Detroit. He used to walk out in the evening to see them when there was a fog or a mist, or a fine rain was falling, because then the branches made a soft pattern in the gray light from the high lamps.

I bought a Sunday paper and went up to the room and lay on the bed, trying to read, waiting for Russ to come in. In the magazine section of the paper there was a piece about a song called:

"Oh Gloomy Sunday." The police in some country in Europe were trying to suppress it. The first lines went:

*Oh gloomy Sunday—I waited, my dear—*
*My arms full of flowers—for you to appear.*
*With prayers on my lips, my heart full of dreams;*
*I waited alone and in vain it now seems.*

There was no heat in the room and it was cold and I threw the paper down to the floor and lay a long time thinking about Russ and the girl and the little Italian and the job that I had in the factory. Sometimes a big city like Detroit is a terrible place and it comes to you, all of a sudden, that the only thing that stands between you and the cold and an empty belly is your little, thin hold on a job that you've got no control over and that's liable to be somebody else's any morning when you come to the factory; look for your card in the rack and find it's not there. Nobody has to tell you that it's up on the superintendent's desk—punched out for good. Times when I get to feeling like that I pull the blankets up over my head and get to trembling all over. Times like that, even though I'm a-scared of the city, I want to get down into it even closer. I want to become a part of the noise and the speed and the racket so that I can't think—can't remember.

When I woke up in the morning Russ was not there. His bed was made up the way the landlady had left it Saturday. He hadn't slept in it all night.

# CHAPTER IX

It was late Sunday afternoon when he got back to the room, and because I made a crack he didn't like about the girl, he blew up and for a month we were like strangers. Not mad at each other, exactly, but at the same time, not friendly. We worked together and talked to each other when we had to, but he went his way and I went mine and neither of us ever so much as mentioned the girl to the other. At night, after work, he'd take a bath and change his clothes and leave the house without telling me where he was going; I wouldn't ask—I wouldn't have to. And then when he had gone the room would seem lonely and empty and I wouldn't know what to do with myself to kill time. I'd go out and walk up and down Hastings street and talk with the niggers; maybe I'd shoot a game of pool at Jim's Place or go to a movie. Doing those things with him would have been fun but doing them alone—I was bored stiff most of the time. Every time I thought about the girl and how she's roped him in I got sore.

Sometimes when the weather was too dirty to go out I stayed up in the room and read Mr. Holt's book. For the first time I began making a real study of it—going through it systematic—learning whole paragraphs by heart. I made neat copies of some of the verses and stuck them up on the walls on my side of the room. One of Mr. Holt's favorite mottos I pasted onto the edge of the mirror. It read:

Machinery—the new Messiah.

The next morning when I was pulling on my shirt and Russ was combing his hair he saw it there and let out a snort that fairly raised the dust from the floor.

"If you have to stick that sort of thing up here in the room," he said, "put it where I don't have to look at it. It's bad enough up there on the wall without having it here where I have to see it right under my nose every time I use the mirror to comb my hair."

It had a good effect. It broke down the tension between us and started him talking.

He'd got into the habit of taking the street car to the factory while I'd made it a practice to walk. That morning, after we'd had breakfast, he walked to the factory with me.

"Bennie," he said, after we'd got a little way from the house, "I've got to marry the girl."

"Already?" I said.

"Already."

"Well," I said, "there're ways of fixing those things. It's easy enough to get the name of some doc —"

"It's not what you think," he said. "It's not that."

"Then what is it?" I asked. "Has the Old Man got a shotgun?"

"No. It's just that I had her figured out wrong. I thought she was a tough little taxi-dancer—ran around with all sorts of men. That dancing dress she had on made her look grown-up and able to take care of herself. And she wasn't. She's only seventeen—just a kid. And she was innocent."

"A hard-boiled virgin, eh, Russ? And you took ad —"

"Be careful," he said. "I'm talking to you as a friend. She's not hard-boiled. That's only put on to stand off the tough guys that she danced with, that bought lunches."

"She was after you from the start. That first day—she started angling for you."

"I was after her, too, when I found out that she wasn't what I first thought she was."

"That makes it unanimous," I said.

"It does."

"Well—it's your funeral," I said. "Not mine. Does she still work in that taxi-dance place?"

"I asked her to quit."

"And she did?"

"Sure."

"And you'll give up the idea of clamming?" I said. "Settle down in the shop?"

"No. She's going with me," he said. "We've talked it over. She thinks the idea is swell but says we oughta get us a trailer to live in."

"Just wait," I said. "After the honeymoon is over she'll forget about the birds and the flowers—she'll want to get back to the bright lights of Woodward Avenue. She's like me—brought up among the sights and smells of the back streets of Detroit."

"You've got her wrong, Bennie," he said. "She's the real McCoy. And another thing, Bennie—the proposition that I made you about going fifty-fifty still holds. I want you to go."

"No sale."

"But I want you to—she does."

"Count me out," I said. "I'm not in the mood—even for talking about it."

We walked along for a block or so, neither one of us saying nothing. Then he spoke again.

"I wouldn't be surprised," he said, "if I got into an argument this morning with Johnson."

"You mean," I said, "you're gonna ask for a raise?"

"That's it. Exactly."

"When?"

"When we get to the factory."

"But listen—" I said. "There's a heavy schedule lined u "

"So much the better."

"You'll get them mad."

"Let 'em get mad—just so I get the raise. There's a lot of work ahead of us this morning. I'll get the raise or walk out. And what's more—I'll try to work it so you get one, too."

"Forget about me," I said. "All I'm worrying about now, is hanging onto my job. It's the middle of winter. Jobs are scarcer than hen's teeth and there's a big gang outside that narrow gate waiting to step into my place."

"Don't worry," he said. "The time's right—a lot of work ahead; not another man in the factory can step up on that rig and run it. If Johnson tries it—it's gonna be just too bad. I've got it fixed so he'll get into plenty of trouble. If I go out, don't you try it. The static off one of those levers will raise the hat off your head."

We walked into the factory together; punched our cards and the bell rang and Johnson came up with a fistful of rush orders.

"Right avay first," he said, "we'll do some loadin'. Get number one ready ——"

"Before I start," said Russ, calm and lazy-like, "I'd like a raise."

"Got no time to talk about raises, now," said Johnson. "We're busier than a cat doing a chob on a tin roof."

"I got time," said Russ. "Lotsa time. I've been here more than six months—still getting five bucks. I want six-eighty. I came here because I heard Mr. Holt was paying high wages. Now I'm gonna find out if it's so."

"What's-a matta," said Johnson, "tryin' to go on a strike? Trying to hol' up the work?"

"I'm not trying to hold up the work," said Russ. "I'm just trying to make it plain that I'd like a raise. That I'd like to get six-eighty instead of five bucks."

"Then you'd betta get up on your rig. I'll talk to Riley when the time comes and see what 'e says. In a couple-a weeks I'll letcha know."

"You don't get the point, Johnson. I want the raise now—not a couple of weeks from today. The idea is that I get the raise or I don't —"

"Listen—" said Johnson, "don't say it! Right now raises ain't going true. I could put in for you —but I'm tellin'n ya—it wouldn't be no good. We're layin' off fellas now. We're lettin' 'em go every day, 'stead of handin' out raises. Times is harder'n 'ell yet and fellas on production is only workin' tree-four days a week. You're working five. What you bellyachin' about?"

"I've thought about all those things," said Russ. "Do I get the raise—or don't I? If not—I'm ready to turn in my badge."

"Holy smokes," said Johnson, "I can't getcha no raise—the way yer're going at it! You can't bulldoze the Holt Motor Company! There's regular ways for doing dose t'ings. I gotta put in for

you and wait to see what dey say. Maybe it goes true—maybe it don't. See? You ain't big enough to lay down the law to the Holt Motor Company and get away with it. See?"

"Yeh, I see. But I am big enough to tell the Holt Motor Company to stick their job up if I have to work for five bucks a day. I'm just trying to make it plain that I don't pull a lever on that rig until I get six-eighty."

Johnson was in a tight spot. Three furnaces were full of ripe steel. There were a whole mess of orders ahead. And not another man in the shop—not Johnson himself—had brains enough to climb up on the manipulator and run it. Yet he didn't want to give the raise under pressure.

"Listen," said Johnson, "let's you'n me cut out this arguin' togedda. If I had my way I'd get you a raise—it's no money out of my pocket. If I had it to say I'd get you a raise every week. But you can see how it is. You can see how it would look to Riley if I got you a raise and not de oddas. He'd t'ink we was buddies. You know what 'e'll say to me—doncha? 'E'll say 'what's-a matta, Johnson, you and that fella buddies togedda? You roomin' togedda, or sumpt'ing?' See? An' 'e'll say, "Whyn't you get anodda fella for that job, Johnson? Whyn't you fire that long-legged, no-account sojer—get rid of 'im?' Tha's what 'e'll tell me. And you know what I'll hafta do, doncha? I'm gonna hafta fire you to make 'im t'ink we ain't chums; that it ain't sumpt'ing between us. That's what I'll hafta do—see?"

"Don't make me laugh," said Russ. "If I don't get the raise you won't have to fire me. I'll save you the trouble. And as for me being the only one—that reminds me. I want a raise for Bennie. He's been here as long as I have."

"Holy smokes, man! What's the matta with you? You talk crazy. You want everybody get fired? I can't do nothin' for you. See Riley."

"O-keh," said Russ, walking away. "But let me tell you—I'm not afraid to speak up. And if I tell Riley things you'd rather not have me say—don't say I went over your head."

"Wait," said Johnson, "I'll get 'im. You stay here. We'll have it out. If he wants to give you the raise—it's none of my business. But I'll hafta tell 'im you ain't been co-operatin'." Johnson left to get Riley.

"Well," I said, picking up the rags I'd been using to swipe with and putting them into the can, "might just as well start getting our tools together. In about ten minutes we'll be drawing our last pay."

"Leave it to me. If I go it doesn't mean you'll get fired."

"For the love of Mike," I said, "go easy. You can't get hard-boiled with Riley."

"I don't want to get hard-boiled with anybody. I'm just trying to make it plain that I get a raise or I don't work. I've got 'em over a barrel and I'm going to crack down on 'em. If they don't come across it's gonna cost them plenty of dough and they know it."

Johnson came back with Riley.

"What's the argument?" said Riley.

"No argument," said Russ. "I want a raise. I've been here more than six months. I know my job; I work hard; I don't back down when it comes to facing hot iron. During the last three months not a job has gone back to the fire for re-heat. Working hard; putting myself into it—not watching the clock. I figure I've helped the Company make a good deal of money. I figure I'm worth ten dollars a day. I'm not asking ten—I'm asking six-eighty."

"What about your helper?" asked Riley. "Six dollars o-keh?"

"You bet it is, sir," I said. "Six dollars is fine, sir. I would appreciate it." It was the first time I'd ever talked to Riley.

"Better let them have it," he said to Johnson. "They're in line for it." It was simple—like that.

A couple of weeks later, walking home from the factory, Russ told me the news. He'd got married. And not only that, but he and Rita had rented a house and on the way home nothing would do but what we had to get off the street car, walk three or four blocks, and have a look at it. Rita was there with her kid brother, painting some second-hand chairs, and when we came in she ran up to Russ with the brush in her hand and got yellow paint all over the back of his coat.

The house wasn't much. Not very big and there was a bulge in the floor so that two legs of the stove had to be propped up on one side to make it stand level, but there were electric lights and running water. There were only three rooms. Two bedrooms, one on each end, and a large room in between that would have to take the place of a dining room, living room, kitchen, and everything else. In this room there was a table, some half-painted chairs, a place to wash dishes and an old couch covered with bright new cloth. Rita was full of excitement. They were both happy as kids.

"Wait till I get the curtains up," she said. "You won't know the place. No house is a home without curtains—and yet if a man was doing it, that's the last thing he'd think about."

"Sure," said Russ, "a man would want to look out of the windows. Look at the view, Bennie."

I looked out of the back window and there behind the house, less than a stone's throw from the back door, was a small marsh with a few cat-tails; quantities of old automobile bodies; broken bathtubs; rusty boilers and broken pieces of concrete. On the opposite side there was a row of tar-paper shacks and in between there was such a mess of rubbish and junk that you could hardly see the mud and black water. In the broken-down fence there was an old willow with broken branches and scarred trunk that leaned towards the house as though trying to get away from the sights and the smells of the swamp.

"In the spring," said Russ, "we'll be able to shoot mud-hens from the back door."

"And every night," said Rita, "I'll have a bouquet of pussywillows on the table. The old tree looks dead—but it's not. There's life in it, Nito tells me." Nito was the kid brother who was supposed to be such a fighter.

"And did you notice?" she asked Russ. "There's a lilac bush near the front gate."

"I didn't," said Russ. "In fact, I hadn't noticed the gate. Unless —"

She laughed.

"I mean," she said, "where the gate would be if there was a gate."

"You mean if the kids hadn't taken the gate off the hinges and used it for a raft. I think I saw it stranded out there in the swamp. Oh well—the shack is only costing us twelve-fifty a month." They were gay about everything.

And all the time they were talking and planning I was thinking how gloomy it would be with no one to talk to at night—no one to argue with. And on Saturday nights, when I'd want to go out, I'd have to go all by myself. And not sharing the room with anyone else Mrs. Prouse, the landlady, would raise the rent on me, or else get in somebody I wouldn't like. Somebody, like as not, on the night shift, who'd come in and go out at the most ungodly hours, or sit up maybe half the night with the lights blazing just when I'd be trying to catch up on sleep.

Russ told her about us getting the raise and she gave him a hug and a kiss that would have made a bachelor like me happy for life.

"Now we'll be able to get the rug that I wanted," she said. "And the lamp-shade for Bennie."

"Hey! Hey!" he said. "You're spilling the beans."

"May as well tell," I said. "What is it?"

"Shall we?" she asked.

"Might as well," said Russ. "What's the diff?"

"Well," she said, "we've got a room fixed up for you. We thought maybe we could get you to move in with us. Be our star boarder."

"I couldn't think of it," I said. "You'll be honeymooning the first couple of years. I'd be always under your feet. Be getting in the way every time you'd want to look at the moon or see the sun set."

"Yeh," said Russ. "That would be bad. Those sunsets over that row of old shacks must be pretty swell. But kidding aside, Bennie—we mean it. Two reasons we'd like to have you stay here. One, it'd be lonesome without you, and another—we need your board money to help run the house on. However, we'd only charge you six a week instead of the seven you're paying old lady Prouse. Seven's too much. It's like Johnson says, "Times is harder'n 'ell yet.'"

"He hasn't seen the room yet," said Rita. "How do you know he'll like it?"

"I don't," said Russ. "If I knew he liked it I wouldn't be wasting all this salesmanship."

Rita opened a door and I saw the room. It was pretty small but had a window and a small heating stove. There were some yellow drapes in front of the window, a bed and a chair, and in one corner, behind a curtain that slid on a wire, a place to hang clothes. Near the bed was a waste-paper basket with some blue ribbon.

"It has the feminine touch," said Russ. "How do you like it?"

"Swell."

"It's all yours—on one condition."

"What's that?"

"That you stick a Holt motto over every one of those cracks in the wall."

"That's easy," I said. "I've got enough to cover the walls. When do I move in?"

"Saturday."

"And what about the outboard?" I asked. "Shall we turn it in on a new baby carriage?"

"Not by a long shot," he said. "The outboard comes here. It's all we've got. That and about ten dollars worth of used furniture."

"We've got to keep it," she said. "I'll want to say to Junior, when he gets big, 'Junior—all your father and I had when we got married, was an outboard.' "

I said, "Still got your mind set on clamming, eh Russ?"

"Why not? Getting married makes it all the more logical. Now we've got someone to do the cooking and keep house for us."

"We've talked it all over," said Rita. "He told me all about it—even before we were married. We're all going to sit around the fire after dark while you play the guitar." She danced across the floor, singing a tune —

*She shall have music,*
*Wherever she goes,*
*Rings on her fingers,*
*And bells on her toes.*

"From the dance hall," she said.

The kid had started a fire in the old stove. We stood around it.

"Listen," said Russ. "Where we going to stow the outboard?"

"Is it big?" she asked.

"About as big as a suitcase—a little longer, perhaps."

"There's a shed in the back," she said. "There's some wood in it. We could put it in there."

"Too risky," he said. "Some kid would kipe it. We'll have to stick it under the bed. Can't take no chances."

"Ts it smelly?"

"Not bad."

"But the dust. How will I be able to sweep under the bed?"

"Sweep around it," he said. "I'll pull it out once in awhile—help you."

It was beginning to get dark. Mrs. Prouse would be getting supper.

"I'll be going, now," I said. "Be seeing you later."

"Tell the Old Girl," said Russ, "that I'm eating out. I'll be in after while."

"Nito," said Rita, "you run along, too. Tell Ma I'll be home after supper."

When I left they were standing on the rickety porch with their arms around each other. They looked and acted mighty affectionate, but they were still talking about where to put the outboard. She said something about getting a lock for the shed; he still insisted on putting it under the bed. Well, all I've got to say is that if I ever get married—which I wouldn't be surprised that I would, now that I'm making six bucks a day—I'll be blamed if I'll have any smelly gas motors under the bed until the honeymoon is old stuff. Over at the house the thing stunk up the whole room.

# CHAPTER X

Living together in the little old house we got along fine. Once in a while the three of us would take in a movie, or Russ and I would shoot a few games of pool, but for the most part we worked hard, stayed home, and sat around the fire and talked shop. There was no tearing around—no taxi-dancing and no hanging around beer joints at night. Sometimes after supper we'd sit around the table and play cards and maybe Russ or I would tell Rita about something that had happened in the factory that day. Sometimes, before washing the dishes, even, she'd go over and sit on his lap and start fooling around with his shirt collar or rub his whiskers with the back of her hand. I could see how it was.

"Well—" I'd say, getting up and stretching my arms, "I guess I'll go into my room. I've gotta write a fellow a letter tonight about a dog."

Sometimes I'd get on my hat and go out to Jim's Place and talk to the fellows awhile, or maybe just hang around there and do nothing. Getting home the house would be dark and the dirty dishes still on the table. I'd go to bed and then maybe two-three o'clock in the morning I'd hear them kidding and laughing out there in the room like a couple of kids. They'd fry some eggs, or cook some spaghetti maybe; wash the dishes and then turn around and go back to bed. If they were with each other they were happy and nothing else mattered. She ran the house and knew how to hang onto the pennies, while he talked big about saving money, but if he had a couple of bucks in his pocket he figured they didn't count.

All through the winter Russ was steady and regular but when the spring came he began talking about clamming. And then in May he told me that Rita was in a family way and that they were expecting a kid in November. That should have made him serious about his job and his work, but it didn't.

One morning, on the way to the factory, the windows on the street car were up and he kept sniffing the air like a hungry pup when there's a soup bone a-cooking. The wind was soft and it came in off the lake and there'd been a warm rain in the night and all of a sudden he punched the button and got up.

"Tell 'em I won't be there today," he said, and got off.

On a job like his, to lay off, unless you're sick, is pretty darn serious. The safety rules say "Willful absence from work will not be tolerated."

That morning there was work to be done and Johnson was madder than a wet owl and he called up the front and they sent out a car with two H.P.'s to investigate. They found him. Not at the house, sick in bed; but in the marsh, sitting on a log whittling a stick and watching a couple of blackbirds building a nest.

That night in my room, where he'd sometimes come to sit after supper, I said:

"Russ, the trouble with you is you're too independent. You spit where you see a no-spitting sign; walk on the grass where it tells you to keep off; rub when you're told to blot and blot when it says rub. You're so contrary that if Mr. Holt wanted you to vote for his cousin for mayor, you'd just as likely as not vote for Tom Mooney. There's too much of the old devil in you. Unless you turn over a new leaf and learn to take orders—some day you'll find yourself out of a job."

"I was thinking this morning," he said, ignoring what I was trying to tell him, "that it will soon be summer again. By the first of July we'll have three hundred dollars saved up between the two of us. What say we start about then?"

"I've been thinking it over," I said. "Clamming's pretty uncertain."

"Uncertain?" he said. "What's more uncertain than working in Mr. Holt's factory? When he gets up for breakfast tomorrow he's liable to get a couple of eggs that are too soft, get on a grouch, and shut the whole place down for six months. Then where would we be? We'd be nowhere. With sixty-seventy thousand men on the streets looking for jobs we'd be so far on the outside we couldn't even get a look in through the gate. Clamming is less of a gamble. Besides—it's more fun."

"There's other things in life," I said, "besides having fun."

"What are they?"

"Well, to have a house of your own—go out riding on Sunday in a nice car—have a vegetable garden —"

"Have to be a vegetable garden? No flowers?"

"Well, a vegetable garden's more practical. Can't eat flowers, you know."

"Right from the book, ain't it, Bennie? Listen, Bennie," he said, "how often have I told you to throw that book in the fire? That book will ruin you if you take - it serious. It's full of ideas that won't work for you—won't work for anybody unless they're billionaire auto manufacturers out to get the last ounce of flesh from every man in the shop. Why, Bennie, ideas like that are positively dangerous, once they get loose. They'll be the ruination of us working men if we don't put them down."

"Put them down? Hear you talk—you'd think Mr. Holt was a communist or something."

"He's worse. Take that motto there on the wall—'WORK HARD AND BEHAVE YOURSELF.' It's all right if you own the factory. But if you're a working man—don't behave yourself ever, unless you want to be a machine tender all of your life. Take your own case. You work hard, behave yourself, save a little money, and get laid off when the machine catches up. When you're dead broke you get on again—work hard—save a little money again, and get laid off again when the machine does. And you always get laid off because the machine goes to beat the band and always catching up."

"But I always get on again."

"And you always get laid off again. In the end you're always just where you started. You don't have as much fun as the niggers. They're always broke, too, but at least they have fun as long as the pay checks are coming in and the finance company lets them tear around in new Holts."

"It's the yearly models," I said. "They have to shut down."

"Yearly models," he said. "Yearly models—me eye. They shut down because they want to throw us out of the shop. The whole country would be better off if they didn't have yearly models. They would, themselves. That yearly model stuff gives 'em an excuse to flood the whole country with cars and then close up and kick the men out. If they didn't have some excuse the government would mighty soon do something about it. They ought to, anyhow. It's ruining the country. You've been in the factory a long time. How often have you seen Mr. Holt in the shop?"

"Twice."

"Twice. What was he doing? Working? Answer me that."

"Well—no," I said. "Not exactly. Once he came through with a fellow from the movies. Another time with an English Duke or something. Mr. Holt's too big to work in the factory. He's above that. But even though he's not there—even though you don't see him—you feel his spirit. Anyone that's worked in the shop a long time will tell you it's as if he was watching you—as if he was standing there looking over your shoulder. All the old fellows feel that way—all the fellows that's trying to work up."

"Work up to what?"

"Straw bosses. I feel that way myself. I put an oil can up on the shelf and I try to set it there the way Mr. Holt would. When I stick a bunch of rags in the waste bucket, I try to do it the way Mr. Holt would do it himself."

"And what does it get you?"

"Maybe I'll get to be a straw boss some day."

"And if you do, when the shut-down comes—you'll get laid off with the others."

"Maybe. But I'll have a good record. I'll get on again. The trouble with you is, Russ, you've never learned to take orders. What you need is a spell on the assembly line where some other fellow throws in the switch and you do the work and the electric motors set the pace for you—tell you when to start—when to stop—and when to speed up. Electric motors you can't argue with and

can't shut off when you want to go to the toilet, and a straw boss that's not in the habit of talking very much but takes you for a walk and lets you have a long look at the string of men at the employment gate when you get behind in your work and hold up the line."

"That reminds me," he said, "of an old song we used to sing in the woods:

*I shave my whiskers like a man,*
*Use a larder's pail, or an old tin can*
*To lather up my grizzled pan,*
*Then give me an axe, with a blade that's true,*
*A double-bitted axe, that's bright and new,*
*And a hack and a whack, and then I'm through.*

"I've shaved with a double-bitted axe, Bennie. Give me a double-bitted axe and I can hold up my end any time—with any man—on any line. If you think it's easy to shave with an axe—try it some time."

Sometimes when we'd get to arguing that way his talk didn't hardly make sense.

# CHAPTER XI

A couple of weeks later, on account of his hot-headed temper, Russ got himself into a mess. Blame it all, I had to lie to beat the band to get him clear.

Herman, the fellow who ran the overhead crane, chewed tobacco.

You'd see him up there near the ceiling coasting along in his iron cage with his head sticking out, a cud in his cheek the size of a duck egg, and every once in a while sending a long, thin squirt down to the floor. He hardly ever hit anybody and almost never hit Russ' rig, but just the same Russ was worried. At night, after work, he'd go around the machine, looking it over.

"What's that?" he'd say. "Looks mighty suspicious to me."

"Aw, get out," I'd say. "It's a little iron rust or some water."

From day to day he worked himself up about it something fierce and nothing I said made any difference. And then one day he sent in a long complaint to the safety department, and the next day, after lunch, two safety engineers came to the floor. They got Johnson and called Russ down from the rig.

"What's this," they said, "about you being liable to kill somebody on account of the overhead man chewing tobacco?" They had Russ' letter.

"Well," said Russ, "I work on this rig. The man's up there over my head. You can see what the situation is."

There was Herman, his head sticking out of the cage a foot, a cud in the side of his face, looking down and wondering for all he was worth what the deuce the pow-wow down below was all about. In a minute or so he spit, in a sort of meditative way, and a brown stream of tobacco juice sailed through the air, flattened out and broke up in a dozen long smears.

"It's just luck," said Russ, "I wasn't there that time. Suppose I had been and a swab of that hit me in the eye. And suppose Johnson here, was standing there under my rig. I'm handling a big lug of steel—I can't see for a minute—lose control—hit the wrong lever. I drop the load and kill Johnson. It would cost the Company some dough, wouldn't it?"

Johnson laughed a thin little laugh.

"He's neva hit you yet, has he?"

"No," said Russ. "And I've never killed you yet, either, have I?"

"No —"

"Well, there's always the first time."

The safety men looked serious.

"We oughta do something," said one. "What would you suggest?" he asked Johnson.

"Tell 'im to be a little more careful," said Johnson. "I'll see this fella don't kill me."

Johnson, himself, chewed tobacco. In fact, he was practically never without a chew and even as he talked he jerked his head around every once in a while on the sly and spit to one side. But not being up in the air fifty feet he wasn't conspicuous about it like Herman.

"There's a chance there for an accident all right," said one of the men. "It's our business to catch things like that before somebody gets hurt."

"Somebody's liable to get hurt," said Russ. "And if they do, you'll have to admit I gave warning."

"What would you suggest?" said the other.

"Suggest? I wouldn't suggest. I'd tell him. I'd tell him to stop chewing."

"We can't pick on him."

"Why not? You'd pick on me if I smoked. If I smoked my card would be pulled in a minute. Smoking's no worse than chewing."

"Depends on how you look at it."

"Well," said Russ, "if I had a job in the safety department I'd look at it the way Mr. Holt looks at it. Mr. Holt hates tobacco. He'd put a stop to it while we're standing here arguing."

The safety men left and went to see Riley. They were pretty serious about something that didn't amount to a darn.

"Of course," I said to Russ, "it wasn't yourself you were worried about."

"I suppose not," he said. "I could put on a raincoat and wear goggles, but that wouldn't protect Old Betsy."

"What's the diff? I'm the swipe. You're making a big stir about nothing."

"Not exactly," he said. "Maybe I'm a little sentimental but I don't want anybody spitting tobacco juice on Old Betsy nohow at no time."

A couple of days later a general order came through from the safety department. There was to be no more tobacco chewing by crane operators while on duty. Herman was sore as a boil. He knew who was to blame. So did forty-fifty other crane men after Herman made the rounds.

A little thing like chewing tobacco don't mean much to you and me, but to a crane man, sitting up there in his cage the long day, with nothing to do except pulling the same little levers and thinking what he'd do to the hooker if he got the chance and never being able to do it, it's different. For him, it breaks the monotony and makes up for not having anyone to talk to and not being

allowed to cuss out at the men on the floor. It's something to smooth out the little irritations that come up every day. Besides, it gives him a chance to express his feelings when he gets mad at the hooker and gets all steamed up inside like a boiler. Give a crane man a sizeable chew and he can express himself one hundred percent in the way he lets fly at the hooker or a dumb loading man down on the floor.

As I said, Herman was sorer than a mashed thumb. And he took it out on Russ by starting to swing in his loads. All that afternoon he kept swinging closer, and once, when Johnson wasn't on the floor, he pulled one straight over the rig. Russ got up on his ear, and that night, after Herman climbed down from the crane, Russ warned him again.

"I'm telling you once more," he said. "Keep your loads in the clear. Swing another load over my head and I'll reach up there and pull you and your cage down to the floor so quick you won't know what's happened."

"Boosh-wah," said Herman. "Tell it to the safety committee, why doncha?"

I had a chance to talk to Herman at the tool crib.

"Better take it serious," I said. "When he gets his hands on them levers—he'll do anything—he ain't human."

"That's all right," he said. "Me—I'm hot-headed, too. If he wants to start something—I'm for it."

The next day it happened. It was about three in the afternoon. Johnson was up at the desk talking to Riley. Russ had a piece of cold stuff and was getting in position to load number three. I had the air off and was raising the door when Herman came down the bay with a stack of front axle blanks, three-four tons of them. The load came down the bay in a straight line for Russ. I figured Herman was going to throw a little scare into Russ—figured he'd come up close and then swing his load to the other side of the bay. But he didn't. He came straight on—the load swinging a little at the end of the long cables. He was close—getting closer—without cutting speed. Thirty feet—twenty—coming straight over. But no—Russ dropped his load to the floor and shot backwards. He stopped; raised his boom like a snake getting ready to strike and stood his ground. Herman came straight into it. Russ shot out his boom, the iron claw open for business, smashed into Herman's load, and the front axle blanks clattered and rained to the floor. The racket was something terrific. Iron chips flew in every direction; dust rose thick from the floor; scalers and hammer men scattered. I ducked for a pillar.

The fight was on. Herman rolled back and pulled his hooks up—got into position. Now they were empty—ready to hit. Russ drew in his boom like a rattler getting ready to strike. The big claw snapped open—aimed at the cage—came at Herman. But Herman struck first—dropped his hooks like a swinging plumet in a long curve. It was a good shot. He got a grappling hold on the undercarriage of the rig. He drew tight. A couple of pulls and he'd turn the rig over. But Russ was too quick. He slashed his boom around against the steel cables and wiped himself clear. Snarling

steel rope filled the air. In a wild swing Herman's hooks struck the top of a furnace. Bricks rained to the floor—dust was thick enough to walk on. Somewhere a steam line let go. Noise was terrific.

Herman shot back and rolled in his line. Came in again, maneuvering for a direct overhead drop, trying to keep Russ on the defensive. But Russ went at him. He shot out his boom—full length—straight from the cage. Herman kicked back—not a second too soon. Another two feet and Russ would have had him down on the floor. Herman dropped the hooks; Russ struck as they fell and sent them spinning, and they crashed against the big hammer. But they were open and on the rebound they hit the undercarriage of the rig—closed up and held. Herman gave her the juice—all he had. His lines tightened. Once more Russ tried to slash himself clear—struck out. It was no good. The steel lines tightened still more. Russ swung his boom—raised and lowered—trying to cut through. Fire leaped from the cables as steel sheared on steel. No use. The rig—one side—began to raise from the floor. He'd go over! To save himself he aimed his boom for the crane—shot out to full length—clamped onto the bridge. It held. Herman was powerless to move him. The two machines were deadlocked to a standstill.

It was then I thought about throwing out the master switches like I'm supposed to do in emergencies. Running through the white fog of dust from the wrecked furnace I nearly knocked over Johnson.

"What's the matta?" he hollered, eyes sticking out a foot. I kept a-going.

Both switches were up there on the wall pillar and I cut Herman out first, and when I did, Russ settled back to the floor.

And then I got busy. Fellows were running all around, looking up, still not sure whether the building would come down or not. Scalers with brick dust on their clothes began showing up on the floor looking scared.

I went up to a couple.

"Listen," I said. "You fellows. I don't care who you're for. But if one gets fired—they both go. We gotta make them think it was an accident. I'll do the talking."

And that's how it come about that I had to do some powerful lying. Blame it all—I don't like to tell such tall lies. Mr. Holt is against lying. But what could I do? There was Johnson and he had the two men down on the floor, and there was Riley and a whole bunch of others and they wanted to know everything. And after I got started, there was no way of changing my story—no place to stop; and I got in deeper and deeper; and I told them that the two machines had just accidentally come together, and that in trying to untangle they had got scrambled up something awful. Russ was still fighting mad, but looking at him you might have thought that he was just scared, and I was afraid that he would lay into Herman right there while I was talking, though a fist-fight, I guess, would have been pretty tame after the way they had been going at it. And there were the two machines, still standing there with death grips on each other, in what you might call a compromising position—axle blanks and broken brick scattered all over the floor and smoke pouring

from the hole in the furnace. If Johnson or Riley had had a lick of sense in their heads they wouldn't have had to ask any question, but what it came down to, I guess, is what I told Russ. They just couldn't imagine that there would ever be two fellows so dumb and hot-headed that they would try to run off a fight with a bridge crane and a manipulator.

The pow-wow ended up with me getting it in the neck from Johnson.

"When you saw what was happening," he said, "why'n-cha do sumpt'ing? Why'n-cha t'row out the switch right away, 'stead of standin' there with your hands in your pockets?"

# CHAPTER XII

In May, times were still bad in Detroit, and things didn't pick up like everybody said in the winter. Factories that were running four days a week cut to three; and those that were running three, cut to two; and some closed down altogether under the excuse of changing models or taking inventories. When business is bad, taking inventory can sure keep an automobile factory closed down a long time. Gangs of men loafed around the street corners and in the barber shops, and rats started coming out again in broad daylight looking for garbage, not waiting for dark and the stiff competition the men out of work gave them. You could pick up a good-looking dame on the streets just for buying her supper.

Mr. Holt made a statement in the newspapers. "We'll take it easy," he said, "and get ready."

"That's an idea for us," I said to Russ, one night after supper. "We'll just go along easy and steady and hang onto our jobs."

"You're all wet," he said. "When things look bad, take the bull by the tail. Don't wait until he gets his horns into you. I'm just waiting to catch Johnson with a heavy schedule. I figure we've got another raise coming."

And the very next day things happened. All that day we'd been working along same as usual and there was nothing to show that anything was different, or that we wouldn't be on the same job a long time, but after the bell Johnson called Russ and me over and gave us a couple of slips.

"Take these," he said, "and go up to the transfer department and see if ya can get yaself a couple new jobs. I can't use-ya no more."

"What's the matter?" said Russ.

"It's nottin' the matta," said Johnson. "It's just what I'm tellin' ya—I can't use-ya no more."

"Why not?"

"Cause I can't. We got a new way figured out for making dies. We ain't gonna forge 'em no more."

Johnson was fooling around with some blue-prints—filing some away—throwing some in the can.

"Who's gonna run the rig?" asked Russ.

"Nobody."

"'What's gonna happen to it?"

"They'll feed it to the open-heart's. Melt it up and make some new Holts. In a couple days you'll see it standin' out there in the bone-yard. The big hammer goes too. No more poundin' and bangin'. It ain't civilized to make dies like that."

"Ain't civilized? How are you gonna make dies if you don't forge them?"

"We're gonna type 'em."

"Type them?"

"That's what I said."

"It sounds crazy."

"Might be it sounds crazy to you."

Johnson went on with his work.

"But listen, Johnson—in typing you use cast ingots."

"What of it? You don't have to pound and bang around and play circus in front of a bunch of visitors with a piece of steel to make it tough. It's fun for you, maybe, but it's old fashioned. It ain't civilized, I tell you."

"But how are you going to make dies without forging? How are you gonna make 'em tough and hard—to stand up?"

"What's gotta be harder'n a camshaft for a Holt car?"

"I don't know."

"And what's gotta be tougher'n a crankshaft?"

"I don't know. Why?"

"Well—I'm just askin' to see if ya know. Why'n-cha keep on your toes? Know what's going on in the shop? We ain't forging camshafts no more. Neither crankshafts. We're castin' 'em. Now what d'ya tink about that? The first ones came t'rue two mont's ago. I could-a tol' you then—your job here was blowed up."

"I still think it sounds crazy."

"And I still t'ink it don't make no difference what you t'ink."

"But what's to hinder them breaking—wearing out?"

"If I tell you—you'll keep you mout' shut?"

"Sure."

"Well, a little copper in steel makes it tough. A little carbon makes it hard. But how much to put in—that's sumpt'ing I wouldn't dast to tell."

"But why junk the rig?"

"It's absolete, I tol' ya. Odda companies use old fashion tools. We can't afford to."

"Then why not sell it?"

"Because the Holt Motor Company ain't in the second-hand business."

Johnson put on his coat.

"Betta get going," he said. "They'll be closin' up." Then he left.

I had to wash up and when I got back to the floor Russ was fooling around with the rig. He had a piece of rag in his hand—too small to do any good—and pretended to be swiping.

"Don't wait for me," he said. "I'll be along later."

But I didn't go and while waiting for him I went over some old clothes in my locker, throwing some away, saving others; and while doing this, I watched him, and what he was doing was sort of saying farewell to the rig. His big hands curved over the brasses, his fingers touching and feeling—the tips of his fingers sensing the feel of the metal that was still warm from the heat of the day's work. Along the smooth shafts his hands slid, gentle and yet strong in their motions, firm and gentle, flowing along the warm steel. Continually in motion, they were—always exploring, except when they rested a moment cupped over a journal, or hiding the soft bronze of a bearing. Always in motion, over the rounded shells of the motors—along the easy curves of gear-housings—on bare iron, along naked steel; always exploring—always caressing and feeling and seeming to draw something from the warm steel. He climbed to the controls to the brass controls, and let his hands flow over the levers—levers that his hands knew so well; touching each one—sliding his hands along the smooth metal—feeling them—understanding them with the tips of his fingers. And then down again, reaching a hand intimately into a nest of warm gears, leaning the while against the base of the machine, one hand exploring and touching, the other hand pressed against the bare, unpainted steel.

"Come on," I said. "Let's beat it. They'll be closed up before we get there if we don't get a move on."

He came out of it then, and we left, and it was a long way to walk—past the rolling mills, the hospital, the final assembly, and the foundry. The night shift was on and the Cooper-Hewitts were burning, throwing a grey-lavender light that made a man's face look like a corpse. A ship lay at the side of the dock, unloading. The spot lights turned on her deck, and the Hullett unloader, like a giant praying mantis, unbuckled and bent and reached down deep into the hold and lifted out trailing buckets of ore. Straining locomotives shifted cars of red, molten metal that lit up the sky, and high overhead, conveyors carried endless streams of rough parts and castings, finished parts and new motors, still wet with paint, from one part of the plant to another. From the river a low fog crept in and a cloud of steam from the quenching tower dimmed the high lights and spread like a blanket over the big plant.

At the foundry we stopped in a minute and spoke to one of the bosses and asked if it was true that crankshafts for the new motors were being cast. He said they were and pointed out a section of the building given over to that special work. Here the men were all Negroes and the night shift was on and they were pouring. It was line work—a continuous process, going night and day. The

molds were set endwise on L-type conveyors, each one receiving a charge of the hot metal as it moved past the furnace. There was no secret about it, the man said; the metal used being a high carbon, copper, silchrome steel; carbon, 1.5%; copper, 1.75%; chromium, .5%; and manganese, .7%. It worked out so well, the man said, that they were able to make each crankshaft fifteen pounds lighter than when they were forged, and the machine operations were cut down from sixty to fifty.

After we left the building Russ said, "We're not the only ones. A lot of good mechanics got laid off or transferred when that bunch of cotton-pickers went to work on that line."

"And to think of it," I said. "They're doing a better job of it. If they can turn out crankshafts like that I'm ready to believe anything Johnson tells me about making dies. Engineers are sure smart."

"Smarter than we are," said Russ.

In the transfer department they were getting ready to close up for the night. A clerk took our slips and looked at them.

"Don't you fellows know," he said, "we close at five?"

"How long does it take?" I asked. He didn't answer. It was still not a quarter to five.

He went to the files; looked at a couple of cards, and came back.

"What have you got for us?" I said.

"Motor assembly," he answered, starting to fill out some cards. "You'll have to turn in your badges. Get new ones tomorrow."

"But listen," I said. "This fellow here's a mechanic. He can run anything that's got wheels. Ain't you got something more in his line?"

He stopped writing and kept looking at the point of his pencil with a painful expression.

"Listen, pal," he said, "I ain't got time to stand here arguing with you all night. We close at five. You don't have to take it—only make up your mind."

"Aw, what's the use arguing with the fellow," said Russ. "If he's got something else and won't give it to us—what's the diff?"

The clerk finished making out the cards and we left. It was later than usual when we went out the gate. The day men had gone and there was a thin crowd around a medicine peddler, dressed like an Indian chief, trying to sell some kind of dope he said was a sure cure for oil dermatitis, a skin disease that was common among the men who worked on the automatics. We walked. Russ was quiet and gloomy and didn't say very much and I guess I rambled on just to make talk.

"After all," I said, "we didn't get put on 'blue mass'—that's something. On motor assembly a good man can take it. After all, a man's got to get out the work. If he didn't, Mr. Holt couldn't pay the wages he does. Others are only paying three-fifty—some even less."

Motor assembly was only working four days a week. There was talk of cutting to three. And there, we'd get cut back to five dollars a day, but even that's better than three-fifty.

"And then another thing," I said, "in motor assembly I know the bosses. I worked there before. Maybe they'll put me on again as helper. That's a job that puts you right next to the bosses. It's not the same as being a helper in the drop forge. You break in new men; stand in for fellows that want to go to the toilets. But you can't tell. Can't tell, either, what they'll give you. Maybe you'll get something pretty soft—like splitting cotter pins. All you do is stand there with a pair of pliers and split the keys open—no responsibility, no worry, no nothing. Maybe it'll be just putting on a gasket as the motors go by. It's a cinch it won't be nothing hard like the job you had in the drop forge where you had to be on your toes—getting it in the neck when things went wrong—thinking all the time—figuring out all the time what to do next. There's no jobs there—not like that—not in motor assembly. I know."

All the time he walked along as though he didn't hear me.

"If you get to work on a machine," I said, "it'll be an automatic, working on cylinder blocks, boring cylinders, cutting valve seats, or drilling push-rod holes—something like that. All you do is put the stuff in, press a lever, take the stuff out, and put it back on the conveyor. The machine checks its own work—fastens the piece in—won't start if you get it in wrong; stops if anything goes hay-wire. The machine you had in the drop forge didn't have any brains—you had to do all the thinking. There it's different. There the machines have more brains than some of the fellows that run 'em."

Still I didn't get a word out of him.

"Of course," I said, "there's some things in motor assembly you won't like, but you'll get used to 'em. The standing in line: you stand in line at the tool crib—to punch in—to punch out; when you go to the toilet you have to stand in line for your turn. There's fifteen hundred men to the acre. In the drop forge we had the whole place to ourselves. In motor assembly you'll get your own little square to stand on—you have to watch your elbows. Machines all around you: fifty, maybe hundred doing the same work, making the same noise, making the same number of revolutions a second. When there's so many—when they all run at the same speed it sort of gives you the wobblies till you get used to it. After a-while the vibrations get inside of you—under your skin. First you don't like it—you fight it. I did. But after a while you get so you time yourself with the noise and go along with it the same as the others. It's not bad if you know how to take it—let yourself go along with it. Don't try to run things."

Still he didn't say a word.

The fog came in off the lake like a rolling breaker, and yet when we reached the house it wasn't quite dark. Light enough, it was, to see the outboard laying there in the wet air on the rickety front porch. Rita opened the door and the first thing she said was:

"I'm sick and tired of having that thing under the bed. I hate the smell of it. I wish you'd get it out of here. I wish you'd sell it. I could sure use the money to get things I need for the house."

He took the motor into the house and shoved it under the bed and covered it carefully. Then we sat down to eat.

There was a bouquet of twigs from the old willow tree on the table. There were no flowers, no leaves on them—nothing but a handful of sticks.

We were having liver for supper and Russ speared a slab with his fork and put in on his plate and began cutting it into neat squares.

"When that motor goes out of here," he said, "I go. Savvy? "

She got up and went into the bedroom; slammed the door and flopped down on the bed, crying. We could hear her carrying on something fierce.

# CHAPTER XIII

It was like I told Russ the next morning while we were waiting for the timekeep to give us our badges and make out our cards:

"A fellow ain't really worked in an automobile factory until he's been on the line—knows what it's like to hold up his end on production."

"Looks to me," he said, "like any man could hold up his end along with these fellows. They're not the same breed we had in the drop forge department. Kids, mostly, and those that ain't kids are pot-bellied. The only real men here are the niggers. What would a man do with a bunch like this in the woods? Pick up chips—that's all he could use 'em for."

"That's all right," I said. "You'll have more respect for them after you've watched their duet for awhile. You'll find out that they can get out the work. They's fellows here, that when they step out for relief, four men like you couldn't hold down their jobs on the line."

It was good to get back where things were humming; where I knew the fellows and where I didn't have to worry about somebody dropping a piece of steel the size of a house on my head. The graveyard shift had punched out and the day shift was on and the noise made you feel as though you wanted to get going at something. In one end of the building were the automatics, machining cylinder blocks—boring and drilling, cutting and honing and milling. In the other end, a quarter of a mile long, was the assembly line—a moving conveyor system—hundreds of little four-wheeled buggies, moving slowly along, pulled by an endless chain driven by electric motors over a track eighteen inches above the floor. Starting out, each buggy carried a cylinder block—a single piece of cast iron; and as it moved along each man did his work, adding this part and that, until at the end it was a complete motor—ready to run. At right angles to the assembly line were the over-head conveyors, bringing in materials and parts where and when needed. These were monorail conveyors, mostly, attached to the ceiling—little streams of pistons, little streams of valves, starters, transmissions, cylinder heads and gaskets—streams that came into the main assembly line—the big river.

The timekeep took us in tow. Past busy machinery, through groups of men, over air hoses and cables, under fast-moving belts and shafts.

Near the middle of the line we met Norman. I knew Norman—he was my old straw boss.

"I got a couple of men for you," said the timekeep. "One's worked here before."

Norman looked at me—saw who I was.

"Well, well," he said, "if it ain't Bennie. Let's see, you was a helper—before. Guess I'll put you doing same thing again. Follow me, both of you." Norman was always busier than a dog with seven kinds of fleas. I walked close up.

"This other fellow—" said Norman, "he your buddy?"

"Not especially," I said. "We been working together, that's all."

"Guess I'll put him next to Jerry," he said, "starting nuts on pin bearings. Con rods—you know the job, doncha?"

"Sure."

"He ought-a pick it up in a couple weeks. You stay—till he gets on."

"You bet."

"How's this fellow, Jerry?" I said. "He used to have nutty ideas. Used to think he was Mr. Holt's son. Still funny that way—is he?"

"Worse than ever," said Norm. "He's got an idea now that he's gonna commit suicide. Better tell this new fellow not to pay him no mind."

We got to the place on the line. A couple of helpers were doing the job and we took their places, me on one side and Russ on the other, next to Jerry.

"Aw right," said Norm, "guess you know what to do." And then he left with the other helpers. As soon as his back was turned the fellows started razzing me, making cat calls and hollering "See who's here! Look what the cat's drug in!" And then, all together, they let out a howl like a bunch of hungry coyotes sitting back on their haunches. I didn't pay any attention. You don't have much time for foolishness like that when a job is new to your fingers. And the line was traveling—not fast, but still pretty good—maybe three hundred motors an hour.

The job was one of those that look easy when you stand and watch somebody else do it. Russ could see what to do. I didn't have to tell him a word. The motors were bottom side up. Jerry put on the caps over the bolts; we started the nuts—eight to each motor. Didn't turn them down—just started them on. The nuts were there right in front of us in steel trays. We didn't have to bend down, didn't have to reach if we stayed in our station.

"You get four," I said to Russ, "and I'll get four on each motor."

"What am I supposed to do the rest of the time?" he said.

"You'll find out," I said. "I won't have to tell you. The line's not traveling fast yet. In about a half-hour it'll start speeding up."

It was one of those tricky jobs where the only thing that makes it hard is the speed. If you had twice as much time, or only half as many motors to do, there'd be nothing to it. A job like that—when you try to learn it you don't grit your teeth and try to get a stranglehold on it. You go at it easy—sort of play around with it for a couple of days and let the helper do most of the work. You try to cut down your movements—figure out the best way to stand and limber up the muscles of your fingers. I've seen fellows get all tied up in a knot just because they tried too hard to lick a job in the start. But I didn't tell Russ. I thought I'd let him find out for himself what it was like to hold down a job on the line.

On the left of Russ was Jerry, the guy with the nutty ideas, who put the caps on the bearings. He and I had never got very chummy together. On the right was Thomas Jefferson, or Jeff, who ran on the nuts that we started, with a high frequency electric wrench. Jeff was a nigger. Any garage mechanic watching Jeff run down those nuts would have got an inferiority complex and laid down his tools in disgust. Jeff had been on the same job eight years. With his big hands on the handles he'd pull the trigger. Eight jabs with the spinning socket—eight smoking nuts—tight and in place. Visitors coming along the steel bridge over our heads never gave him a look—he made the job look so ridiculously simple and easy. But the fellows who knew their stuff on the line often watched him, and us helpers, who had to step into his place when he took relief, had the nervous jitters every time he took a long drink.

Some of the fellows on the line used to think I was a stool, but I'm not. Of course, when you're a helper, you've got responsibilities. You get paid for more than just the work you get out. And, of course, I've got ears, and if there's red talk around, or talk about unions, I get to hear it and I get to talk with the bosses.

"We might make a straw boss out-a you sometime," they used to tell me, "if we thought you wasn't holding back on us—if we thought you was telling us stuff—telling us who the trouble-makers are on the line."

And then there's rumors that have to be put down, and these always start on the line where the fellows work close together, elbows touching. Rumors travel fast and someone has to plug in and cut them off before they get too far down the line; spread through the factory and get out on the streets. Out on the streets anybody will believe anything about the Holt factory if the fellow who tells it has a Holt badge on his coat and looks serious. And about half the rumors are that Mr. Holt is going broke.

They start like this: Some fellow near the head of the line mentions that he has read in the papers that Mr. Holt is only going to clear ten million this year. The next fellow cuts it to nine. By the time it gets down the line a hundred yards Mr. Holt is only just about breaking even. Another hundred yards and he's losing ten-fifteen million, and by the time it reaches the end of the line he's dead broke and the money lenders of Wall Street are dividing his coat-tails.

And then about every two-three months a rumor gets started that Mr. Holt is going to shut down, and that rumor, once it gets started, is bad. It makes everybody stop spending money. The fellows stop making payments on Holt cars, stall the landlords on rent, and let their houses go back to the mortgage companies. The tradesmen and small storekeepers all over town pull in their belts—lay off the help and sit tight. Anybody can see what would happen if us helpers didn't try to stop rumors like that.

The line got into its swing. The fellows stopped joking and talking. There was no whistling or singing or horseplay—no time for nothing but work. It was good to be back in the noise and the racket; it was like getting back to city streets after being in the country a long time. It made you feel good; it made you feel like you were a part of the factory. On the line there was the rata-tat-tat-tat of pneumatic hammers, the sharp pft-pft-pft and snarl of air hoses, the whine of electric drills and the hum of power wrenches and screw drivers. But above it all rose the beat and the peculiar vibrating hum of the high-speed automatics. The vibrations from these filled the whole place and got into your blood and your nerves. It made you breathe faster, work faster; if you wanted to go slow you couldn't, and if your work didn't keep you busy you jiggled around on one foot, or made some extra motions with your hands or your arms just to keep in time with the noise. Just to be there—to be making your share of the noise—it made you feel good. It made you feel as though you were a part of something pretty darn big and important.

Russ wasn't satisfied with trying to get four or five nuts on each motor. He'd made up his mind he was going to get all of them right off the bat. He stood there with his feet wide apart, jaws set, and went at his work as though he personally had to lick the tar out of every motor that came towards him down the long line—as though he wanted to hold them back—keep them from coming at him—tear them apart with his hands. Not being used to the work, his fingers were clumsy. He'd drop a nut, start picking it up, get mad at himself, and then drop another. By that time the motor he was on would be in Jeff's station—another one coming—no nuts for Jeff to run down, and I'd have to jump in and work to beat the band to catch up.

After lunch things went the same. I didn't tell him anything. Sometimes when a fellow has ideas of his own it's better to let him find out for himself they're no good. Tomorrow, I figured, he'd be in the right mood to listen. He'd be ready to take some advice and I'd get him straightened out. When the bell rang, and we were standing in line to punch out, I said: "How do you like it—so far?"

He let out a snort.

"That's no job I got there," he said. "It's a pain in the neck."

"Tonight," I said, "you'll be putting on nuts in your sleep."

"Tomorrow," he said, "I'll have that job learnt. I'll either get all those nuts—or I'll eat my shirt."

"Well," I said, "you'd better wear a shirt that goes down easy."

He didn't have the right attitude, yet.

# CHAPTER XIV

"Russ," I said, the next morning, after the line had started up and was still going slow, giving the men a chance to warm up, "you'll get yourself all tied up in a knot on this job. Kind of take it easy for awhile. Don't try to learn it all the first day. Not even the first week."

"Learn it all," he said. "What's there to learn? Putting these bloody nuts on—that's all. Stand back! Give me room here to work!"

"Listen, now," I said. "I've put in more years than you have days on this line. You're not the first man I've helped to break in. Let me tell you a few things. Show you how to use a little science on this job."

"Science—me eye. All I need here is a weak back and a weak mind."

"But to make it easy for you, I'll show you. I'll give you a few pointers."

"All right," he said. "What are they?"

I stepped in beside him.

"In the first place," I said, "don't waste time with a nut that won't start—that won't take a hold of the threads the first time. Maybe it's got a burr, maybe the threads are not right. Don't fool around with it. Shoot it into the scrap box.

"In the second place—don't pick up a nut that you drop. It ain't worth the time it takes to stoop down and get it. And in the third place—don't waste any motions. Make every move count and go through the same motions exactly the same way each time."

I showed him.

"You grab a bunch of nuts with your left hand," I said. "Get nine—no more and no less. At first you can't do it. I can't myself. But after a while, you'll get expert; you'll hit it right every time. That gives you enough for one motor and leaves one for the scrap.

"And then to start them," I said, continuing to show him, "you take your right hand—get one nut between your thumb and forefinger. Pick it up so you're holding it right—so you won't have to change it. Put it on the end of the bolt, give it one twist to start it—not two—just one spin with

your thumb and forefinger. At first you can't do it—you're clumsy. Your fingers are all thumbs and a yard long. But you'll get it. It'll come to you after a while and when it does, you'll have the job learnt. You'll be the best little nut-starter there is."

"I've got it learnt," he said. "All I need now is some room to work and less noise. Clear out—will you?"

Him talking about noise!

"Noise," I said, "you're used to noise, ain't you? Seems to me we had some noise in the drop forge. Seems to me you helped make some."

"It's not the same," he said. "You could think."

"You'll get used to it," I said. "After a while you'll get so you'll like it. You'll get so if you didn't hear the noise it would be like dancing without music. Let yourself get into the swing of it. Don't fight it. And remember—if this job's too much of a strain, let me know. We'll talk to Norm. Maybe we can work out a trade with some other fellow."

"They're all alike. One job's as bad as another—except one."

"What's that?"

"Jerking the motors off when they get to the end."

"Cripes," I said, "that job's a man-killer. Nothing but hard manual labor."

It was the only job on the line that had the engineers stumped—where brute force was still doing the work that should have been done by electricity. They had tried out different kinds of hoists but none of them worked. A big Russian had the job. He'd been doing the same thing for years. He wouldn't have traded jobs with the superintendent himself. He worked a long iron lever attached by a chain to a truck that slid along a rail near the ceiling. He snapped a pair of iron hooks over each motor as it came to the end of the line and heaved it off the buggy and swung it onto another conveyor that ran into the motor test room. It took all of his two hundred and fifty pounds of beef at the end of the lever. But the visitors, coming along the steel bridge, watched him work. Here was a man, leather pads on his hands, sleeves cut off at the shoulders, doing something with a swing and a flourish—getting things done. They could appreciate his efforts, see the sweat on his shirt—watch his big muscles swell. The other jobs on the line were hard to understand. Not spectacular. Little jobs, for the most part—doing little things with the little muscles of the hands and the fingers. But the job the Russian had was different and he made the most of it, showing off for the visitors. He was the only man on the line that sometimes busted out in loud song. He had a pair of mustachios that stuck out like a pair of horns on a Texas steer. His shirts were never anything but silk, sleeves cut off at the shoulders, and on his ham-like arms, exposed to the admiring view of the school-teachers, were the tattooed figures of a wild boar and a wolfhound, which, held side by side, showed the animals to be in a fight when he made the muscles twitch in his arms.

"No soap," I said. "I know that fellow. He won't trade. He's been on that job for years. He likes to show off for the visitors."

About nine-thirty the line speeded up and the bosses started riding the buggies. About one buggy in every two hundred had a line boss on it instead of a motor, the boss standing up on the buggy and riding. You'd be working along and all of a sudden a couple of feet would show up and there would be a line boss standing over your head, drifting along, checking the operations to see if everybody was doing his work and not dragging over or bucking the line.

On a conveyor system like ours one man can ball up the whole works. If a man is slow on his operation he gets dragged over into the next fellow's station, and the next fellow gets pushed over into the fellow's station beyond him, and so down the line. In cases like that, a helper, or maybe two or three helpers, jump in and in a few minutes they get things straightened out—running smooth again.

But there are other fellows harder to handle—harder to find. These are the fellows that make it a practice to buck the line. Most generally they never get behind on their own operations—they're too smart for that—but they make it hard for the others, and especially for the niggers, by breaking down the morale, starting wild stories, putting on nuts that jam and won't thread, using defective gaskets, and balling things up in general, so that there is always a kind of fight going on between the men and the bosses—the bosses trying to speed up the line, trying to get out production—the men holding back, doing things to make the line drag. Generally these fellows stay covered up, but once in a while one comes out in the open and when he does—he's jerked out pretty darn quick! One of these, I'd always had a sneaking suspicion, was Jerry, the guy with the nutty ideas who worked next to Russ.

Lunchtime came and we lined up for soup. It was a long line—seventy or eighty fellows crowding each other, the stomach of one man rubbing the back of the fellow ahead. Behind Russ was a fat little Polack, crowding just like the others. Russ was pretty uncomfortable, shifting about, first to one side and then to the other. The little Polack, not wanting to lose his place in the line, shifted, too, and Russ got more and more nervous. He wasn't used to that kind of thing. In the drop forge there were only a few of us and we never had to line up. In the lumber camps, I guess, he had the whole woods to himself. Anyway, he had funny ideas about not wanting to be touched, not wanting to be handled by others. I noticed it first when he jerked away from the doctor while taking his physical examination at the time he was hired.

Russ turned around and said to the little Polack:

"What you trying to do—run over me? Stand back a ways. Don't stick your paunch into me. Don't touch me."

"'Was's a mat," said the little Polack, "you goosey—maybe?"

"If you're anxious to find out," said Russ, "try it and see."

The little Polack picked up an air hose and goosed him. Russ turned around, quick as a cat, and hit the Polack with his open hand alongside of the head. There was a stack of camshafts right near and the Polack grabbed one. But before he could raise it Russ let him have one that rolled him

clean to the floor. There was a crowd right away and two H.P.'s, one big and one little, strong-armed their way up. Always, they seemed to bob up in pairs—always one was big and one little and the little one usually did all the talking while the big one stood around and looked serious.

"What's the matter, here?" said the little one.

Russ started to explain. .

"This little Polack, here," he said, "was crowding me from behind. I told him to lay off and he wouldn't. I hit him."

The little Polack was back on his feet and started jabbering.

"That's not all," I said. "The Polack goosed him with this air hose."

The big one picked up the hose. Pressed the lever.

"Air in it," he said, mighty solemn.

"Is that right?" said the other to Russ. "Did this fellow try to goose you with this hose?"

"That's not what I knocked him down for," said Russ. "He picked up an iron."

"That's not what I'm asking you. I want to know—did he try to goose you with this hose?"

"Aw, skip it," said Russ. "He's learned his lesson. Let the poor guy go." Russ walked away.

But some fellow in the crowd I didn't know, spoke up. Said he had seen the Polack pick up the hose. That was enough.

"Aw, right," said the big fellow to the Polack; "turn in your tools; pull your card. You're coming with us."

The little H.P. climbed up on a box and began making a speech.

"Now I wanna tell you fellas something," he said. "There's gonna be no more horseplay in this shop with air hoses. There's been too much of it. It's gonna be stopped. I want you fellas to get that through your heads. If you fellas can't read the safety rules, get someone else to read 'em for you. What'd you t'ink dese rules are for, anyhow? What'd you t'ink we put 'em up for all over dese buildings? Just for fun? Every year somebody gets killed with a busted gut just because some of you fellas never learn nottin'. Some of you fellas ain't got brains enough to get along with hardly." Etc., etc.

He went on that way for quite a while before he calmed down, got off the box and shut up. By that time the little Polack had got back with his card, looking worried and scared.

"Please, mister," he said, "I don't like me get fired. I got famlee—six. My wife seek. She's no goot to vork. Pleese—mister—I no do nottin' no more."

"Come on," said the big fellow. "We're gonna learn you a lesson."

And the little Polack, carrying his card and still begging for all he was worth not to be fired, was marched away.

# CHAPTER XV

In the afternoon Jerry started shooting off his mouth to Russ. Up till then he hadn't said a word to Russ—hadn't looked at him hardly. But he'd seen the fight and the way Russ handled himself and now he started taking Russ under his wing—getting pally with him.

"Why don't you pull out of here," he said, "before this thing gets you down. Once it gets you, and you get to the point where you don't mind it, you're sunk. Never be no good again for nothing. Lose your nerve—lose your self-respect—your manhood. Stay here a year and you might's well be dead."

Things like that he was telling Russ.

Russ was handling the job all by himself. But I stuck around pretty close, knowing that if he got behind and balled things up on the line, I'd get the blame. Besides, I wanted to catch some of the things Jerry was saying.

I knew Jerry. Knew him from the time I came to work in motor assembly. He was a Jew and full of crazy ideas. He wasn't a communist, exactly, but he read books about Socialism and labor unions, and he went to Townsend meetings where he got up and made speeches. He used to go around telling people that he was Mr. Holt's son—the real Raymond Holt, and that, by rights, he should be sitting with his feet on the big desk, running the yacht, living in the big house on Jefferson Avenue, and that Raymond should be doing production work on the line. When I first came to work in the factory he got chummy with me. He got me alone one day in the toilet.

"Listen," he'd said, "if I let you in on a secret you'll keep your mouth shut, won't you?"

I promised and he pulled out a bunch of papers, worn out and dirty from being carried about a long time.

"These prove it," he said. "I've got finger prints and everything. We was born the same day—same hospital. The nurse got us mixed."

The fellows kidded him along. They said anyone could see just by looking at him that he was Mr. Holt's son—same features—same little habits, like jingling coins in his pockets and pulling his

watch chain when he talked. Norm tried to straighten him out, but you couldn't argue with him. If you didn't agree with what he said, he got mad.

And then one day he got all his papers together and sent them to Mr. Holt, along with a letter, explaining everything. The very same day a couple of H.P.'s popped up in his room; looked the place over, told him he was all wet and ordered him to lay off talking about Mr. Holt and his son. That had the effect of making him crawl into his shell and shut up tight as a clam, and he got the idea that the H.P.'s were all down on him and that they watched every move that he made day and night. Let a couple walk by strictly minding their own business, which they sometimes did, and he'd say to the fellow next to him:

"Notice the way they looked at me, then?"

"Too many books," was the way Norman explained it, and I guess he was right. Once a fellow from the University at Ann Arbor made a study of Holt workers in Detroit and found that they spent on the average twenty cents each each year for books, not counting papers. Jerry spent twice that much and has a good education besides. And what does it get him? A lot of nutty ideas.

One idea that he had was that Holt workers should raise kids without brains to work on the automatics and assembly lines. Thinking, he said, was bad for a man that worked in Mr. Holt's factory. Got him into all kinds of trouble. But a man without brains could work on the line, run his car hell-a-tootin' up and down Woodward Avenue, drink beer with the Polacks, shoot pool with the niggers, listen to what Mr. Holt said and have a big time. He was serious about saying these things. It's like Mr. Holt says in his book: "Too much education may be a very bad thing for a man."

He was talking again, telling Russ about his plans.

"Some day," he said, "I'm going to commit suicide right here in this plant. I've got it all figured out—the way I'm going to do it, but I'm not telling anybody. These Holt spotters around here watch every move I make. They'd put a jinx on my plans if they could."

Russ didn't join in the talk very much. He was too busy.

"All I'm telling anyhow now," he continued, "is that I've got a way figured out that's a honey. It'll get my name in the headlines. And on the same day Mr. Holt will get a bunch of papers that will make him sit up and take notice—make him wish he'd done different. It'll be too late then."

"How are you going to commit suicide here in the plant?" said Russ. "Get yourself run over by a switch engine?"

"'Na-a-a—" he said, in a way that insinuated that Russ' ideas about such things were pretty old fashioned, "I've got a way figured out that beats that all hollow. But I can't tell you. I'm not telling anyone. All I can say is that it's going to shut the whole works down for three solid days. Everyone on production will get laid off and have a chance to go to my funeral. It'll be the biggest funeral that's ever been pulled off in Detroit. And it's going to cost Mr. Holt plenty of money—plenty."

Such talk as that gets around and is bad for the men. I had a good notion to speak to Norm and tell him that his talk was beginning to sound red.

# CHAPTER XVI

In the motor assembly we were cut back to five dollars a day, worked four days a week, and Russ, instead of laying away money, was spending more than he made. One reason was he'd take a day off and go job-hunting whenever he felt like it, or heard a rumor that some other company was hiring. On Fridays and Saturdays he'd ride the street cars, going from one plant to another, trying to get a better job. But none of them paid as much as five dollars; most of them worked even less than we did.

Coming home he'd have stories to tell—things the fellows around the employment gates had told him about new machines and new ways of doing things in the factories. He'd done some welding, once, and started out trying to get a job as a welder, but soon gave it up. He heard the men talk about spot welders, seam welders, butt welders, and flash welders, and found that these were the names of machines, and not, as he first thought, types and kinds of work done by skilled welders.

There was no more handwelding to be done in the factories except a little piddling and patching with oxyacetylene torches where the machines skipped. The machines had taken over the trade.

Some of the welding machines that he told about were sure slick. There were some that took in the parts of a car body and welded them together in a shower of fire, making a single, solid whole of the pieces—closing seams in one shot that were six feet long—doing the work in one flash that used to take three or four men a couple of hours. To hear him tell it the operators of the machines had no control over the work; the time, pressure, amount of wire, melting rate, and heat all being fixed by the engineers who set up the machines.

One company had a machine called the "Iron Man" that welded gas tanks. It was a spot welder—fully automatic—turned and tilted the tanks as it worked on them and ran a neat row of eleven spots to the inch around the edges like a sewing machine hemstitching a handkerchief, except that nobody put his hands on the work. Four of these did the work of two hundred and fifty hand welders.

Another company had a machine that checked and sorted piston pins for size, grading to limits of one ten-thousandths of an inch. The operator fed them into the machine with a shovel. New machines to combat the hard times by cutting down labor costs were being moved into the plants every day. Among these were the centerless grinders, where, because the work did not even have to be fastened in, the operator ran a whole battery of machines. There were drum-type milling machines, merry-go-rounds the men called them, that took the rough pieces around in a circuit and brought them back fully machined, eight or ten riding around at the same time; full automatic contour grinders for camshafts; and complicated machines that bored as many as ninety-six holes from five or six different angles in the same operation. In the power plants not a man put his hand to a slicing bar or a shovel, these tools being seen only in a glass cage in the boiler room where they were pointed out to the visitors as relics of an age that was past. In the steel mills of the plants there were a few men in the big, glass, air-conditioned cages, watching a row of tiny lights that went off and on—manipulating rows of steel levers that sent long, snakelike bars of red steel backwards and forwards between the giant rollers—flattened bar steel to thin strips the width and thickness of wallpaper—tossed ingots of steel back and forth with the strength of seven thousand horses; but down below on the floor there was not a man to be seen except the headers who stood with long-handled tongs next to the rollers and started the red snakes into the right grooves. After telling about these things Russ would be pretty discouraged.

"The engineers," he would say, "are cutting us out of the picture. I can see why the men that have been around in the plants all want to be sweepers. It's th last stand against the machine; it's the last transfer, Picking up the dirt the machines make."

He was always looking on the dark side of things.

After supper he'd haul the outboard from under the bed; spread a newspaper out on the table and begin taking something apart. Rita got so she hated the sight of the thing and would go into the bedroom and close the door. One night she came into my room.

"As long as he's got that thing," she said, "he'll never settle down and take his responsibility. I wish there was some way I could get rid of it."

"He'll get tired of it," I said. "Give him time. Soon's he gets used to his new job—gets to like it—he'll forget all about clamming."

"You think so?" she said. "Do you think he'll ever settle down and be steady like the other men that have families?"

"Sure," I said, wanting to make her feel good. "After a month or two more the work will be a cinch for him. He'll think he's got the best job on the line. They all do, after they've been on the same job a while. Get so they do it easy—don't have to think. What gets 'em is when they have to think about work they don't like."

"I don't know," she said. "He's not like the others. I keep worrying. With the baby coming—I don't feel like I did about things. I want things to be certain. It's not myself I'm thinking about."

"Of course not."

"I used to think it was fun to talk about clamming—live out in the woods like Indians. But I didn't think he was serious—not about that kind of thing. Going about from one place to another —not having a job—no pay checks coming in."

"You're like I am," I said.

"Only—you're not having a baby."

"Well—not exactly."

"I'd like to have money," she said. "Enough to go to a hospital."

"Mr. Holt's would be a good place."

"But it costs money," she said. "And we're not getting ahead. We spend more than we make. A lot goes for carfare. He lays off when he hears some other company is putting on men. And as long as that motor's under the bed—as long as he tinkers around with it—I know what he's thinking."

"I know how you feel," I said. "I won't encourage him. I'll try to make things go as smooth as I can in the factory. Get him to like things."

I was mighty sorry for her. Sitting there on a box where I kept my writing things, she was sewing on a blanket that was hardly as big as a man's handkerchief. That baby coming—being on the way—had sure changed her. It had changed her from a taxi-dancing flapper and was making a woman out of her. The trouble was—it left Russ the same.

One night, coming out of the factory after we'd been in motor assembly a little more than a month, we passed the bone-yard, and there, in with ten acres of other scrapped machinery, we saw the rig. One side was down in the mud; the boom was all screwy, and the big iron claw hung loose and open like an idiot's mouth.

"There's Old Betsy," said Russ. "Let's go in and see what they've done to her."

I didn't see the use, but I went, getting my feet wet and muddy. He went up to the rig and put his hand on the control box.

"Cold iron," he said, serious. "No static, even. But if you was to turn the juice into her she'd soon come to warm life again."

"She'll come to warm life," I said, "when they get the torches to work on her—cut her up and feed her to the open hearths. One of these days she'll be coming over the line in the shape of cylinder blocks and you'll be starting nuts on her."

"You know, Bennie," he said, sliding his hand back and forth along a drive-shaft, "there's something almost funny about the way this steel feels to the touch. You get used to having a thing feel the same way, don't you? And when it doesn't—it's almost as though something was wrong. Even during the night she never got really cold. In the morning there was always some heat left in the metal. It must be that way when you feel the hand of someone you've known a long time and —"

"Must be," I said. "Let's get going. If the H.P.s see us fooling around here you'll have a hard time making 'em believe that you're preaching a funeral sermon and not trying to get away with

some brass bearings."

"Don't rush me," he said. "What's the difference if we get outa this place a few minutes later than usual? This is probably the last time we'll see the old rig."

"Last time you get sentimental about it, I hope."

"To you," he said, "this machine here is just a pile of old iron—junk. But to me it's more than that, Bennie. To me—it's Old Betsy—still. To you, all machines are alike. Pieces of steel and iron put together—all alike. But they're not, Bennie. Machines do things to us—the men that work with them. Things the engineers never think about. Some machines build us up—help us to make the most of ourselves. Some tear us apart—grind us down. A machine geared to a man—is one thing. A man geared to a machine—is something else. One's human, gives you a chance to be your best self. The other works on you like a gear-cutter—whittling you down, chiseling at you, cutting grooves in you, making you like all the other small gears that work on the line."

He stood there fingering a winged nut on a brakerod, just the bare hint of a smile near the corner of his mouth, that smile that I never knew quite how to take.

"I don't know what you're thinking about," I said, "but I guess it's all right."

"I'm not sentimental," he said, in his quiet way. "At least, I don't think I am. I see things for what they are worth—to me. When I was in the drop forge I had a man's job and did a man's work. It was fun. Remember how I used to stay after the bell rang and try to work out ideas for getting the work done faster, better? I had a chance to use the brains I was born with. Old Betsy, here, gave me a chance to get the most out of myself. When a job was done, I looked it over. Took some of the credit, if it was good. Took some of the blame, if it wasn't. Tried to figure out how to do it better the next time. Old Betsy was geared to my brain—did what I wanted it to do. Gave its strength to my hand, gave its power to my will. I was the boss.

"But in the motor assembly, Bennie, it's different. There the machine is the boss. The machine does the nice work—the hard work—the part that takes skill. The machine's everything and gets credit for the work done. You're nothing until you've learned to be a gear—a small part of the big machine—until there's nothing left of you but a very small cog without any will. You start and stop when the machine's ready—go slow or fast as the machine tells you. The machine counts—you don't. And why should you? You don't furnish the brains. You don't furnish the skill. All you do is fasten a nut, put on a washer, stamp on a number. The machine does the real job. It's the big boss standing over your head—grinding you down—wasting your strength—whittling away at your brain. Making you a small part of its dead, mechanical self."

"Come on," I said, "it's late. Supper will be waiting for us. We haven't cleaned up yet."

"That's right," he said, picking his way through the mud, "we haven't cleaned up. In the drop forge—we used to clean up every night before leaving. Used to change our clothes and wash the dirt from our faces. Walk out of the gate looking decent. Now we don't—ever. Nobody does. When it's time for the bell we don't think about anything except getting out—getting out.

Getting away from the machines. We lay our tools just so—roll our sleeves down—untie the knots in our aprons. We get set for the bell. We get ready to rush out when the bell rings, thinking we'll get rid of the machines for a spell—the machines that eat into us like gear-cutters. But we don't, Bennie. We don't—ever. They stay with us, they get into our blood, leave their dirty imprint on our faces. It's there when we hurry out—there on the river of dead faces streaming out through the gate. And in the morning, when we come back to the machines—it's still there. We go home and use water and soap but we never clean up. The work of the machines that keep whittling and chiseling at us is too deep."

# CHAPTER XVII

Gus was too old to work on production. He was too slow to keep up with the others. He was fifty.

"Gus," his straw boss would say, "you've got to step on it a little. You ain't gettin' out the work. Colored fella on the graveyard shift is gettin' out seventy blocks every hour—you're doing fifty."

"Ya-but—" he'd say. And then he'd get off a bunch of excuses. Always he could think of excuses. Always he'd start off the same way. "Ya-but—de oddas got hoists to lift de blocks op. I got to lift 'em myself. Allatime lift 'em myself," or, "Ya-but—de blocks vas so hot I couldn't stand putt my hands on 'em."

It got so, after a while, half the fellows called him "Old Ya-but." He was too old. He was too old for production but not too old for thinking up excuses for not doing the work faster and better. He had a one-speed brain and no gear-shift and once he made up his mind—no reverse. No wonder the bosses were always riding him—always right on his neck.

The machine that he worked on was a high-speed, five-way automatic drill that bored ninety-eight holes from five different directions into the cylinder block in the same operation. He put in a block and pushed the lever. Hydraulic clutches took hold; clusters of drills slid out and got to work on the iron-boring and drilling, cutting away the gray iron. Bright tungsten steel in hot clusters—cutting-speed seventy feet every minute—doing it all the day long, not complaining, not snapping off short under the heat and the strain; getting the holes where they belonged—not too deep, not too shallow—not too big, not too small, either. Getting them just right every time.

The operation done, the clusters of drills backed away; hydraulic clutches let go, and the machine pushed the block up and waited for Gus to come to, pull it off, and put on another. The machine did the work—the nice work—the hard work. Gus did the complaining.

"Ya-but," he'd say, "if I had a wooden floor to stand on. My feets all-a-time get tired. Ya-but—de soda water. Het makes my hands hurt." Always complaining. Always thinking up excuses for not being able to hold up his end of the job—not being able to keep up with the niggers.

Before coming to motor assembly Gus worked on the wrecking line. Old cars came into the plant from all over the country to be torn down and stripped and crushed and cut into slices and fed to the open hearth furnaces. Twenty-five dollars Mr. Holt paid for them. They came from Texas, Iowa, Indiana, Florida, Arizona—every state in the Union, every town in the country. On the trucks they came in—on the long double-deckers; on the lake boats; some under their own power—limping in through the gate, you'd see them—some with fenders that waggled, some with pieces of canvas tied over the tops, lamps busted. Not many ran on all cylinders.

On the wrecking line all the power tools ran in reverse—screwing nuts off instead of running them on. The wheels were removed; the engine heaved out; all glass saved; upholstery stripped—after which the conveyor dragged them onto the bed of a giant crusher. Here a piston came down and with one agonizing blow flattened the old cars into thin patches of scrap metal. And when the shears cut the patches into small strips, it was almost the end, except for the short ride on a belt to the furnaces.

In the wrecking department Gus had worked on the crusher. He had pulled the short lever that brought the huge piston down. One day, so they said, he had killed a man—the man who stripped out the upholstery. It had been just after lunch. The man had fallen asleep in the old car and had not awakened when the line started up. No one blamed Gus for the accident, though at the time, there had been an investigation, as a matter of course. Gus had been hauled up front. Still excited, he hadn't been able to say much and what he did say was probably the wrong thing. But he needn't have talked. It was probably one of those things that happen in factories. But since then he had got into the habit of thinking that he still had to clear himself of the blame to us. Kept thinking of all the things that he should have told the investigators at the time—things that he should have said and hadn't—things he'd got balled up on and got wrong, maybe. Generally he was pretty gloomy and silent. With his big cow-like eyes he'd sit there eating his lunch—not saying much—chewing a dry sandwich—looking down, blank eyes to the floor. Not hearing a thing the other fellows were saying. Lots of times I'd wonder what he was thinking about.

But just let one of the fellows bring up the accident and he was ready to talk, ready to explain how it happened. That he hadn't meant to do it, that it was none of his fault. And, I guess maybe it wasn't, but the more he talked and the harder he argued the worse he made it look for himself.

We were having lunch one day—Russ, Amos, Jerry and me and one or two other fellows sitting together, when Amos, who worked below Jeff on the line, got him started again, just to have fun. Amos was always kidding somebody that wasn't quite as smart as himself.

"Gus," he said, "you never told Russ, here, how that accident happened on the wrecking line. How you killed that fellow—that Irishman—and how they tried to put the blame onto you. Of course, we all know you didn't do it—didn't do it on purpose, that is. But Russ, here—Russ' never heard the story from you. Why don't you tell it before somebody else does and gives him the wrong idea?"

"Sure," said Russ, "let 'er come. I guess I can stand it if the rest can."

Gus came out of a daydream and took notice.

"Vell, I can tell you vun t'ing," he said. "I didn't done it on purpose. So shure I sit hier, I didn't know he vas in die old car. If I know he vas in dar, I vould not have killed heem."

"Of course not," said Amos. "You didn't know he was in the old bus. But at the same time—I guess he had it coming to him, didn't he, Gus? All the time running down the Hollanders and bragging up the Irish, wasn't he?"

"Ja," said Gus. "He vas all de time bodthering me. "'Tis I-don't-care-to-me a fellow bodthers me ven I'm not vorking. But ven I vork, I don't like bodthering—all de time bodthering."

"How did he bother you?" said Russ.

"Vell, you see, he vas de last man on de line—hexcept me. He pooled de stuffings out de old cars. All kinds tings he found in de old cars. Under de cussions—in de side-pockats—in de upholstrie. Some t'ings vas goot tings; some t'ings vas not goot. Some t'ings vas maybe in de old cars en long time. Stuck avay, maybe, by spooners. On a dak road at night. Somebody is coming, maybe. Some t'ings is—stuck avay in a hurrie. Alvays does t'ings he found. Goot t'ings—bad t'ings. Vomen's pajamas, elastics, safety pins, lipsticks, old cigarettes, Sunday school papers, snooze boxes, bottle-openers, playing cads, old viskey bottles. Vun time a half stick dynamite in a side pockat.

"De line—he vas not so fas'—like dis vun. De Irisher talked to me. To de oddas.

" "Hil? he say. 'Look vat I found in dis car. 'Tis en car van en Dutsman—en Hollander's car. De register card has on it a Duts name.'

"Den he vould hold op a voman's chemise, maybe. And all de oddas vould laugh me out. Alvays, if he found somet'ing bad—it was a Duts car. But joost ven he found somet'ing goot—it was en Irisman's card. Iris name on de card, or somet'ing.

" 'Look,' he vould say, and hold op maybe a Bible. All de oddas vould look.

" Ya,' dey vould say, 'de Iris is goot peoples—Iris is nice! Hokay de Iris!' And gif me vunce more de laugh.

"First, I dun't care. En den I get en little bit med. En den I get medder and medder. By'nby I'm so med I can get. But joost de same—I no kill heem."

"Of course not," said Amos. "I don't see how you held yourself in. A man can stand just so much of that kind of thing."

"All-a-time I'm de vun vats hokay. I'm lifing goot, going early to bed, standing up early, vorking hard every day. En de Irisher—he's out every night, runnin' round vit all kinds vomens. Vunce, vid his Sunday clothes on, he came in de factory. All de whool night he vas out—tomcettin' around. En den vun day—on a Monday—it heppened. Maybe de whool night he vas out again. Noon time, de line vas shut down. I eat my lunsch. I dun't see heem de whool time. I t'ink might-be he's gone out, maybe. Might-be he's telefunning. Same as alvays—de line stats again. En old car

moves up on de block. I pool de lever. De big piston comes down. En ven it moves op again—I see bloed. I see all oever—bloed."

"Flatter'n a pan-cake, eh, Gus?"

"Shure."

"Too much runnin' around Sunday night. Vent to sleep in the old bus, eh?"

"Hexactly. I couedn't halp he vas in dar, in die old car. De boss say to me—'Ven die old car he's op on die block—pool die lever.' I pool heem."

"How'd they pick him up?" said Russ.

"Putty knifes and blow torches. A thousand tuns came don on heem."

"Too bad," said Amos, "have to go through something like that. Must-a been a pretty bad sehock—see all that blood."

"Het vas awful," said Gus. "Het vas joost awful. De whool afternoon—I couedn't vork. En de next morning—I couedn't. Ven I vas tryin' to raise my arm to pool de lever—I couedn't raise heem. My whool arm—he vas paraliced op to de schoulder. He vas stief."

"So you got a transfer?" said Russ.

"Ya-but—my arm, he's not rite. Sometimes he bodthers me yet. Ven production is fast en all time de boss he comes op to me en he say, 'Vat's de madther, Gus; can't you stap on it? Can't you keep op? You vant I should gif you a transfer to blue mass production?' Times like dat—my arm he bodthers me yet. He gets stief. Sometimes I hardly can raise heem to poosh de lever on de macheen."

"That's hard to figure," said Amos. "Sounds like your conscience was bothering you. You didn't kill the guy—not on purpose. Did you?"

"Shure not. De boss say to me, 'Ven die cars come op on die block—pool die lever.' En now—sometimes ven I poosh die lever on de drilling macheen en de boss he's all time make me go fast—I see bloed. De soda vater on de hot drills gets first pink—en den red. En I t'ink—vot ef it's somebody in de macheen! Vot ef de drills go eento heem! Ento hes head—eyes—stomack—all over, eento heem. Vot ef it's bloed—ef I kill! Den my arm he gets stief en I go to de toilet. Ven I come beck—de soda vater he's vhite again. My arm—he's hokay."

"That proves you're not guilty," said Amos. "White stands for innocence."

"Ya-but," said Gus, "sometimes het' s red."

Jerry got up—mad.

"What are you trying to do?" he asked Amos. "Make the poor guy miserable? Trying to make him crack up?"

"Naw," said Amos. "Just trying to kid him."

Gus blinked a couple of times. Looked from one to the other. He was too dumb to catch on.

The bell rang and we all went to work.

# CHAPTER XVIII

ONE DAY WHEN THERE WAS A HEAVY SCHEDULE AND THE BOSSES WERE RIDING THE BUGGIES, trying to get out production, Russ got into trouble. A couple of times in the morning he started dragging over into Jeff's station, interfering with Jeff—still trying to get the nuts on when Jeff should have been running them down. This put Jeff behind on his operation and he crowded Amos, and Amos put up a loud squawk.

Amos didn't like to be crowded. It interfered with a crazy notion he had.

The cotter pins that Amos inserted went in from any one of six different directions. The nuts were castellated with six points and the pins were inserted between the points and through the holes in the bolts. Nearly always one of the holes would be lined up with the points and it didn't matter which hole was used, or from which direction the pins were inserted—just so they were in, just so the nut was locked on the bolt. And that's the way he did his work on all the rods—all except number one. On number one rod the pins had to go in just so. They had to go in parallel to each other and heads to the front of the motor. Every motor. It was a crazy notion—a kind of game he played with himself. It made a lot of extra work—a lot of extra fiddling around to get the nuts right. The holes might be all lined up for the pins to go in crossways, or at an angle. It didn't matter. He fooled around with the nuts until the pins would go in parallel. Getting those two in was more work than all six of the others. But it didn't make any difference to him. He had to do it his own nutty way. If you asked him why, he looked foolish and said that he had to leave his mark on the motors. To skip one, to let one go by without leaving his mark, bothered him all day. It made him nervous. And when Jeff got behind because of Russ, didn't get the nuts down in time, it crowded Amos. It didn't leave him time enough for his foolishness and he would put up a squawk to Norman. I'd have to jump in and help Russ. Get everybody up where they belonged.

Twice in the morning it happened, and then again after lunch.

"Russ," I said, "what's the matter with you? You're not snapping into it. You ain't balling the jack today. What's the matter?"

"Bennie," he said, "I've been thinking. I've been thinking about what I'm gonna call that kid when he comes. I'm gonna call him 'Bennie'—after you. What'd you think about that?"

"That's swell," I said. "That's swell, Russ. But right now—we're building motors. What's the reason you're gettin' behind all the time?"

"And another thing, Bennie," he said. "When do you suppose we'll be pulling outa here?"

"When the bell rings, of course."

"No—no—I mean, leave the factory. Start clamming. I've got a way figured out to make a cradle. Take some ropes—hang it under a tree. And when he gets bigger we can make a place for him up front in the boat. Take ; him out on the water. I've been thinking about it all morning."

I had him up again.

"All right," I said. "I've got you back in your station. Better think about the job for a while."

I stepped back. Thought I'd watch him a while.

Everybody was snapping into it—keeping time with the beat of the machines. Blue smoke hung like a low fog over the hot automatics. The line was fast, all right, but not too fast for Russ if he put himself into it.

For a while he held his place fine. Then he started slipping again—losing ground. Every motor carried him back an inch or two and pretty soon he was over the line in Jeff's station again. He wasn't trying. He was taking it easy; going along in an absent-minded way—taking up a handful of nuts in loose fingers—starting them on with long, easy motions. Working as though the motor he was on would be the last to come over. I had to help him again.

"It's the last time," I said, stepping in. "After this—it's up to you. Norman's bellyaching to beat the band—me helping you all the time. Five or six fellows want relief."

"That's too bad," he said. "But I'm glad you're back. I wanted to ask you, how old does a kid have to be, generally, before he starts saying words? I don't mean talking—I mean saying short words like 'Daddy,' for instance. There's an awful lot I don't know about kids. When a man knows he's gonna be a father it sets him thinking. He thinks about a lot of things he's never thought about before. What kind of songs, for instance, does a fellow sing when he's putting a kid to sleep after supper? That's one I'll bet you never thought about yet."

"No, by Judast," I said, "I sure ain't. And neither has nobody else when they're working on the line—trying to get out production. You're daydreaming, Russ. That's what's the matter with you."

"What do you mean—daydreaming?" he said.

"You're just not there. Your mind's not on the job."

"Doesn't have to be. I don't need my mind for the job. All I need is two fingers. I've got it down to four motions. I keep time with that belt up there. I do it this way—see: ONE—two—THREE—four. Two heavy beats. Two light ones. Do it over and over—without thinking."

Overhead, attached to the ceiling, there was a ventilator fan driven by an electric motor and a long belt with four metal splices. The splices made a clicking sound as they passed over the steel pulley. Not loud—not as loud as the noise from the automatics. Not as fast either. But the sound was very distinct, once you noticed it.

I stood beside him—looked on. A helper meets up with some crazy ideas on the line, but this was the nuttiest I'd ever run into.

"Notice how I keep time," he said. "Do it with my eyes shut, if I wanted to. ONE—I pick up the nut; two—I set it on the end of the bolt; THREE—I give it a twist; four—I move my hand back for another. Nothing to it. Once I get into the swing I don't have to think about the job. ONE—two—THREE—four— Don't have to give it any attention. Swing along with it."

"You'd better start giving it a little attention," I said. "Better start right now. Snap out of it, Russ. That motor's not synchronized with the line."

"If I don't miss any beats," he said, "do three hundred and twenty an hour. And I haven't missed any all morning and yet you're bellyaching about me holding up the line. Last week I missed some and there wasn't a squawk outa nobody."

"The line's faster today. That motor up there runs the same speed all the time. Get the noise outa your system. Break away from it. Concentrate on the automatics."

"On the automatics? That's what I want to get away from. They interfere with my thinking."

"You're not getting paid here for thinking. You're getting paid for getting the work out."

"I'm not thinking about the work."

"You're not getting the work out, either. The others are laying into it, giving her all they got. Why can't you?"

"I'm doing one man's work—and a little more."

"Listen, Russ," I said. "It don't make no difference to me how much you loaf on this job—it's none of my business. I'm not the boss. Only thing is—I promised Rita I'd see you got along. I don't want to see you get fired. But you're bucking the line—that's what you're doing right now. And you can't get away with it. Others have tried it and they only lasted about three days. Once the line bosses figure you're not trying—you're gone. It's not like it was in the drop forge. They don't have to send to Cleveland to get somebody to step into your job. There's plenty fellows waiting, right out there by the gate. Ready to step into your place."

"Q-keh," he said. "Now you've got your little sermon off-a your chest—run along. Don't worry."

Just the same, I was worried. I didn't want Norman to think we were buddies. I didn't want Russ to get fired, either. I spoke to Jeff on the quiet.

"Jeff," I said, "Russ ain't feeling so hot today. If he gets behind give him a lift. Slip on a couple-a nuts for him once in a while, if you can."

"Sure."

Good old Jeff. The niggers never give us helpers no trouble.

Then, as I turned to go, I heard that bloody belt up there again, going: ONE—two—THREE—four— I heard it that time without listening for it. Heard it above all the noises. Russ would be hearing it, too. It would be getting into his system—drowning out the automatics—the fast time of the machines that were keeping step with the line. It would be there above his head all the time. Going slow. Going—ONE—two—THREE—four—Two heavy beats. Two light ones. I couldn't get away from it.

All that afternoon the bosses were riding the buggies; all that afternoon Russ was dragging over, not quite holding his own. He wasn't worried. The others were feeling the strain—laying into it. But not him. He was taking it easy. Something had to be done. I talked to Norman.

"Norm," I said, "I guess you'd better take Russ for one of them little walks. Like you did me when I first came to work here. It made a Holt man outa me—maybe it'll help him. He's dragging over—getting behind all the time."

"What's the matter," he said, "bucking the line, is he?"

"He's not bucking it," I said. "Just not hitting the ball, that's all."

"You ain't tryin' to kid me, are you?" he said. "You fellows ain't buddies, are you?"

"Cripes, no," I said. "If we was buddies I wouldn't be giving you the low-down. I wouldn't be telling on him, would I?"

"You ain't telling me nothing," he said. "What you think I use my eyes for? All day he's been gettin' behind. Half the time you're over there chewing the rag, helping him. Only thing is—if he's bucking the line—doing it a-purpose, I wanna know. I wancha to tell me. I'll pull his card for him."

"You know me, Norm," I said. "I've always worked with you, ain't I? He'll snap outa it. He's trying to save up. Wife's gonna have a kid, so I hear."

"No funny ideas—about unions? Ain't red? Don't belong to C.I.O.—nothing like that?"

"Never said nothing to me."

"Q-keh," said Norman. "Get back on the job."

Nothing more happened that afternoon, but that night, walking home, I had another talk with Russ.

"Russ," I said, "you either got to snap into it or else you might's well start looking yourself up another job right now. Timing yourself with that belt was a dumb stunt. Once that one-two-three-four business gets ahold of you, you'll never get away from it. You're sunk. Might work all right when the line's slow, but the minute it speeds up—you're in trouble."

"The line's never slow," he cut in. "Ever stop to think about that?"

"I know, but that's a non-variable speed motor up there on the ceiling. It's not timed with the job; it's not synchronized with the line motors. It goes along up there all by itself—same speed all the time. The line speeds up—you don't."

"I could, Bennie," he said. "I could put myself under a strain and speed up and get out four hundred motors an hour if I wanted to."

"Why don't you?"

"Why should I? I'm not getting paid for working that hard. I don't want to work that hard for five dollars. I don't want to be nervous and unstrung when I get home at night. I don't want to feel mean and dragged out like I did first when I was under a strain learning the job. I don't want to tear around, drink booze, and fight with my wife like most of the other fellows that work on the line. If the line's too fast—let 'em cut down production, or give us more to get the work out. If I get behind it's not because I'm laying down on the job. It's their hard luck—not mine."

"Yours—if you get fired."

"Why should I get fired? They fire a man for not doing his work. I'm doing mine. I'm starting as many nuts as any two men you could put on that job tomorrow. On that job I'm an expert. It looks like I'm loafing. I'm not. I've got it down to a science. I make every move count."

"Yes, but you're holding back the others."

"Forget about the others. That's not what we're talking about, is it? How fast should I go? How many motors an hour? Two-ninety? Three hundred? All right, say three hundred. That's two thousand four hundred a day for five dollars. Well, I'm doing three hundred and twenty an hour when I'm going along with that belt. I know. I've counted. The others don't know and the bosses are scared to death they'll find out. Sometimes the line's fast—sometimes it's faster. That's all the men know. If they knew any more—if they knew every time the superintendent screwed up the rheostat another notch when they were already breaking their necks to get out production, the whole system would break down."

"And then we'd be out of jobs."

"Out of Holt jobs. But there would be other automobiles. Other jobs. And most important for us, Bennie—other systems."

"But you can't buck the system."

"I don't want to," he said. "All I want to do is to save up enough money to get away from the system."

"Then you'll have to hold that job for a while. And that means you'll have to get away from that belt. It all comes to the same thing. Maybe we'd better see the Polack. See if he'll trade you. Give him a little bonus if we have to."

"Nix," he said. "I'll stay where I am. When we get back to working full weeks Ill be saving money again."

"But that belt, Russ. It's got you stymied. The noise gets into your system and you drift along with it and then you start daydreaming. I've seen others. When the line's fast it's the noise from the automatics that carries you along; that keeps you in step with the others."

"On the job I got now," he said, "Mr. Holt's not paying me for the use of my brains. It's not like it was in the drop forge. I'll go along like I am. I'll do Mr. Holt's work—give him a little extra. And I'll use my brains to do my own private thinking."

He was a long ways yet from being a Holt worker.

# CHAPTER XIX

The next day the line was fast again. First thing in the morning Russ started dragging over, getting behind, crowding the others. I jumped in twice and got him back in his station. Jeff helped a little but it didn't do no good. Just before lunch Norman jumped on him. I wasn't there to hear what was said.

After lunch it was the same. Russ taking it easy, the others hitting the ball—laying into it.

Times like that there's a real snap to the line. Makes you feel good just to be there—to be a part of it and know you're doing your share of the work—making your share of the noise. Power wrenches pop and cut off quick; the pf-f-ft, pf-f-ft of air hoses is sharp; the short bursts of the pneumatic hammers stab through the noise like a racketeer's gun. No leading up to it—no fumbling around to get started. Slam into it—get it done—grab another before it gets past.

Times like that, one man can hold up production in the whole department. He can slow down the work of two thousand others. One man hanging back is all that prevents the superintendent from screwing up the rheostat another notch—cutting off another two or three seconds—stepping up production five or six motors an hour.

Forty minutes before the quitting bell rang, Norman came up.

"Come with me," he said. "I want you to take your chum's place for a while."

We went up to Russ. He was behind again—across the line in Jeff's station. I jumped in.

"Didn't do no good—me talking to you this morning, did it?" said Norman.

"No harm, either," said Russ. "Seems to me I'm doing pretty good."

"Not good enough," said Norman. "Don't look to me like you're trying."

"I've been doing three-twenty an hour—right steady. That's better than I did last week."

"How do you know you're doing three-twenty an hour? You got time to stand there and count motors? Other fellows ain't. Maybe that's why you're gettin' behind all the time. Maybe that's why you ain't keeping up."

"I don't have to stop work to count them," said Russ.

"How do you know then how fast they're coming over? Other fellows don't. I don't even, myself."

Russ didn't answer. Didn't say anything about the belt, though all the time they were arguing, his hands were keeping slow time with it. Norman didn't catch on to the situation, though to me, it was as plain as a fellow keeping step with a drum.

"Come on," said Norman, "me'n you's gonna take a walk." Russ dropped out and they left.

It was all I could do to hold the job down, even with Jeff's help. Helpers never get as expert on an operation as the regular men. They don't get to practice enough on one job. On some operations that are real tricky it takes two, three, and even four helpers to hold the job down while the regular man takes his three minutes off. Russ' job was tricky enough to call for two, and here Norman was leaving me to do it alone, and the line extra fast. Besides, there was the belt going ONE—two—THREE—four— Two heavy beats—two light—trying to keep in time with my movements, trying to slow me down. I broke away from it. I thought about something else—about the time, four-five years ago, when I first came to work in motor assembly; when I got behind and Norm took me for a walk. It was his favorite way of making a man snap into it, making him appreciate his job.

I thought about Norman and Russ—about what they were doing. Now they'd be outside, walking past the blast furnaces, Norman not saying anything—a little ahead—Russ wondering what it was all about. But not asking. On these walks Norman always wanted it to be a surprise. Then across the railroad tracks and along the side of the glass factory—past the loading platforms and into final assembly where they put the blue cars together. "Blue mass" the men called it. Here, where they put on the fenders, Norman would stop. Here where they really work. Where they pinch fingers and cut hands on the sharp metal. Where they bend down and stoop and look under and half stand on their heads—where it's a struggle all the time to get the bolt holes lined up. Where the holes are never just right and a perfect fit is something to wonder about and it's a fight all the while against time—against the little seconds that slip by and never wait for you to catch up.

One fellow that worked there had lost both his legs in an accident. He shot over the floor in between the legs of the men on a scooter. He worked under the cars, starting nuts on fender bolts, and hooked his scooter to the chassis and rode along beneath the car while doing his work. The job done, he unhooked, shot back and hooked onto another. The visitors never failed to "Oh" and "Ah" at the fellow, because he was as clever as could be, and the guides used his case to show the visitors how well the Company took care of the men who got hurt in the factory; the scooter, with nickel plated wheels and ball-bearings, having been made especially for him. On the opposite side of the line was a man doing the same kind of work, but he was not nearly so fast, nor so expert, because his legs were just so much extra weight to push around on the scooter, and, besides, they were always in the way and getting tangled up in the gear such as light cords and air hoses.

"How would you like to work here?" Norman would say.

"Not so good."

"Makes your job look pretty sweet, don't it?"

Then they'd walk again, past the rolling mills and the foundry and into the power house. Up the long stairs. There they'd stand in front of the big plate glass and look out.

"Stand over here," Norman would say.

There, below, would be the steel gate and the big guard, the ex-fighter, who filled the narrow lane with his shoulders. Back from the street, at the end of the narrow passage, the employment office—a little building all by itself. Fifty-sixty men would be standing there outside the high fence, some of them lined up, some with fingers hooked in the wires, faces against the iron fence—waiting to get in—eager to get jobs—hoping for a chance to earn their five bucks a day. Most of them would be mighty proud to have a Holt badge pinned to their shirts.

"See all those fellows out there?" Norman would say. "Plenty of good men out there. Every man there's wait-ting for a chance to step into your shoes."

Norman wasn't much of a talker. He wouldn't say very much. He wouldn't have to. Most generally the fellows he took for these walks didn't have any trouble at all getting the point. The whole story was there.

It was four-thirty when they got back to motor assembly. The bell rang and I met Russ at the clock and we went out and grabbed us a street car. For a wonder we didn't have to stand up.

"Well," I said, "what happened?"

He laughed a dry laugh and looked out of the window and said nothing until the aisle was packed and the car started. Then he began talking.

"He walked me all over the place," he began. "Took me to see the fellows work on blue mass. And then to the power house and we climbed four flights of stairs—long ones. There he stood me in front of a window and had me look out. Down below was the gate to the employment office and a long string of men trying to get in.

" 'See all those fellows?' he said. "They're just waiting to step into your job.'

"'That what you brought me all the way up here for?' I asked him. 'To see that?'

"'Yeh,' he said. 'Kinda makes you think, don't it?'

"Sure does,' I said. 'Makes me think plenty. For one thing—it makes me think I've been wanting to ask you for a raise. How about it?'

"For five minutes he stood there sputtering like a steam engine with a busted cylinder head full of cold water. Too bad he can't talk."

"Then what?"

"Then I lit into him.

"'How do you expect me to take care of a job,' I said, 'me worrying all the time trying to figure out how to get along on my lousy wages? If you want me to work faster—give me a raise. See what happens. Don't parade me all over the place—make me climb stairs to look at a bunch of poor bas-

tards starving to death—worse off than I am. Do a thing like that in a lumber camp, I'd hate to think what would happen to you—or how quick.'

"All of a sudden he was in a hurry to get back.

"'You're gonna listen to me," I told him. "You're gonna listen to my side of the talk. I've got a family. I've got to pay rent and buy groceries. What I'm getting won't do it—no matter how much I worry. I'm giving you value for the wages I'm getting. If you want me to work harder, give me more money, more time. Give me enough so I won't have to dig into my savings to keep going. Enough so I won't have to worry about what's gonna happen when the little money I got saved up is gone, so I'll be able to pay the doctor when the kid comes. Don't take me up here and try to throw a scare into me by showing me a bunch of poor fellows starving to death. I've got worries enough. I don't want any more. Understand?'

He stood there and whimpered like a sick pup.

"'I can't help it,' he said, 'if I have to step on you. I gotta get out production. They're jumping on me all the time. If my section falls down—it's my job. They'll give me the gate.'"

I saw how it was. All of a sudden I was sorry for him. Mr. Holt jumps on the general manager; the general manager jumps on the superintendent; the superintendent jumps on Norman; Norman has to take it out on us. We're the butt-end of the system. Norman is just a cog in the same gear-cutter that's working on us. He's not very important. Not very powerful. He's taking the dirt from those above him—I saw it all. He couldn't even get the raise because I'm getting the same as the others.

"'Come on,' I said to Norman, 'I've got nothing against you—personally. I lost my temper. You and me—I guess we're just a couple of dice in the same shaker.'

"On the way back we got to talking about things. Not business, nothing that had to do with the factory. Just this and that—where he lives and what he did before he came to Detroit. He's got a kid about a year old. And what kind of songs do you suppose he sings when he puts him to sleep after supper?"

"I don't know."

"Cowboy songs, he told me. 'Little Buckaroo' is his favorite. I'm gonna learn it. He told me where I could get the words and music."

# CHAPTER XX

In the morning there was a rumor in the factory that Mr. Holt was going to shut down. Men were ganged up in the aisles and around the time clocks and when the bell rang not more than half of them were in their places.

The line got off to a sloppy start and in less than two minutes shut down. The superintendent himself pulled the switch and when he saw how things were he rallied all the straw bosses around.

"Any man," he hollered, "not in his place when the line starts will go home."

Straw bosses began slinging out orders; us helpers stood in shoulder to shoulder with the men, and line bosses climbed up on the buggies. The line started again but there was no speed and no snap. The men bunched up to talk and swap gossip. Rumors were all over the shop.

The superintendent threw in more speed, thinking he could force the men to tend to their work and cut out the talk, but the whole bunch from one end of the line to the other started dragging over. Norm got us helpers together. He was pretty burned up and excited.

"Listen," he said, "it's getttin' serious. If it gets any worse the boss is gonna send everybody home. I want you fellas to do what you can to help put it down. No relief, see? No going to toilets. Circulate around. Hear what they're talking about. Find out who started this talk—I wanna know."

"Cripes, Norm," I said, "we can't find out who started it. It got started on the graveyard—last night. It was going strong when we got here—it's all through the shop."

"All through the shop?" he said. "How do you know it's all through the shop? You sound like you been helping to talk it up, too."

"I ain't been talking it up," I said. "I been trying to help put it down."

"How you know, then, it's all through the shop?"

"Well," I said, "starters ain't been coming through like they oughta. Half the motors is coming off the line without starters—that's what they tell me. That shows something is haywire in the starter department, don't it?"

"Listen," he said, "you ain't gettin' paid for checking up on the starter department. It's listening to that kind of talk that gets things started like this. Get busy here. Do what I said—understand?"

He tore off. There was plenty to keep Norman busy.

When the line goes haywire and wild talk spreads all through the shop—times like that us helpers can do more to get things straightened out and running smoothly again than the bosses. The bosses—even the straw bosses—are on the other side of the fence, but the men figure that us helpers belong to the gang. A helper, if he uses sense and is careful not to let the men think he's a stool, can find out what the men are thinking and talking about, but the minute a straw boss sticks his neck into a conversation the men shut up like a clam.

The men were bunched up in Jeff's station. Jerry was dragging over; Amos was too far ahead and right under Jeff's elbow. Russ, on the opposite side of the line, was getting along fine because production was only about half as fast as it should have been. I squeezed in.

"Come on, fellows," I said, "let's break it up now. The big boss is gonna send us all home if we don't snap into it. There's nothing to it—this talk about shutting down."

"Oh yea-a-aah?" said Jerry. "How do you get that way, wise guy? I just heard they shut down the blast furnace."

"Times like this," I said, "you're liable to hear anything. You know how it is."

"Yeah, we sure do," he said. "What you're trying to give us is a lotta bull. I'd go easy with that kind of talk here if I was you."

"If you don't think we're gonna shut down," said Amos, "maybe you'd like to buy a used car cheap. Only three more payments against it. I'll let you have it for half what I paid for it."

"An' I's gwine lose my radio," said Jeff. "I ain't gwine make no payments no mo'. I's gwine write them they radio ge'mens a letter. I's gwine say, 'Heah's yo radio, ge'men. Come get it.'"

It was easy to see that I couldn't get anywhere with Norm's idea. It was too late. The talk about laying off was more than a rumor. The conversations turned into discussions about ways and means of getting by cheaply; of stalling landlords and hanging onto the last cent of cash. The young fellows schemed and cussed loudly but the older men who were married looked serious and listened and kept their mouths shut. They were still afraid of the bosses.

In the afternoon things got even worse. About two-thirty, generators stopped coming through and we heard that the men from the generator department had been sent home. Half the buggies in the line were empties and the men started dropping out, going to the toilets, without asking permission. In doing this one fellow did the work of the man next to him as well as his own. When the first man got back they changed places. This kept the line at less than half speed, and yet us helpers were swamped. The line bosses shouted and ran back and fourth across empty buggies but they had no control over the men. The quality of the work was something fierce. A third of the motors, it seemed, were rejected and on the "tear down" line where the motors that failed to pass

final inspection were taken apart and the pieces put back on the conveyors and where all power tools ran in reverse, motors were stacked high on the floor and there was a lot of confusion.

I circulated around. The toilet opposite our section was jammed and all sorts of wild tales were going the rounds. Amos, who always managed to do more than his share to get rumors started, was telling everybody that Mr. Holt was going to fire every man in the shop and that he was going to hire back only the Arkansawyers and niggers. Russian Bill was burned up because someone had told him that the whole plant was being moved to Grand Rapids because Mr. Holt wished to get away from the labor agitators who were making things bad in Detroit. One fellow who claimed his uncle worked in the front office and got all the big dope said that Mr. Holt was getting ready to come out with a Diesel car and that the plant would be closed up tight for a year.

Jerry was standing on the edge of a toilet seat looking out of a window.

"They got her shut down," he hollered. ""There'll be no more cylinder blocks coming through."

"Got what shut down?" someone yelled.

"The blast furnace," said Jerry. "They're running off the slag. There's a couple of H.P.'s out there—looking on."

Norm stuck his head through the door. He saw me.

"Aw, come on down off-a there," I said to Jerry. "Why don't you get on the job? Us helpers are swamped."

Jerry got down and a few of the fellows went out and Norm pushed his way in. He had a pretty dark look on his face and I thought he was going to say something but he kept his mouth shut, which was good judgment, because some of the fellows were itching to get into an argument, not caring now whether they got fired or not.

Russian Bill, who had a wife and four kids, muscled his way up to Norm.

"How about it?" he said. "Do we get laid off—or not?"

"How do I know?" said Norm. "They ain't told me nothing about it."

"Yeah—and if you did know something about it," said Russian Bill, "you wouldn't have the nerve to tell us. I'll bet you got the lay-off notices right there in your pocket."

"I ain't got the time to argue with you," said Norm, and tore out. Russian Bill laughed.

Towards the end of the shift things got even more disorganized. Two thirds of the buggies were empties and fellows began visiting about on the line, or went around trying to get tools they had loaned out to someone else. These would have to be turned in. There were accidents up in the front end of the shop where the men worked at the high speed machines. Three or four times during the afternoon the high-wheeled hospital cart raced down the aisle. In fifteen or twenty minutes it would return, hauling a man stretched out on his back and a pair of oily shoes sticking out from beneath the end of the white covering. A short time later stories would begin circulating around

about what had happened but you never knew from these whether the man had actually got killed or not.

When the bell rang the notices were up near the clocks. No one was the least bit surprised. There was no definite time set for coming back and we were told to get our money on Friday.

Russ and I checked out and left. He seemed not at all downhearted.

"Well," he said, as we passed out of the gate, "that's that, I'll never go back—except to get the money Mr. Holt owes me. We should have got out before—but we didn't have the nerve. Tomorrow we'll step out and get us a couple of real jobs."

"Lots of other fellows will be thinking the same thing," I said. "Some of us that's been through it before won't be as optimistic as you are."

"Any time I feel like working," he said, "I work. I've always been able to get a job when I wanted one. All this talk you hear around the country about men wanting work and not being able to get it—most of that's pure bunk."

"Ever try to get a job," I asked, "in a town where thirty-forty thousand fellows have been laid off in one crack?"

"No."

"Well, tomorrow," I said, "you'll have a chance to see what it's like. Mr. Holt's shut-down is just the start. Tomorrow other outfits—stores and factories and barber shops and transportation companies will be laying off men left and right. They'll figure every way to cut overhead and they'll sit tight until Mr. Holt opens up again. I read once where the street-car company alone loses twenty-two thousand bucks a day when Mr. Holt closes down. Other outfits lose money, too. So they all draw up their belts and sit tight. That's what we'll do, if we're smart."

"That's all wrong, Bennie," he said. "We'll use our heads. The other fellows will be resting for a couple of days before getting out. We'll get out early tomorrow—make the rounds of the factories."

"Sounds good, Russ, but I've been through it before. We'll be off three or four months, and when we get on again, we'll be back on the line—building motors."

"Not me. I've had enough of that job. In fact, I've had a little too much. The only time I'll ever go back there will be Friday when I draw my last pay."

"When you draw it," I said, "you'd better leave the five bucks with Mr. Holt and hang onto your badge for dear life. As long as you've got your badge—you're on the pay roll."

"As long as I've got the badge," he said, "Mr. Holt's got my five bucks. When I go back to get my dough, I get all of it."

That was the way that he felt. But during the next few days things happened that made him take my advice.

# CHAPTER XXI

Early the next morning Russ and I were making the rounds of the factories. But it was like I told him—they were laying men off instead of hiring. With Mr. Holt closed down, the other companies were expecting a slump. The public would hold off buying cars until it had a chance to see what Mr. Holt was going to bring out. It was not unusual for Mr. Holt to hold up his new model until after the auto shows because that way he got all the publicity to himself. According to the talk that was going the rounds, he would stay closed until January. If you listened to the talk of the men you got a pretty good idea of how much you had to pull your belt in.

At one of the big factories we couldn't even get close to the gate—and if we had it wouldn't have done any good because it was locked. There wasn't even a man at the gate to encourage the men in hanging around and yet the men filled the sidewalk and overflowed out into the street. They sat in small groups on the curbs. They were not badly behaved—only sort of dull and dragged out, with hands that looked unnaturally helpless and empty. Not one expected to get in or be hired and yet they hung around, waiting for some wonder to happen.

If the gates had opened to let one man in, the crowd would have turned into a mob. There would have been a riot. At Mr. Holt's plant the crowds are never allowed to get large. If more than fifty collect at any one time the H.P.'s come out and herd the whole bunch down the street. Big crowds hanging around employment gates are dangerous.

Russ and I circulated around through the crowd. It was a new experience for him. As usual, there were a lot of hot arguments going on and the talk was about everything except automobiles—about everything except the one thing they knew something about.

They stood around in groups talking excitedly about what was wrong with the country. A big Swede with bushy eyebrows who could hardly talk English said the country would go straight to the dogs unless all the niggers were shipped back to Africa. An old man with oil dermatitis sores on his arms was in favor of retiring Roosevelt on a pension and electing Townsend for president. One guy said that the country needed a bigger navy; another said that the country would never get over the bad effects of Prohibition—three percent beer was all right but it'd come back too late to

save the good ship from piling up on the rocks. The man waved his arms and threw a fine spray of spit over the heads of the men in the crowd, and when he paused a moment to get his breath someone stuck his head through the front ranks and shouted "Aw-w-w—nuts!" A little Italian with beady eyes and a black shirt said that what was needed was a dictator with nerve enough to lay down the law to Mr. Holt and run all the Russians out of town to the opposite side of Rouge River. Nobody agreed with anybody and everybody got into the arguments and worked themselves up into a sweat. Everyone, that is, except the niggers. They took it all in and grinned and kept their mouths shut and said nothing.

On the curb there was a crap game in progress between the niggers and whites and on the far edge of the crowd two fellows, one big and one little, were working a racket. The little fellow was wearing a straight jacket. He looked dumb and bewildered and said nothing. There was a rope tied around him and the big fellow, doing his best to collect dimes and nickels. He was the spieler and carried a bunch of ropes and chains with big padlocks on them.

"All right," he said, "I've got one-forty. 'Tain't enough for this act. A few more nickels and dimes and I'll let any man in the crowd here tie another rope on him. Tie him up tight—use any kind of knot—use any kind of language while you're doing it. If my deaf and dumb friend can't get loose—I'll let him lay in the gutter. I'll throw every cent back to the crowd."

He got a few more dimes and nickels. A big nigger stepped out of the crowd, took one of the ropes and wrapped it around the dummy's shoulders and arms. The dummy grunted and screwed up his face in make-believe pain.

The big fellow was not satisfied. He wanted more money.

"I got two dollars and five cents," he hollered. "I want three dollars. Three dollars and I'll let any man in the crowd tie up his legs. Tie him up tight—treat him rough—call him names if you wanna—see if I care. Yesterday he made me lose six dollars. Had to throw it all back to the crowd."

Once more he passed round the hat. The crowd began to take an interest in the dummy. The ropes were cutting his body. This time a white man with a rigger's belt round his side stepped out from the crowd.

"Gimme that rope," he cried. "Ill tie the son-of-a-bitch up. I'll tie him up so he'll stay tied."

He knew his stuff. He used knots as big as your fist. Wound the rope round the little fellow's knees and between his legs. The last knot he pulled tight—tight as all heck. He put his foot up against the little guy's hip and heaved with all of his might. When he finished the little fellow was all trussed up like an Egyptian mummy. His arms and legs were wrapped tight so that he could no longer walk.

And yet the big fellow was not satisfied. He was after more money. The men heckled the dummy and one or two who had paid out good money took pokes at him through the inner fringe of the crowd. It was good fun—exciting. The pot jumped to four dollars. Another rope was put on

—it was the last. The crowd yelled for chains and the big fellow raised the pot to five-forty. Six fellows stepped out of the crowd. An Arkansawyer threw in a quarter and settled the argument.

"Lemme at him," he said. "I'll tie the bastard. Ah hepped to string up a nigger back in Missouri. They had to let him down with a hack-saw."

He walked round and round the dummy, licking his lips, working himself up into a lather.

"I'll get this yere chain on so tight it ain't nevva gonna come off."

His elbows stuck out and his legs were bowed like a bantam rooster's. When he went to work the dummy squawked and bellered. He was better at making up faces than a professional wrestler. The Arkansawyer was rough, putting the loops of the chain where they hurt most—doing a good job—kicking the little fellow in the shins when he refused to stand still. It was as good as a sideshow at a circus.

At last all the ropes and chains were put on. The dummy's legs, arms and hands were covered. Three men laid him down in the gutter.

"And now if he can't free himself in two minutes," said the big fellow, "I'll throw all this chicken-feed into the crowd. If he gets out, I keep it. Get back! Give him room to work!"

The little fellow got busy. He grunted and struggled. He rolled and twisted his body around in the gutter. Pretty soon he had two fingers free. Then one hand and a wrist. Then the other hand came out from below. Knots melted. Chains slid over his head. The coils slipped off from his legs. He stood up. He was free and the time was less than two minutes. The big fellow picked up the gear and they slipped out of the crowd and left quickly.

Some of the fellows were still good and mad at the dummy. The Arkansawyer picked up a clod and fingered it sweetly. The nigger hollered an insult. Getting us mad at the dummy was a part of the scheme to get our nickels. It was a part of the racket.

As the two of them got to the corner of the big building, a block down the street, the little fellow turned and fanned his nose at us. "That goes for all of you," he hollered back at us. He wasn't a dummy. The rigger picked up a rock and then dropped it. It was too far.

# CHAPTER XXII

A WEEK AFTER THE LAY-OFF RUSS AND I WERE STILL LOOKING FOR JOBS. NOT THAT WE EXpected to have any luck, but there was nothing else for us to do. Besides, Mrs. Rettinelli, Rita's mother, had suddenly got interested in the coming of little Bennie and when she busted in about nine in the morning it was like trying to put up with a whirlwind in the house. We had to move out.

There was plenty Russ didn't know about having babies. He didn't exactly think that babies were pulled out of cabbages but at the same time, he was plenty ignorant. His education in that line had been, you might say, neglected.

Rita had long had her mind made up to go to the Holt hospital. She had heard that things were pretty slick there because Mr. Holt had carried out a lot of ideas there that he'd had a chance to work out and experiment with in the factory. The doctors punched clocks and wore badges the same as us fellows. Prices were the same for everybody—everybody went through the same system.

Rita had gone there for an examination to see if everything was all right. She had passed down the line from one doctor to another. She had told us about it. Every doctor had his own tools that were charged out to him—little jabbers and lights. Every doctor had his own little job and he did that and nothing else. They got to be experts, like us fellows. One had a hammer and tapped knees; one stuck a lamp down your throat and made you say "A-a-a-a-ah"; another checked your heart with an instrument that must have been something like those the men on final inspection use to test motors.

Both Rita and I thought the system was pretty slick but Russ made fun of it.

"From what I can figure out," he said, "Mr. Holt has got the system down so that it's practically automatic. When it comes to having babies all the women probably go in at one end and come out the other like the motors in motor assembly. Every doctor has his own little job on the line and when the women get to the end it's all over. There's probably a mechanical scrubber to run the new babies through—and someone to stamp on the numbers."

Lots of others had funny ideas about the Holt hospital. In the factory there was a story that once went the rounds. It was about a woman who had got on the maternity line by mistake. She wasn't even in a family way but when she got to the end of the line she had a baby the same as the others. But it was a mechanical baby—had a duo-tone finish and a mohair covering—everything but a spare tire and bumpers, and these are not standard equipment.

Russ had no idea, for instance, that a woman who was going to have a baby got funny notions about things and lost her temper easily; that she couldn't stand certain smells, like those that came from a gasoline motor under the bed. Mrs. Rettinelli could, having had seven babies herself, and so she put the motor under my bed and told Rita not to cook bacon for breakfast. You couldn't argue with her because when she didn't agree with what you were trying to say she couldn't understand a word of English, but she could talk a blue streak in Italian against you when taking Rita's side in an argument.

The preliminaries to getting that baby were complicated and strange. Mrs. Rettinelli warned Rita about taking long steps and told her never to hold her hands over her head. To drink black coffee was as bad as having a black cat around. Dogs were all right. There were dozens of things like being left alone when it thundered; frying liver; looking out of a window at lightning; watching a funeral go past, that left marks on babies. The sight of blood was especially bad and once when Russ cut his finger and Rita was tying it up the Old Lady came in and drove us both out of the house. She got the idea that whenever Russ pulled a boner, somehow I must have had a hand in it.

One morning when we were having breakfast, another argument got started. We had just sat down when Rita said to Russ:

"There's thirty-two dollars and fifty cents gone from the box in the drawer already. If you don't get a job pretty soon there's not going to be enough left for the hospital."

"Thirty-two dollars and fifty cents gone?" said Russ. "Where'd it all go to?"

At first it looked as if the money might have been stolen but after they figured a minute they both saw that it had been spent. Russ had paid out twelve and a half for rent; she had paid the water bill and bought groceries; Mrs. Rettinelli had taken a couple of dollars to buy baby clothes, and Russ had lost two dollars in a crap game with some niggers about which nothing was said. But it made them both sit up and take notice. Russ got downright excited.

"Cripes," he said, "here I've only been out of work a little more than a week and over thirty dollars is gone. That only leaves us about a hundred and ten bucks."

"And eighty of that," she said, "is going to pay doctor and hospital bills. I'm going to take it out and hide it somewhere. We're not going to touch it no matter what happens."

"That leaves us thirty."

"Until you get a job," she said. "Or else—until we go on relief."

"Never," he said. "There's gotta be work for me somewhere. I'll find it."

"Maybe."

He got up from the table.

"Thirty dollars," he said, "is enough to get us out of Detroit, if we leave now. It's nothing if we get stuck here and I can't find a job."

"Leave now?"

"Yeh, leave now," he said, "before we're dead broke."

"Where would we go?"

"Up north. I know lots of places. We could get us a cabin for a couple dollars a month. Get our wood for nothing. I could line out a string of traps and cut fence posts for the farmers. We could save up some dough."

"I'd die," she said. "And so would the baby. Suppose I had to have a doctor in a big hurry?"

"There are doctors up there. People have babies—even out in the sticks."

"Don't talk about it," she said. "It scares me—just to think about it."

"We've got to talk about it," he said. "Things are tough. Times are bad here in Detroit. Another month of laying around and our money will be gone. We'll be sunk. We've got to do something—now."

"Well—why don't you? Get a job. Get a job on the W.P.A. A pick and shovel won't hurt you."

"I can't. Don't you see? Carrying stones in a tin bucket—throwing dirt for some other W.P.A. worker to throw back again. That's putting in time—wasting money. I'm not built that way. I couldn't do it."

"Others do it."

"Tet erm."

He grabbed his hat and threw it down in a chair. And then stood looking out of the window. I tried to smooth things up.

"It's this way," I said to him. "This is not what you'd call a depression. It's only what us old-timers call a 'new model recession.' We've been through them before. Every year or so, it's the same thing. We get used to 'em. What I think we should do is to sit tight until Mr. Holt opens up. When Mr. Holt calls us back the old town will come to new life. We're on the pay roll; we've got our badges."

"And he's got our five bucks."

"That's all right. Knowing you've got a job is worth five bucks, ain't it?"

"Not when you can't work at it."

"It's this way, Russ. If we pull out now—leave Detroit—we're liable to be out of luck when the shop opens. We're liable to be out in the sticks when the fellows get notified to come back to work. Some other fellows would get our jobs on the line and we'd be shut out of luck."

"And so what?"

"And so we've got to be here. Got to stay close to the job."

"And starve."

"Not exactly. But we've got to tighten our belts. We've got to work things the way the others do. It's this way: this month you keep track of what it costs you to live. Next month you cut that in half. And the next month you spend half what you did the month before."

"And the month after that you live on nothing."

"You never get to that. We'll get called back to work. But what I was going to get to was this: I'm paying six dollars for board and room. Next month I won't be able to pay but five."

"That's o-keh."

"And after that, four, till we get work."

"That's o-keh, too."

"But I'll help rustle up things. Hunks of coal from along the tracks, and vegetables. When the cold weather comes we'll be able to get vegetables that are frozen a little. You can get them for just about nothing. Once you realize what you can save by using your head, and getting along on just a few dollars a month—it's fun. One thing—the rent's got to be cut right now."

"Fun, is it?" he said. "Fun to eat frozen vegetables. And it'll be fun, I suppose, to feed frozen stuff to the kid? And I'm the guy who used to kick like a steer about the food we ate in the camps."

He laughed.

"That's all right," he said. "I can take it. But the kid's not going to eat frozen vegetables. If I've got to steal—he's going to have the best there is. Come on. Get your hat. The last payment is due on the outboard. Let's get it over with."

"Russ," she said, getting up from the table. "Are you crazy?"

"We gotta pay it," he said, "or they'll take it back."

"But you can't. We need every penny to live—for hospital bills. Let them have it."

"Certainly not. It's the last payment. It's only five-forty."

"Only five-forty? That's enough to live on a week."

"I'm gonna pay it," he said.

She moved towards the door of the bedroom.

"Not if I can help it," she said. "I'll take every cent and hide it."

"You're too late. I've got the dough in my pocket. Bennie's board money."

"Hand it over," she said, coming towards him. "Give it to me. I do the cooking—I make the beds. Give it here."

"And lose the outboard —"

"Yes, lose it. Throw it away. Get rid of it. I'm sick and tired of having that thing in the house. I hate the sight of it; I hate the smell of it. I hate it—I hate it."

"Pipe down," he said. "What're you getting excited about? Where would we be next summer —clamming—without it?"

"Clamming," she said, walking around in circles, squeezing her apron. "Clamming—clamming—clamming—it's all you think of. It's all you talk about. I'm sick of it. Why don't you think

about your responsibilities?—your job?—your wife?—your baby that's coming? I don't want him to grow up a clammer."

"And I don't want him to grow up a Holt worker."

"I'm not going. If you can't settle down and be steady —"

"Steady! Man alive, how can I?"

"If you go clamming I'll leave you—get a job. I've been to high school. I've got an education. I'll sell lunches—work in the dance hall again—take care of the baby."

"And make a Holt worker outa him."

"Give me that money!"

"I'll not."

"Give it to me—it's mine. Give it to me, Russ—or get out."

"I'll get out."

"And stay out," she screamed. "Do you hear me?"

"Sure, I hear you. So do the neighbors."

She grabbed the bread knife and came towards him. He picked up his hat and backed towards the door.

"Give it to me," she yelled, "or I'll throw it. Hand it over, Russ."

The door flew open and Mrs. Rettinelli busted in.

She rushed up to Rita, took the knife, and threw both arms around her.

"Oh, Oh," she cried, "mia bambina—mia povera—mia povera bambina!"

She turned on Russ and me. Pointed at the door and sent us both out with a blast of strong-sounding Italian. We left—slunk out like a couple of tom-cats caught in the act of eating the family canary.

# CHAPTER XXIII

When we left the house and went down the street, Russ was pretty discouraged about things. The old town itself was not very cheerful. Fellows were hanging around in the barber shops and in the cheap eating joints reading, too broke to buy their own papers. One restaurant had ten or fifteen men hanging around and the waiter was sitting behind the counter on a high stool with nothing to do but look out of the window. Two street railway fellows were welding a rail and a whole gang of men with oily shoes stood watching.

"Let's bust outa here," said Russ. "Let's get us an old car and pull out—what say?"

"Think it over," I said. "I know how you feel now. But you'll feel different tonight. I'll put down the dough for the outboard this time and you can be owing me your half. When we get home give her the six bucks."

"I'm getting mighty fed up—her laying it into me. I'd keep a job if I had it. I'd be steady. But how's a man gonna be steady when he can't find nothing to do?"

"Women are funny," I said. "It's not your being out of a job—that's not what's a-bothering her. It's your attitude—your hating the factory. Any day, she figures, you're liable to pull out and there'll be no more pay checks. It's like Mr. Holt says in his book —"

"Cripes, Bennie," he busted out, "can't you forget Mr. Holt's book just this once. Why try to be funny? I'm serious."

"So'm I. I'm trying to show you how your wife feels about things—how I feel—Mr. Holt."

"I'm not interested in knowing how Mr. Holt feels."

"I told her I was going to go clamming. We talked it all over before we got married. She was crazy about it, thought it was fine. 'Cute' idea, she called it."

"That's before she was in a family way. Now the kid's coming. She's not thinking any more about having fun—having a good time for herself. She's already thinking about educating the kid. Sending him to Mr. Holt's school—making a straw boss outa him."

We came to a meat market and went in, thinking we might pick up an odd job. Russ talked to the manager who was behind the counter scraping a big chopping block.

"Many fellows asking for jobs?" Russ asked.

"Plenty."

"Some fellows ask for odd jobs, don't they?"

"Yeah—like sweeping the floors and stuff. But I can't do nothing for 'em. I can't even keep busy myself."

"Fellows real hard up, with families, would even take jobs just for a piece of beef, wouldn't they?" he asked.

"Sure they would. Little jobs, like delivering packages and stuff. But I got a kid."

We turned and walked out.

"What's the idea?" I said.

"The idea of what?"

"The idea of stringing out a lotta talk like that. Why didn't you just say: 'Mister, you got any kind of a job for us?'"

"I can't do it," he said. "I feel lower than a snake's belly, now. If I get turned down once more I'd jump off a bridge. Doing it that way, you don't get slapped in the face."

"Kidding yourself."

"Maybe. But at the same time you keep enough self-respect to be able to walk up to the next man. After all, he didn't turn me down."

"You didn't ask for a job."

"I didn't have to. I knew it wouldn't do no good."

We went to the store where Russ bought the outboard and made the last payment with my dough. Then we still had nearly the whole day before us. I made the suggestion that we go to Jim's Place and hang around, but Russ knew a place on a side-track where they were unloading some coal and thought we might be able to earn a couple of bucks swinging a shovel. But when we got there, there were twenty W.P.A. men on each car. They had hardly room enough to lean on their own shovels.

We walked up Woodward a ways to a place where they were putting in a big sewer. That, too, was a W.P.A. project. Russ was disgusted. The ditch was as big as a river and all the dirt was being handled by man power and shovels. A big excavator had been pulled off the job and stood idle.

"That excavator," said Russ, "would do more work than that army."

"You're always bellyaching," I said, "about machines putting men out of jobs. What you see there oughta make you happy."

"It's the automatics," he said, "that are bad. The automatics that work on production. It's not the excavators and manipulators that make things tough for us fellows. Nobody buys a sewer. Dies are used in the factory. But the automatics are always used on production. The things those fellows you see there would like to use but can't buy."

"How come?"

"Because the automatics are doing the job, getting the pay checks. Last year, according to the papers, the automatics made four million automobiles. The men helped, but not enough so they can buy new cars. The automatics draw wages, too—real wages. But they are not, used to buy cars. Some goes for taxes, some into Mr. , Holt's bank—a lot goes to buy more automatics to put * more men out of work. And now the automatics are resting—waiting for us to use up the four million cars. They'll have to wait a long time if we're going to earn the money on W.P.A. projects."

It was hard to follow his arguments.

We took a long walk across town to East Davison, to Jim's Place. It was locked up, and in front of the joint young fellows were walking back and forth, milling around, carrying big banners and signs on their backs.

"What the hell," said Russ. "It's picketed."

Sure enough. We read the signs. "More Cuspidors," one said. "Fix Walls," another. "Better Loafing Conditions," "New Radio," "Level Pool Tables," "Air Condition," "Kill Cockroaches."

We eased up. There were twenty-thirty young fellows. A guy who went by the name of "Popeye," was the president. They had a vice-president, too. A couple of cops stood off a block and looked on. I knew some of the fellows. They wanted us to join in, but I didn't like the looks of the set-up. Not but what the place needed improvements, all right. Cockroaches had gray whiskers and were long as mice, but there were too many chances for arguments. Let some guy get excited and heave a rock through a window and the cops would pile over and gather the whole bunch in.

A big guy by the name of "Moon Mullins" stuck a sign on the door with the "Demands of the Committee" and Jim, the owner, stuck his head out of the window upstairs and told Moon, in strong language, to keep his hands off the joint. The fellows jeered back and Jim let out a yell and waved for the cops to come over.

"Come on," said Russ, "let's tear outa this mess. Things are gonna get hot."

Going up the street, not more than two or three blocks away from the place, we saw the squad wagon tear down the boulevard, two cops in front and two hanging onto the railing behind.

We circulated around, trying to get odd jobs in stores, parking stations, beer joints and restaurants, but we had no luck and in the afternoon we found ourselves on Hastings Street, in the colored district.

"Always make me feel good," said Russ, "to get into this neighborhood and just loaf awhile. There's a different feeling—a different atmosphere here."

"Different smell, too," I said.

"Sometimes I wish I'd been born a few shades darker," I said Russ. "Niggers always seem to have a good time. Give 'em a W.P.A. job and they're happy. If they lose the job and go on relief, they have a good time just the same. White fellows worry. They lose their jobs and slink around like a bunch of hungry coyotes. They beat the landlords and the landlords try to beat them; they

skin the grocer and the grocer tries to do them dirt. Among the whites it's dog eat dog—all the time. I never seen nothing like it."

The dirty street was swarming with people, mostly Negroes. Down below, near the river, the government had started a new housing project. Wreckers tore down the houses, engineers killed the rats and blew up the old foundations, and new buildings like barracks were put up for the niggers to live in. But the niggers packed their junk into two-wheeled carts and old cars and moved up the street, pushing the colored district a little farther out as they went. It looked like the engineers would never catch up.

The niggers, standing in little groups, sauntering along the broken sidewalks, looking at the displays of congealed stew, ham hocks, and boiled cabbages in the restaurant windows, were all happy as kids. There was a lot of laughing and knee-slapping at stories that didn't amount to nothing, and plain loafing. Nobody seemed to have any business that needed attention. Across the street a couple of colored janes with a French poodle came out of a door that led up a narrow stairs. Anybody could see they were whores, but as they went down the street the colored fellows —friends and customers—touched their hats or made strictly decent remarks. They were treated like ladies.

The old stores and houses, close together, leaned against each other as though they were tired. In a window, right near us, there were piles of bacon rinds in rolls, a tin platter of tripe, oxtails—blue with age—herrings, and a string of wild rabbits, and gallon-jars of buttermilk that looked like soft cheese floating on the thinnish blue liquid. Twenty feet down the alley lay a dead dog with legs stiff and outstretched; and a gray cat, with sides like an empty purse, picked its way cautiously across the uneven street through six inches of garbage, old papers, tin cans, and ashes. Down the line a ways a dog fight got started. Heads popped out of windows; men flocked out into the street and traffic was tied up. Russ and I were moving along when a colored kid twelve-fourteen years old stopped us. He carried a box that hung by a strap from his shoulder.

"Yo-all wanna see what I got's heah?" he said.

We looked. It was a rat—bigger than any I'd ever seen in the back streets of Detroit. He had yellow tusks like a boar and a snout like a wart-hog. He was scarred up something fierce. One ear and a part of the tail were clean gone.

"Judast!" said Russ.

"They's gwine be a fight at fo-thutty."

"A fight?"

"Yeah."

"What kinda fight?"

"Rat and cat fight. Napolean, here, is gwine fight a big tom-cat."

"How many rounds?"

"No rounds. Jist till one gets laid out."

"You selling tickets?"

"No, sah. Mr. Felix, he sell 'em. He be along directly, I 'spect."

The kid passed up the street, stopping now and then—showing the rat and explaining his fine points as a fighter. In a couple of minutes Mr. Felix came up. He looked prosperous in a black derby.

"Ah see you talking," he said. " 'Spects you-all'd like a couple of tickets."

"How much?" said Russ.

"Fifteen-a-piece. Two fo quatah."

"Where's the cat?"

"Ovah theah." He pointed diagonally across the street. There was another kid with a box slightly larger, selling tickets and working up bets on the cat.

The colored gentleman pulled out some small squares of cardboard. On them there was a pencilled address.

"Can't spare the money," said Russ.

"Ah'm taking bets, too."

"How's the odds?"

"They's even. Yo-all ge'men see dat cat yet?"

"No."

"Must be some cat. What chance has a rat got to clean off a cat?'

"Tha they rat's a pow'ful mean rat."

"He didn't look mean. He looked scared."

"Tha's a way he's got. He don't look mean even when he's fightin'. Ah wish yo-all ge'men could see the kind look on tha they rat's face when he's mad."

"Get's mad, eh?"

"Oh, sho. Get's pow'ful mad. But he don't let on how he's mad. Let's the cat tear into him, fust. He don't fight back, or nothin—looks kindhearted and sad."

"Then what?"

"Tha cat lays off and sets back. 'Tha ain't sich a bad rat,' he thinks to hisself. 'Ah's gwine leave him be!' And then the rat he done do's his stuff. With the lovin'est look in his face he noses up to the cat and sorter nudges his way under till he most gets clean outer sight. Slow and easy he does it—nice and gentle like he's trying to make friends. Then he flips hisself over and rips the cat's belly wide open. Splits out the guts. Tha cat makes on-n-ne pow'ful leap and leaves half hisself on the floo'. Yo-all ge'men wanna put a buck on the rat?"

"We ain't spending," said Russ.

We loafed around some more. Went down the street a ways and met Jeff. He'd lost his radio but was getting by fine. Said he hadn't got down yet to picking up snipes. To him the lay-off was just a chance to be more sociable and hang around more.

"How you fixed for bu'ning wood?" he asked Russ.

"Not so good. I'm about. Have to buy some, I guess."

"With money?"

"Sure, what else?"

"Don't nevva spend no money for bu'ning wood," said Jeff. "They's gwine be a house-wrecking next Friday. Evybody's welcome to come."

He started fumbling around in his pockets for an address.

"Can't find it," he said. "They's colo'd people. They was buying till the man he got laid off. The holdin' company give 'em notice to clear out."

We had heard about those house-wrecking bees. It was a good way to get wood if somebody in the neighborhood didn't call the cops. Sometimes only a part of the house was carried away by the men. Sometimes there was nothing left but a cellar hole full of old plaster.

It was late afternoon and it was a long ways to the house. We drifted along. Half-way home we came into another bunch of pickets. This time it was a large, fifty-family apartment. Men and women and kids were walking back and forth in front of the building, displaying big cards that read: "We demand lower rents," "No Unjust Evictions," "Human Rights First," "We Are Striking for Low Rents, Landlord Unfair," etc. A good-looking blonde wanted Russ and me to join the parade. She said the refreshments would be out pretty soon and tried to string a couple of signs the size of barn doors on us, but when we asked for details about the eats, she was vague about things.

Near the house we stopped in to talk to a man who ran a feed and fuel place. In his usual roundabout way Russ led up to the matter of work and found out that the man had just laid off three men. The fuel business, the man said, was so rotten it stunk.

"Maybe you can tell me," Russ said, "what all these families around here do to keep warm."

"Sure," he said. "They're not using their furnaces. They set up a tin stove and all live in one room."

"But they've still got to have fuel."

"Old boxes," he said. "They go along through the alleys and pick up old boxes and stuff. I see 'em go by here with carts and old baby buggies piled high with junk, dragging it home. Some of 'em even burn old tires—makes a hell of a stink."

Russ got an idea. He could hardly keep his mouth shut until we got in the street.

"Bennie," he said, "there's an idea for us. Instead of wearing out good shoe leather looking for odd jobs, we'll cut down expenses. If we save a dime, it's the same as making it. We're gonna start getting in wood for the winter. It'll be something new in lumbering for me."

Before we reached home, he stopped in a hardware store and laid out two-seventy-five for an axe. It was decorated with red paint and nickel plate—had two cutting edges and was sharp as a razor. When we passed a shade tree near the sidewalk it was all he could do to restrain himself from going to work on it with the new axe.

# CHAPTER XXIV

The weeks dragged along and it was November and most of the eighty bucks that Rita had stuck away to pay hospital bills had been spent for groceries and rent, and Mrs. Rettinelli, who had a way of figuring out things, said that Rita's time was near. Not being able to go to the hospital made Rita feel glum but it had the opposite effect on the Old Lady because she had the idea that anyone who went into a hospital—even Mr. Holt's—was practically a goner. Besides, having the baby at the house gave her a chance to superintend the job to the end. She went about the house running things and Russ let her do as she pleased until one day she tried to convince Rita that Tony would be a better name for the kid than Bennie. Then Russ put his foot down and let her know that he was the boss.

Mr. Holt's factory was still closed up tight as a drum. Once a rumor got started around that he was going to open, but when November was more than half gone and there was still no sign of work, the talk spread that we would go back in December. There was nothing to do but sit tight and wait. Russ and I had plenty of time on our hands and we used it, mostly, for figuring out ways to hold down expenses. We cut each other's hair and washed our own clothes. Fancy packages never came into the house and instead of buying cereals and stuff in pretty boxes all done up in waxed paper and cellophane, Russ went to a feed yard and bought corn meal and cracked wheat for less than five cents a pound. Stale bread we got for half price and after being steamed in the oven you couldn't hardly tell but what it was fresh. Meat we didn't have very often but when we did lay hard cash on the counter for a pound of hamburger we spoke about having a big dog and asked the butcher to throw in a bone. This we used to make soup.

As the weather grew colder, getting wood kept us pretty busy. From the swamp in back of the house Russ salvaged a raft made of old doors that the neighborhood kids had left stranded in two feet of mud. It was too wet to burn good. Three or four times a week we searched the alleys behind stores for discarded boxes. These we dragged home and Russ broke them up with his axe. They burned like paper and on a cold day it was a two-man job to keep a fire going right—one man to haul in the stuff while the other fiddled around with the drafts and dampers. And even then the

old stove was either red hot or stone cold—either going to beat the band, or clear out. The chimney had a habit of catching on fire and the first time it happened Russ, all excited, climbed up on the roof with a bucket of salt and smoked us out. Coming down he near busted a leg and after that when sparks started shooting out into the yard we let her roar.

Early on Thanksgiving Day, before daylight, Russ came into my room and woke me up.

"Get on your stuff," he said, all excited, "call the Doc and get the Old Lady. It's started."

I was awake in a jiffy, grabbing my clothes.

"Hurry," he said, "the kid's liable to come before they get here. Never mind your shirt. Grab your shoes."

In the other room I heard Rita. It was a sort of low moan.

"How long's that been going on?" I asked, making a dive for my shoes.

"Just started," he said. "Don't stop to fasten your shoes. I'm liable to have a kid on my hands here, Bennie. What'll I do?"

"Keep your shirt on. Be a couple of hours yet—maybe."

"Cripes," he said, "I don't know." He tore back into the room and popped out again as I grabbed my coat and made a pass for the door.

"Hurry, Bennie," he hollered as I busted out of the house; "and come back—don't leave me alone."

There was a telephone in an eating joint two blocks away that stayed open all night. I got the number and hung onto the phone. After what seemed like an hour, Doc answered.

"Better get over here right quick," I said. "Things are happening."

He didn't seem to get what I meant. Yawned a couple of times and asked questions. Wanted to know how long she had been having pains—how often they came.

"Judast, Doc," I said. "I don't know nothing about that. All I know is the lady is having a kid and the guy's throwing a fit."

He said something about nature taking its course. "Be hours yet," he said. "You tell that big guy not to worry. Tell him to calm down—I've handled lots of baby cases and never yet lost a father."

"Listen, Doc," I said, "he's going in circles. If I told him a crack like that—I don't know what would happen to you or me either. Better jerk your pants on and get over."

At Rettinelli's I got more action. The Old Lady had her things packed and grabbed a street car. Then Retti-nelli got out and we made coffee and got us some breakfast. After that we sat around a while and just talked. I wasn't in a hurry to get back. Thought I'd give the kid lots of time to get born because I didn't want to get back there in the middle of things. With the Old Lady and Russ there at the same time and both excited, things would be going round and round.

About nine I left Rettinelli's and went over to Jim's Place.

There was only two or three guys there, hanging around. I couldn't see that picketing the place had changed things none. One thing was sure—the same cockroaches were still there because I recognized an old boy who'd lost his whiskers one time in a fight. But there was a new sign on the wall —

Play Ball or Get Out.

I explained to Jim how things was at the house.

"Sure," he said, "stick around all you wanna. Turn on de radio and stuff. It's only for dose oddas I got-a sign up. For dose son-of-a beeches what tries to tell me how I shoulda run deesa place." Jim was all right if you knew how to take him.

I hung around till noon and then went to a movie, after which, I figured it was about time to go home and see if it was a boy. But when I was still a half a block away from the house I knew I was early. The Doc's coupe, with a blanket over the radiator, stood at the gate and I heard Rita. Not soft, gentle moans like in the morning, but loud. It was enough to make a man freeze in his tracks. I figured it was no time to turn back—they might be needing me bad.

In the house things were in a wild state of affairs. Mrs. Rettinelli was running back and forth between the stove and the bedroom. Russ was going around in circles kicking the furniture. The fire had gone out and the house was stone cold.

"What's the matter?" I asked Russ.

"Cripes, I don't know, Bennie. It's been going on like this for hours."

Doc came out into the room and left the door open. He had his sleeves up—no coat. Through the door I could see the edge of the bed. It had been moved a little away from the wall. The closet door stood open and there, up on a shelf, I could see the red box in which Rita kept her silver shoes and black dancing dress.

"Get some wood," Doc told me. "Keep that fire going. See if you can make a job of it."

Rita cried out again, four-five times in succession. She sounded desperate and mad. "Us Rettinelli's are all fighters," she had once told me. Her cries rose to a high, screaming pitch and then dropped to a low gurgling moan. Russ' face twisted all out of shape. He spoke to Doc who was looking for something in a black bag that sat on a chair.

"It's killing her, Doc. Can't you do something?"

"She's all right, I tell you."

"It's been going on for hours—getting worse all the time."

"Big baby—she's little."

"But it's killing her—she's gonna die."

"She's not going to die, I tell you. First babies always come hard."

"Give her something—kill the pain, can't you? Get it over with."

"She's got to help. I can't do anything alone."

The screams came again. Throaty screams, from deep down. Through clinched teeth and set jaws—in a struggle to keep down the pain. Mrs. Rettinelli was with her—spoke soft sounding words in Italian.

Russ sent a chair spinning over the floor.

"I can't stand it," he said. "It's enough to tear a man's heart out, Doc. Give her something—give her something—stop it!"

He grabbed Doc by the arm.

"Can't give her anything now," said Doc. "She's got to help—I tell you." He jerked free. Looked at his arm. He had a syringe in his hand.

Russ came towards him again. Once, I saw a guy with D.T.'s.

"Doc, if she dies—it'll come out of your hide. Understand what I'm telling you?"

"Listen, big boy," said Doc, "I'm going to get hard in a minute. I've had enough out of you. Put on your hat and get out. Get out and don't come back till I let you in. Get —"

"I can't, Doc. I——"

"Get out!"

"I'll keep my mouth shut!"

"Get out, or I'll throw up the job. I don't want you around. The way you been carrying on here—get out."

Russ sobered up.

"You're right, Doc," he said. "I can't take it."

I got his hat, put it on him. Rita started again and he rushed into the bedroom.

"Oh, baby," he kept saying over and over, "I wish I could help—I wish I could help."

I went out to get an armful of wood and when I got back he was gone and Doc was trying to blockade the door with a chair.

There was a pan of water on the stove with some rubber gloves, needles and pieces of gut in it. Also, a white porcelain tank with a cover, that Doc must have brought with him.

I started a fire and then began peeling potatoes, not knowing why, except that I wanted things to be natural again—to have the place seem like a kitchen again and not like a hospital.

Doc came and stood at the stove and poked at the rubber gloves to make them stay down. He stood with his feet wide apart. He had small hands but big, hefty arms with hair on them—the kind of arms that would have done a good job changing a tire.

"Can't do a thing with that fellow around here," he said. "Comes back again I'm going to throw him out—he's a nuisance."

Rita started in again. The pains must have been something fierce, but he never let on to hear her. He was the rough sort—the kind that could take off a man's leg and be telling a story about Mae West.

"Everything all right, Doc?" I asked.

"How do I know?" he said. "In a case like this, you never know till it's over. And even then—you don't know. She should be in a hospital where there's something to work with. It's a crime, trying to deliver a baby in a place like this."

"Nothing to worry about—yet?"

"May have to use forceps. Don't like to tear her up more'n I have to. Get that water boiling quick as you can."

"Forceps dangerous?" I asked.

"Not necessarily dangerous," he said. "Don't like to use 'em if I don't have to, that's all. Only thing around here that's dangerous is that big guy—trying to tell me what to do. If he comes back here— No fun for me either. My wife's got a big turkey all cooked. I had plans made to go out into the country this afternoon—shoot rabbits."

He lit a cigarette, looked at his arm.

"That guy's strong," he said.

"Plenty. If he comes back in," I said, "you'd better let me handle him. He'll generally listen to me."

The cries from the bedroom grew louder, more desperate. They were almost continuous.

"Won't be long, now," he said. "I'll give her something pretty soon to ease up the pain."

He walked to the window and looked out.

"What's this?" he said. "There's somebody out there on the porch."

It was old Rettinelli, standing there with his hat in his hand, too scared to knock or come in. I took the chair away and opened the door.

"Was 's-a matta?" he asked. "Little To-nee—'ee's-a not come yet?"

"Not yet," said Doc.

"You t'ink 'ee's come pretty soon—queek maybe?"

"I think so. Be along pretty soon, I guess."

The old man stood there fiddling around with his hat. It looked like there was something more he wanted to say.

"Is already long time," he said.

"Yeh, I know," said Doc. "Can't be helped, though. The girl—she's all right. When it's all over, we'll let you know."

Then I saw Russ coming back down the street with long steps. Mrs. Rettinelli came out on the porch and talked to the Old Man in Italian. Doc and I stepped back into the house. Russ barged in through the door.

"Has she been calling me, Doc?"

"I thought I told you—stay out."

"I could hear her, Doc —"

Rita cried out again. He went into the room. Mrs. Rettinelli came back into the house and hurried into the bedroom. Her eyes were red. She looked pretty darn serious.

"Well—" I said to Doc, "he's back again."

"Tell me something," he said, "I don't know. He's going out again—if I have to use force."

Doc had the white tank on the table and was busy fishing out some big instruments with wide blades and strong handles. He put them carefully on a tray.

"Don't touch them," he said. "Keep that fire going all the time."

Russ came back into the room.

"Doc," he said, "she's getting worse."

"Listen," said Doc, "if you'll just let me alone—get out of here—stay out —"

"But she's getting worse. She's losing her nerve."

"She's all right, I tell you. If you'll get out, give me a chance to do something, I'll probably get you a big healthy baby."

"Probably—" he said, "probably. Things are not going right. You know it. You're keeping things from me."

He saw the instruments on the table.

"What are these things?" he said.

"My instruments—what else?"

"You're going to take it away from her. You're —"

"Get away from that table."

"You're keeping things from me, Doc. You know it. I want another doctor in here—to take charge."

Doc was beginning to get sore.

"I'm handling this case," he said.

"Then do something," said Russ. "Do something. She's getting weak. Hear that? She's not so loud—no fight. Do something—can't you?"

"I will—if you'll give me a chance."

"Quick, then; before it's too late. She's losing her strength—getting weak."

"She's all right, I tell you."

"She's not all right, Doc. You lie ——"

"All right," said Doc, starting to roll down his sleeve, "I'm through."

Russ grabbed his arm.

"No—no—" he said, "don't go. I don't know what I'm talking about, Doc. I'm crazy."

"Now, listen," said Doc. "I want you to get out and stay out. Stay out till I'm through. Don't come back till I let you in. Go now—or I leave."

I got an idea. I took Russ by the arm.

"Listen," I said, "Doc's right. He can't do nothing with you tearing around here. I never see you so rattled—you act worse than a kid. You gotta get out—give him a chance."

"I gotta be near, Bennie. I can't be out on the street—if she calls me."

"You've gotta get out, stay out. Get your axe and work up that old willow in the back yard. We've gotta have wood."

"I'd like to, Bennie," he said. "But Rita ——"

"What good's the old tree," I said. "It's half dead. We've gotta have wood. We're clean out."

The idea worked. He got the axe and went out the back door, and then wanted to come back for his coat.

"Never mind your coat," I told him. "Work hard, you won't get cold."

"Stand at the window," he said. "Anything goes wrong—I wanna know. I didn't know it'd be like this, Bennie. I'm worried—I'm scared stiff."

"Everything's o-keh," I said. "Doc told me. That cry- } ing don't mean a thing—they all do when they're having kids."

I went back into the house. I fixed up the fire and then stood at the window and looked out.

In the bedroom things were going on. Doc was working—staying close to the job. Rita's cries were not so sharp any more—not so loud either. They were dull groans but they still had some fight in them.

I heard Doc. "Now rest," he would say. "Take it easy. Relax. Now get ahold of that sheet. Do your stuff. Grit your teeth. That-a girl. Fine."

Then she'd rest. And then, in a minute or so, another spasm would hit her and she'd go through the same thing again. It was awful—just to be there—to hear it. Things didn't seem real in the house. Things seemed like a bad dream that had no end to it. I got to wondering—got to thinking if that was the way I'd got born.

"Mrs. Rettinelli got more excited—but not nervous like Russ. She ran back and forth, put another pan of water to heat on the stove, hung some cloths on a chair set back to the fire. "Kip going," she told me, meaning the fire.

Outside the sky got colder and darker. A fine drizzle began and there was not a bit of light in the sky where the sun was going down behind the row of gray shacks on the other side of the swamp.

I watched Russ. He had the old willow down. Standing over the black, knotty trunk he swung mighty strokes. Chips the size of a man's hand flew off with each powerful stroke of his axe. In the dusk, lying there in the mud on the ground, the old tree looked like a dead dragon. Russ had his foot on the body, lopping off the legs and the claws, leaving white scars. Once more—he had control over things.

I got the smell of chloroform or ether. It was chloroform, I think. Mrs. Rettinelli got a pan of water from the stove and when she went back into the room she closed the door behind her. Doc's

voice again—I couldn't hear what he said. Dull groans from Rita that turned to ear-splitting shrieks. I was afraid Russ would hear—come back again.

Then all was quiet. There were movements behind the closed door. Doc's voice again—talking, this time, to the Old Lady. And then I heard a faint squeak. After all the noise—all the excitement—all the big pains—that little squeak sounded pretty darn small.

A minute or two went by and then Mrs. Rettinelli came out with something red and small in a cloth. She took a blanket from the chair and spread it out on the table.

"Ross-s-s," she said. "You call—now." Doc must have heard her.

"Don't -call," he yelled. "I don't want him in yet."

Russ had the tree nearly worked up. The rain drops began to make a noise on the roof. Yellow lights from the shacks across the swamp began to show up through the darkness.

Mrs. Rettinelli washed the baby—rubbed it with some sort of oil, and then wrapped it up. I got a look at its face. It was wrinkled like a turnip that's been left in the cellar too long and is all puckered up.

Doc came out.

"All right," he said. "I've got the china packed. Let in the bull if you want to."

I went to the back door and let out a whistle. He came up on a run.

"We can call it Bennie," I said. "It's a boy."

"Rita—" he said. "Is she all right?"

"They're both fine and dandy," I said.

Doc was packing his tools.

"May I see her?" asked Russ. Now that it was all over, he was meek enough. Mrs. Rettinelli was holding the baby but he never even went near it.

"Sure," said Doc. "Don't make it too long. I want her to sleep."

Russ went into the bedroom and dropped down on his knees to the floor. He tried to cheer her. Mrs. Retti-nelli went in too, with the baby. Now they would be happy, I thought, now that it was all over and they three—Rita and Russ and the baby—were together. They would be happy, I thought, and wouldn't need me and I would be left out. I felt terribly alone. I edged towards the door. Rita was talking to Russ.

"I'm tired," she said. "I'm awfully tired, Russ. It was a long time."

"Too long," he said. "I'm sorry you had to do it alone—terribly sorry. I wanted to help—but I couldn't."

There were tears in his eyes. I was ashamed to be there, looking on. Yet I wanted to stay.

"Did I hear you chopping?" she asked.

"Yes," he said. "Doc and Bennie wouldn't let me stay in the house. I cut up the willow. We were all out of wood."

"You cut it?" she said. "Cut it down?"

"Yes."

"Oh Russ —"

Mrs. Rettinelli pushed forward. She felt something was wrong.

"Il bambino," she said. "Qui il bambino, Rita."

She put it down beside Rita.

"Oh Russ," Rita said, "how could you do it? How could you?"

She turned her face to the wall. She didn't even notice that the baby was there.

# CHAPTER XXV

By the middle of December things were tough. According to the papers forty-fifty thousand families were on relief and the mayor spent half his time going back and forth to Washington, trying to raise dough. I had fifty dollars left in the sock but Russ was getting down pretty low. He had bought a snow shovel and an ice spud and earned a few quarters cleaning sidewalks, but about the only real dough that he saw was the four dollars a week I paid in. And a good share of that went for some high-powered baby food that cost like the deuce.

Rita wanted Russ to go on the dole.

"Others do it," she argued, "why don't you?"

"Just the idea," he said, "gives me the willies. Every day I see 'em, standing in rows at the fire houses, trying to hide their faces behind their coat collars—waiting out in the cold."

"We gotta eat."

"I suppose so," he said. "But I don't like to do it. It's all right for fellows that are sick or can't work, but I'm healthy—I'm strong. A big guy like me ought to be out bucking the cold and deep snow—swinging an axe out in the woods—earning his keep. I was brought up to think that if a man was willing and able to work he could get along without asking for hand-outs."

She kept after him so much that one morning he pulled his hat down over his eyes and went out. He was gone the whole day and when he got back he had nothing—not even a hunk of good government bacon or a sack of number two spuds like the Rettinelli's was getting.

"What's the matter?" asked Rita. "We'll have a pretty slim supper. I was figuring you'd bring something." She was frying potatoes.

"My feet are frozen," he said. "Been standing in line all day. They shoot you from one place to another. Ask all kinds of questions. Even wanted to know if we kept a boarder."

He grabbed a chair and stuck his feet in the oven.

"How's the kid been?" he asked.

"Fine, Russ. He's in the bedroom—sleeping. But why wouldn't they give you nothing?"

"I'd rather not talk about it. Rather forget about the whole mess."

"But tell me —"

"They asked if we had any money."

"And you told them—how stupid. They're not going to search the house."

"It's bad enough to have to beg—without lying."

"It wouldn't be a very big lie," she said. "Do you know how much we've got left?"

"No."

"Six dollars."

"Is that all?"

"That's all. And when that's gone you'll have to do something—sell the outboard."

"Never. First I'll turn in my badge. Get the five bucks."

"You would. And let someone else get your job when the factory opens."

Sometimes Russ didn't use his head. At other times you had to give him lots of credit. When he made soup, for instance. He would spend fifteen cents for a knuckle joint of beef, chop up a few carrots and onions, throw in a handful of barley, and make what he called lumber-jack soup. It was like nothing you ever got in a restaurant. Even the kid liked it.

And he was good about bringing home fruits and vegetables, after dark, mostly. Some of the stuff was frozen, some partly spoiled, but trimming and washing made it all good. After all, the main thing was to get by. I never asked where he got it and he never told me, either, until one night he came home with a whole case of frozen celery. He had a cut on the side of his mouth and one ear was puffed up like a turnip. He'd been fighting—I could see that in a minute.

"A couple of Polacks," he said, "tried to take it away from me. Claimed they saw it first. We went round and round in the alley."

About half the case was good. We had celery for two weeks.

He would have had more luck rustling up odd jobs if he hadn't stayed home so much fooling around with the kid. Nothing gave him more fun than to get the kid out by the stove and change a diaper, or let him play with his finger.

"Look at that," he'd say, kidding me, "notice the way he hangs on. The little bastard thinks he's got ahold of a speed wrench. He's gonna be a straw boss some day."

Down in his heart he was scared to death the kid would be a straw boss in a factory. He had the idea that the kid would furnish the argument to get Rita to leave Detroit and move out into the country.

"Bennie," he once said to me, when he was serious, "I can't think that Rita would want him to grow up in the dirt and noise of these streets. What a kid needs when he's growing up, is lots of fresh air; room to tear around, and a chance to learn something about animals and trees."

And she had the idea somehow that the kid would make him settle down in the factory and be steady—that it would make him forget his wild dreams about clamming and roaming about in a trailer. She talked to me, confidential.

"He'll see it the way I do," she would say, "when the baby gets older. He'll want him to have advantages—get an education like I did. Just think how awful it would be if he'd get sick—way out in the country. He might be dead before we could get to a doctor. I want him to go to the Holt School."

They were so far apart in their plans for the kid they didn't dare to talk to each other about them. They talked to me.

The auto shows came and went and some of the auto factories got into production but Mr. Holt stayed closed. The auto business was dead. There were too many used cars on the market, for one thing, and those who wanted new cars and had the money to pay for them, didn't buy, because they wanted to see first what Mr. Holt's new model was going to be like. The factories that had started up ran long enough to fill up the show-rooms and then they shut down again and Detroit was deader than ever.

And then one day, right after Christmas, we heard a rumor that Mr. Holt was going to call back twelve thousand men. The next morning at daylight, Russ and I were lined up at the gate. So were a big bunch of others, both niggers and whites.

It was seven before the big guard came into his booth. But he didn't take the lock off the gate. I held Russ' place while he went up and talked to the guard through the steel gate. They were not hiring, he said, just a rumor. He didn't have any idea when the plant would open. Cards or telegrams, he said, would be sent when the company wanted us back.

Still he was there and that meant something—enough to keep the men lined up for a couple of hours. And then they left their places and the line broke up and the fellows started milling around in the slush and wet snow, trying to get near the gate, trying to talk to the guard, to ask questions. Some of them had papers showing they had good reputations and didn't belong to no unions, or that they had bought a Holt car on time and were paying for it. Others had letters from the relief workers or politicians saying they needed work, and one fellow who crowded up and was loud in his talk and behavior had a letter three pages long telling all about his refinement and good character. Among other things it said that he never drank, used tobacco or swore, but when he pushed the letter through the bars of the gate and the guard, who was reading a newspaper, let it fall into the mud, he let out a string of cuss words what would have put a steel rigger to shame.

Russ began to get bored. Doing nothing never satisfied him long.

"Let's beat it," he said. "Nobody's gonna get in. With this mob here the fellow would be crazy to open that gate."

"Take it easy," I said. "The mob won't be here long—you see. Cops will be along pretty soon and herd the whole bunch down the street."

"Think so? I'd like to get home, wring out my shoes."

An old sedan with an Arkansas license plate and with four hill-billies in it drove up to the curb and came to a wheezing stop next to a fire plug. The rear windows were gone and a hill-billy with a

woman's shawl around his neck pulled back a strip of burlap and stuck out his head.

"Mister Holt been down yet this mo'ning?" he asked Russ.

"Not yet," said Russ, acting serious. "We're expecting him though, any minute. You fellas looking for work?"

"Yeah—bo. We-all's just rarin' to work."

"What kind of car you got there?" asked Russ. "One of Mr. Holt's?"

"No, sah."

"Then you'd better get it outa here before Mr. Holt sees it," he said. "I was you I'd park it way over there on the other side of them tracks. Mr. Holt see you driving a foreign-make car —"

The piece of burlap went down and the old car started out with a jerk. It showed a good bit of speed, considering its age and looks. Neither did it stop until it had got several blocks on the other side of the tracks. Then the hill-billies spilled out and walked back to the gate.

In the crowd we came across Jerry and Jeff. Jeff told us about a house-wrecking bee that was coming off in a couple of days. He said the house was all wood, the neighbors on both sides o-keh, and asked us to come. Our supply of old boxes was low and the wood from the old willow had all been used up. We said we'd be there although it would mean getting up pretty early.

Then Jerry took Russ and me aside, away from the crowd. He had something he wanted to tell us, something confidential, he said.

"I gotta get in there," he said. "I been coming down here every day. Yesterday they let in a bunch." Then he stopped. A couple of fellows were coming.

"That what you wanted to tell us?" said Russ.

"Wait till these fellows get past." He was acting mighty mysterious and nervous. "Gotta be careful," he said.

Inside the factory there was some activity. A little light smoke floated away from the tops of high stacks on the power plant. A switch engine pushed a string of cars loaded with machines into the plant. As it got closer we could see the machines were all streamlined automatics—gear-cutters, mostly. The coke ovens were running full blast though there was not a man in sight. A steel car moved and then stopped; an iron door raised up towards the sky and a glacier of white hot coke crumbled and fell ponderously into the car. The car moved past the long row of black ovens into the quenching towers and stopped; tons of water sprayed down and from the squat tower a cloud rose and drifted over the plant, raining a shower of tiny black cinders down on our heads.

"A man wouldn't last long," said Jerry, "if he was to jump into that car."

"Get his feet dry," said Russ. "What's this you were going to tell us?" The two fellows had passed.

"Last week," Jerry said, talking softly, "I got an invitation to join the Suicide Club of Detroit."

"Swell," said Russ. "How do they feed you?"

"Na-a-ah, that's not the idea. They don't feed you."

"What good's it then?"

"The idea is—you go there to read—meet fellows and talk."

"You can do that in a pool hall."

"It's not the same thing."

"Well," said Russ, "did you join?"

"Na-a-ah, the place was full of screwballs. Every guy there's got a wheel loose. The first night some fellow got me off in a corner. 'Listen,' he said, 'I'll tell you something, if you'll keep you mouth shut, don't blab it around.'

" 'Spill it,' I said.

"He whipped out a card.

"'['m Raymond Holt,' he told me. 'The real Raymond Holt. Some day when the Old Man dies, I get all the dough—all of it.'"

"The guy was trying to crab your stuff," said Russ.

"No, he was serious. Got mad as the deuce when I laughed."

"And I suppose you told him," said Russ, "who you were—let him know that you were the real McCoy—the real Napoleon?"

"Na-a-ah, the guy was cracked. I figured to myself—what's the use? I walked out."

Russ and I shook him off and walked back towards the gang at the gate.

"The guy's batty," said Russ. "It gives me the willies, the way that fellow acts. He oughta be locked up."

But I didn't think so. He was all right in the shop if you didn't try to argue with him—didn't get him started talking about the H.P.'s or committing suicide.

Two police cars came down the street and pulled up at the gate. Eight or ten cops piled out and began herding the men down the street.

"Move along," they ordered. "It's against traffic rules to block up the street. Break it up. Move along, you fellows."

The men grumbled and cussed. They didn't move very fast, but the cops kept driving—kept crowding and swinging their clubs. The niggers, joking and laughing, moved off towards the main gate. The whites went in the opposite direction. Russ and I beat it across the street into the parking field and got out of sight among the cars.

"We'll lay low," he said; "see what happens. When the cops leave, the big fellow may open the gate. If he does—bust a leg getting over there. Don't wait for nothing." Russ was beginning to use the old head.

Two cops stayed near the gate. The other cops herded the whites along the sidewalk across the tracks away from the plant. Nobody bothered the niggers and when they reached the main gate they stopped and chewed the rag with the guard. Then they came back.

"What now?" said Russ. "They're headed back. What do you make outa that?"

I didn't know. The two cops were still hanging around and when the niggers reached the employment gate the cops didn't chase them away. Instead, they got into the cars and drove off. And then, before we could figure out what was happening, the guard unlocked the gate and let in the niggers—didn't even wait to have them line up.

"Come on!" said Russ, "he's letting 'em in! Let's get over there."

We tore across the wide parking field, across the wide street, ignoring the traffic. But we were too late. When we got there the last nigger was in. The guard slammed the gate. Seven or eight other fellows who had been hiding behind a box-car had seen the niggers go in. They came running up.

Russ was so mad he lost control of himself. Didn't know for a minute what he was doing. He flew at the gate.

"Come on, you big bruiser," he yelled. "Let us in! Open up! We saw you let in those niggers. We want our jobs back! Give us a chance!"

"Get away from that!" the guard said. He had a short piece of heavy hose and clipped Russ across the bare knuckles.

Russ kicked at the gate.

"You nigger-loving bastard," he said. "Let us in! We got our badges—we're on the pay roll! We saw you let in those niggers!"

More fellows came running up. They bobbed up from all over—from out of old cars—from the parking field—from behind an old real estate office. They were eager to get into a scrap—eager to start taking something apart. But the steel gate was locked. It was strong. I grabbed Russ by the arm.

"Come on," I said. "He can't open up. What's the matter with you? This gang would mob him!"

The guard stepped into his booth—grabbed the telephone. I knew what that meant—the cops would be back. The H.P.'s too. They were rough.

Everybody started calling insults—kicking and jerking at the steel fence and gate. It was a mess. You couldn't hear yourself shout above the noise of the crowd.

The place wasn't healthy no more, what with the crowd getting wild and the telephone call. Some of the guys were looking for rocks. I jerked Russ out of the crowd, gave him a kick on the shins. It wasn't a minute too soon. Two cars of H.P.'s wheeled out of the main gate as we crossed the street. We cut through the parking field and went home through the side streets. Russ was pretty burned up.

"They don't want white fellows in there," he said. "They want niggers. I don't blame them. The niggers can take it—we can't. White fellows get their brains tied up into knots. They get screwy ideas like Gus and that crazy Jerry. I'd go nutty myself if I had to work in there all the time. But the niggers—nothing ever happens to them."

I didn’t say nothing. I was feeling lower than a snake’s belly myself.

# CHAPTER XXVI

It was still dark when Russ and I got out of bed to go to the house-wrecking. And it was snowing and blowing a gale and the wind came up through the cracks in the floor and howled around the corner of the old house.

Rita stayed in bed and Russ told her that we were going out to rustle up wood, but he didn't tell her that we were going to help tear down a house to get it. We got us a couple pieces of rope, a hammer, and an old wrecking bar, and left.

A fast walk of ten or twelve blocks got us warmed up and then we got cold again trying to find the right house.

"Gotta find it," said Russ. "Might be a little embarrassing to start on the wrong one—have the owner stick his head out of a window about the time we were walking away with the front porch."

"Sure would," I said. "It'd be worse than going on relief and having a half-ton of coal delivered to your front door free-gratis. Sometimes I can't figure out why I let myself get dragged into this kind of thing."

"Me either," he said, trying to be sarcastic. "When you get home you'll have to look up 'house-wrecking' in Mr. Holt's book—see what he says about it. He's against the dole, we know that already."

We found the house, a little two-story affair—all wood. It was next to a narrow alley, littered with ash-cans and garbage. Through the swirling snow we could see a line of old cars, two-wheeled carts and old trailers parked in the alley, pretty well back from the street. But not a man did we see until Jeff stuck his head out of a window and motioned for us to come in the back door.

It was beginning to get light outside, but in the old house it was still pretty dark. For a minute or so we couldn't see a thing but the lights from two or three cigarettes and a lot of feet all over the floor. Then we noticed there was a meeting in progress. A short, heavyset nigger stood on what looked like a piece of linoleum at the end of the room and was talking. A big gang of niggers and three or four whites sat along the walls on the floor. The room was full and Russ and I stood next to Jeff near the door.

"Done voted a'ready," said Jeff in a whisper.

"Yeah," said Russ. "What for?"

"Officers. Ah's a General."

"What's that make us?"

"Y'all boys kin be Captains," said Jeff. "In my squad. Ah got two othas a'ready."

"Dog-gone," said Russ. "We shoulda been here early. We might-a been Majors—or something. Who's that fellow shootin' off there? What's he holding things up for?"

"Tha's Mista Williams," said Jeff. "Stoodie, we calls him. He the Soo-preem High Commander. What he say—oes."

It had got a little lighter. We could see things. The men were sprawled all over the floor. They had crowbars, hammers, bunches of ropes and hay-wire. One had a shovel and one was eating a fish from a piece of newspaper spread out on the floor. Stoodie was going on as though he was still good for a long time. He was taking himself pretty serious—screwed up his face and tried to look mad, like Mussolini.

"Ge'men," he said, "this yere occasion remind me of the time my ole pappy usta tek me in the woodshed. 'Boy,' he say to me, 'this yere's a mighty solemn occasion—mighty. Ah's gwine remember it a long time—caze it gwine hurt me more'n you, son.'

"'Yeh—Ah knows that,' Ah say to him, 'but it ain't gwine hurt you in the same place.'

"And tha's how it gwine be yere. What we gwine do yere is gwine hurt us more'n what it's gwine hurt the mortgage company what owns this yere place and put the people what lived yere and couldn't pay they rent out in the old street. But it ain't gwine hurt us in the same place. We doing this not so much for to get bu'ning wood, though that gwine help, as to discourage those otha landlords and holding companies who's thinking right now about puttin' us out in the cold, too. They is gwine read about this yere house-wrecking in they papers, they is, and they is gwine scratch they haids and say—'Um-um-umuh, tha's bad. Tha's mighty bad. Ah 'spects Ah betta leave those poo' people right whe'e they is till they gets jobs and kin pay they rents. Not move 'em out.' Yas, sah—tha's what they gwine say to theysefs—if they's sma't."

Russ was eager to get into action. He hadn't been around colored fellows enough to know how to take them. It was their party, not ours.

"How long's this been going on?" he asked Jeff in a loud whisper. ""What's the idea? Why don't we get started?"

"We get sta'ted 'rectly," said Jeff. "Ain't gwine be long now."

The speaker went on and on.

"Ah recollect one time," he said, "Ah got e-viction papahs served on me. Ah most had to move out the house where Ah was. A ge'men opened the door and stuck some papahs at me. Then he looked sca'ed and got ready to run.

"Wait a minute, yere, boy,' Ah say. 'What this y'all give me?'

"'E-viction papahs,' he say. "They's fum che sheriff's office.'

"Way 'cross the front of the papah they was big letters—black as a niggah's funeral.

"Greetings From The State of Michigan,' it say.

"What's this, though?' I asked him. 'It say yere, Greetings fum the state of Michigan. Y'all sho, boy, this yere papah ain't congratulations or somethin' from the Gov'nor?'

"No sah, boss,' he say. 'That they greetings and stuff—that they jist make it legal. That they papah's a notice to e-vict.'

"'F-vict?' I say.

"'Yes-sah, boss. It done mean—get out.'

"What house it say to e-vict fum?'

"'Ah dunno,' he say. "This house Ah 'spect.'

"That all yo brung?' I ask him.

"Yes sah.'

"'Pshaw,' Ah say. "Y'all done brung me wrong papah, boy. What y'all do that fo'? This papah tell me which house to move out of. Ah knows that a'ready. What Ah wants is a papah which tell me what house to move in-to. Tha's what Ah want.'

"P's sorry, boss,' he say. 'I's mighty sorry.'

"Yall tek this papah,' I tell 'em. "Tek it back to that they no-count sheriff and dun't come back yere till y'all gets me the right one. What ah wants is in-viction papahs—not e-viction. That mek it clear?'

"Yes sah,' he say. 'Yes sah, boss. I's pow'ful sorry I mek you dis trouble fo nothin'.'"

Russ was getting mighty impatient. He took a step forward. -

"What are we here for?" he said. "If we're gonna tear down this old joint—let's get going. We're killing time. What's the idea?"

The gang stirred. The men were surprised but said nothing. Stoodie gave Russ a dark look.

"'"N case they's anybody yere don't know," said Stoodie, "Ah'm runnin' this meetin'. Ah'm the Soo-preem High Commander. Ain't gwine be no foolishment. We's gwine to do it 'cording to Misto Hoyle. In the fustest place—anybody that wants to is welcome to make hisself scarce and get out. And in the secondest place—anybody that has got a job and is wukking, is obliged to lay off the wood. We's gwine sta't on the roof and wuk down. The Generals will now please preceed to round up they Captains and re-move the roof shingles."

Russ stepped out into the middle of the floor.

"Na-a-a-ah," he said, "that's not the way to go at it. The idea is to do as much as we can from the inside—stay out of sight. The first thing to do is to get rid of the plaster—drop it into the cellar. Then tear out the windows and walls—collapse the old joint and do all our work on the ground. Get it over with—quick."

There was a buzz of voices. Men talked. They could see that Russ knew his stuff.

"Ge'men," said Stoodie, "does y'all want me—or no? If —"

"Sure we want you," said Russ. "You're the Supreme High Commander, ain't you? I'm the dictator—that's all."

"You is the dictator?" said Stoodie.

"Sure."

"And me—Ah'm the Soo-preem High Commander?"

"That's right."

Stoodie called for order.

"Ge'men," he said, "all who is in favor of having a dictator say 'I.' "

The "I's" were general.

"All who is in dis-favor of having a dictator say 'no.' "

There wasn't a sound.

"Thank you, gents," said Russ, stepping up beside Stoodie. "I'm much obliged to you now and forever. And now to get at the job. We'll do it the same as barn-raising, except that everything will be done in reverse. I want five men to go in the cellar and tear out the underpinning from the rear wall. Rear wall only—make it fast. Stoodie here, as the Supreme High Commander, will pick out the men."

Every man rose to his feet, eager to start. Stoodie selected a General and four Captains. They went below.

"Six fellows," said Russ, "will tear up a couple boards from the floor along the walls. I want ten others to get ready to rip off the plaster and drop it down into the cellar. The others take out all doors and windows. Make it snappy."

Stoodie repeated the orders and selected the men for the jobs. Things started—moved fast. The underpinnings were knocked out in a hurry and as soon as the men came back up the plaster was peeled off and dropped through the slits in the floor. The dust and the noise was something fierce. Doors and windows were loaded into old trailers and hauled off. Braces and fire-stops were pulled out. Then came the ceilings and floors—last of all the partitions. Inside the old house was stripped bare.

"Everybody out," hollered Russ. "Every man get himself a long board."

Stoodie repeated the order—stuck close to Russ. He had a stick in his hand—waved it about like a sword. He screwed his face up so that he looked more and more like Mussolini.

Some of the fellows grabbed long pieces of lumber that had been ripped up from the floor. Others pulled long strips of siding from the outside of the old house. Russ got one, too.

"Have 'em do what I do," he told Stoodie. "Get every man out in front."

They followed Russ. He walked to the front—raised the end of his board high against the face of the old house. The men did the same, though none of them knew just what was going to take place.

"Take it easy," said Russ. "Push when I say—heave. Let off when I say—ho-o-0-0-0. Stay together—keep it up. Get her weaving—heave—ho-o-o. Get her rocking—heave—ho-o-o-o-o. A little harder—get 'er swaying now men. All together —"

At first there was no give. The old house was firm. It looked silly—thirty-forty men pushing and swaying at the face of the old building with a bunch of long boards and thin, limber sticks. One or two fellows quit.

"Keep working," said Russ. "Get her moving—heave—ho-o-o-o. Stay together."

The old house started giving a little—just a little, at first. Not much, but enough to encourage the fellows. They worked harder. Then the whole thing began swaying—rocking back and forth with the sticks. Russ changed the rhythm—a little faster. It moved more and more—swayed farther each time the men pushed. Inside, things began loosening up—snapping and popping. Boards cracked.

"Keep her going," said Russ. "We got her coming. Give 'er all you got—men—rock her over—this time ——"

Wood splintered and snapped. The old building lurched back—the rear crumbled and sagged —the whole front reared up and the house sat down on its haunches with its face to the sky.

Stoodie thought it was funny. He forgot all about trying to look dark and serious like Mussolini and bent double with laughter.

"Oh, Misto Russ," he said, "look at dat now. Ole house 'e ti'ed. He's gwine sit down on 'e's hind end and rest. 'Ah ain't gwine git up no mo',' 'e say to 'esef."

Russ made eight or nine fellows climb up on the face of the old house and the whole thing flattened out and collapsed. After that it was a short job to rip the shingles off with a shovel and tear things apart. The carts and trailers were quickly loaded with old boards and rafters. Some of the men carried away bundles of lumber and lath on their shoulders. I laid out a pile of stuff for Russ and me to take home. It was surprising how quickly the job was cleaned up.

"A neat job," said Russ, "if I do say it myself. The cellar hole is filled—everything is cleaned up. I like to leave a job in nice shape."

Besides Russ and I there was only Stoodie and a couple of colored fellows who had come late. They were gathering up the last scraps of wood from the snow. Stoodie, who had dropped all his high-faluting ways, was trying to salvage a toilet bowl from underneath a big pile of old plaster. Russ helped. The two colored fellows were arguing.

"Tha con'stable sho gonna be surprised," said one, "when he get yere and try to move these people usta be yere outa this house."

"Which house?" said the other.

"This house. This house we jist wrecked."

"How he gonna tell people which ain't yere to move outa house which ain't yere neither. Tell me that—you crazy fool."

"Tha what I jist say. He gonna be su'prised."

"Su'prised at what?"

"Su'prised at they ain't gonna be no house to move the people out."

"Which people?"

"People usta be in this yere house."

"But they ain't gonna be no people yere."

"Usta be."

"Usta be ain't is. Besides—how he gonna move people which ain't is outa house that ain't is neither? Tell me that."

"That what I say—he gonna be su'prised. He gonna say—'How I gonna move these people —'"

"Which people?" "

"People whose name it say on that papah."

"Wait a minute, now. Wait a minute. You's gettin' way head of yousef. Which papah y'all talkin' 'bout?"

"Papah at say for the people to move outa they house in forty-eight hours."

"Which house?" :

"This house."

"But they ain't gonna be no house yere when he come, you crazy fool."

And then they started all over again, going round and round like a couple of dogs trying to catch each other's tails.

We got the toilet bowl out of the dirt. The two niggers tied their scraps and stood looking at my pile of wood.

"Go ahead—take it," said Russ.

"Wait a minute—" I said.

"Let 'em have it," said Russ. "We'll get more."

One of them took the belt from his pants—put it around the pile of boards, and went off with the load on his shoulders.

Stoodie was trying to figure out a way to carry the toilet bowl. He raised it up to the side of his hip.

"Pow'ful heavy," he said. "Can't do it that-a way—might slip. Put it ovah my shoulder, I guess. Ovah my haid."

Russ and I helped. We lifted it up high and let it down, bottom side up, over his head with the weight on his shoulders and against the front of his derby. It worked.

"All Ah needs now," he said, "is a silver sword and a red plume on this heah thing like the Elks wear when they pee-rades down the street on the Foth of July."

He stuck out his hand. Once more, he was the Supreme High Commander.

"Misto Russ," he said, and his voice had a strange booming sound, "Ah'm mighty proud of the way y'all hepped me get this job done. Ah thanks yo from the bottomest depths of my heart." And then he, too, marched down the alley and Russ and I were alone.

"Yes," I said, "you sure did a nice job, Russ. The lot's all cleaned up—no mess. The outfit that owned the house ought to give you a vote of thanks. But what did you get out of it for yourself? Tell me that."

"Satisfaction," he said. "Knowing the job was done right."

"I suppose that's gonna help us keep warm? Pay for the chances we took? If the cops do catch up—you'll be the first to get smacked into jail. You engineered the job."

"'T ain't right," he said, "to burn up another fellow's house."

"But o-keh to help tear it down?"

"It will get into the papers," he said. "It will discourage other outfits from throwing families without jobs out into the streets."

"Aw—nuts," I said. "Your arguments are lousy. Sometimes they're so lousy they stink."

We started home. The wind had died down and the sky was dark and the snow was coming down hard. The dirty streets and the ramshackle houses were fast getting covered with a clean layer of white. We were near the city limits, but actually in the town called Hamtramck. A half block down the street, across the main artery boulevard, hung a huge sign that read —

*YOU ARE NOW ENTERING*
*DYNAMIC DETROIT.*

Halfway home Russ stopped in at the feed and fuel place and laid out fifty cents for another bag of soft coal.

# CHAPTER XXVII

A couple of days after the wrecking bee Russ and I and Rita were sitting in the house after supper. The dishes and stuff had been cleared from the table and the kid was asleep and Rita was unraveling an old sweater. There was not even a newspaper to read, and as we sat there around the old stove I guess we were all thinking about the same thing—that is, when Mr. Holt would open up and let Russ and me go back to work in his factory.

Russ took two one-dollar bills from his pocket and spread them out on the table slow and carefully and then made a systematic search for small change and dug up two dimes and two pennies. These he laid in a neat pile on top of the two paper dollars.

"Two dollars and twenty-two cents," he said. "It's our all time low."

"A dollar and a quarter of that," said Rita, "will have to go for another bottle of baby food. That leaves ninety-seven cents to live on till you get a job or we go on the dole. If you should happen to go back to that relief office tomorrow, you can tell them you're dead broke."

"Might snow tonight," said Russ. "If it does, I'll have a couple of sidewalks to clean off in the morning."

"And if it doesn't snow," she said, "and there're no sidewalks to clean, you'll have to get some potatoes somewhere. Maybe you'd like to borrow some from Dad."

"Farmers pray for rain," said Russ, "when there's a drought. Let's us pray for snow?"

"That ain't gonna do no good," I said. "Mr. Holt's the only one can help us out of this fix. I've only got six bucks left myself. When that's gone I'll be in the same fix."

"Well," said Russ, trying to be sarcastic, "let's have a little prayer meeting right now—just the three of us. Sing a couple of songs, read a chapter from Mr. Holt's book, get down on the floor on our knees and ask Mr. Holt to open up and let us go back to work. Might do some good."

"Might, at that," I said. "I read in a Sunday paper how ideas from one mind can pass through the air and go into the mind of another. It showed pictures of two brains and static jumping from one to the other, like lightning. Mental telegraphy, I think is what the guy called it."

"Not mental telegraphy," said Rita, who knew all the big words in the dictionary. "Mental telepathy is what that is."

"Yeh," I said, "that's it. Mental telepathy. Who knows but what that's how it works when a guy prays. Who knows but what Mr. Holt would get the drift if we got down on our knees and sort of told him how tough things were getting for us and that there was a kid and that we'd like awful much to get back to work? Who knows?"

"Dog-gone, Bennie," he said, "I believe you got something there. It's a kind of mental radio system—your mind and his. But still, if it works, why does he need all those H.P.'s to tell him what us fellows talk and think about in the plant?"

"Nah," I said, "you don't get the idea. This mental telepathy stuff ain't some kind of stool pigeon. It only works on certain levels—between certain minds. It has to be spiritual stuff. Bum thoughts sort of bog themselves down—at least that's the way the guy explained it."

"Oh," said Russ. "No reception, you might say."

"Something like that. A fellow has to be in the right mood. And if a fellow's in the right mood, he ain't gonna have no bum thoughts. Bum thoughts, the fellow explained in the paper, are like static. What do you think?" I asked Rita.

"I dén't know anything about the principle of the thing," she said, "but I think it's one of those things that works if you think it works—at least for yourself. It's like praying. If you don't think it's going to do any good—it's a cinch that it won't. But if a person is sure it's going to work it puts him in the frame of mind where he's liable to get good results just by being in the right frame of mind."

"Well, Bennie, here," said Russ, "is in the right frame of mind to send a little prayer to Mr. Holt. I'm not—my belly's too empty. Go ahead, Bennie—tell him we haven't had a square meal for a month. Tell him we want our jobs back—that we wanna go to work—now. And then, just by way of a postscript, you might add that if we don't get a job pretty quick we'll come down there and get that five bucks he's holding back on our badges. You listen to his broadcasts—no reason why he shouldn't listen to yours."

"There you go," said Rita. "It's not what you're saying that matters—only that it shows how you feel about things—about the man who can give you a job when no one else can. You're all wet."

"Me?" he said. "How do you figure?"

"When you were in the drop forge you were always getting into arguments and fights—laying off when you felt like it—trying to act smart. You're the same now."

"What of it?"

"Nothing of it. Except that we don't have anything to eat—not enough coal or wood to keep warm, and the baby's got to be fed on stuff from the drug store because I've no milk. That's all."

"What's that got to do with what you just said? About being smart?"

"You lost your job in the drop forge. You got put on production—where the lay-offs hit hardest."

"They threw out the machine I was on."

"You were the only two that got transferred—you and Bennie. Bennie got it in the neck because he was your friend. The others stuck. If you hadn't got transferred you'd be working now, getting out dies for the new models—earning money. I know. I've been listening to factory talk all my life."

"She's right, Russ," I said. "Johnson hated our guts."

"And I hated his."

"That's it," said Rita, getting up from her chair. "You hated Johnson—you hate the factory—you hate your own job. If it wasn't for Bennie here giving us board money, we'd starve. We're three months behind with the rent. There's nothing to eat—nothing for me and the baby. And you sit there and make wisecracks about the man whose name is on the pay checks."

"Cripes," he said. "I wanted to pull out of this mess when we could—when we had the dough. You wouldn't."

"I'm going to live in Detroit."

"That's what you're doing."

"With a fellow that's no good for a husband."

"Me?" He got up. They stood facing each other —across the stove. Her eyes snapped. His face was white as a sheet.

"You! Yes—you, Russ," she said. "A fellow that can't keep a good job when he's got one—that tries to be smart when he's broke—tries to be funny when there's nothing to be funny about."

"If I was serious," he said, "I'd go nuts."

"And if you don't get serious—I'll go nuts. We're in a fix, Russ."

"Don't I know it? I don't like it any better than you do."

"Before I married you I had money—things to eat—things to wear."

"So did I. And I didn't have to listen to some woman tell me I was no good—I don't now. If you can't take it—pack up your stuff. Leave the kid and get out."

"Listen," I said, "what's the matter with you two? What's the —"

"I'll get out," she snapped. "I'll be a taxi-dancer again—earn my own living. But if you think I'll leave the baby, you got another think coming. I'll get out tomorrow."

"Get out now, if you want to. But I'm telling you—the kid stays."

"You're crazy."

"The kid stays—Rita."

"He comes with me—Russ. I'm the mother."

"I'm the father."

"He's mine, Russ. I went through agony to get him. I'll take him or else —"

"Hey—hey," I said, "cut it out. What's the idea—going on like this? Nobody's going —"

"Stay out of it—Bennie," she said. "We're going to settle this—now. It's been hanging fire a long time. It's between me and him."

Someone knocked at the door.

"Wait a minute," I said. "Be quiet till I see who it is."

It was a messenger boy from the telegraph office. He had two telegrams—one was for me and one was for Russ.

"You have to sign," I said to Russ. "One's for you."

They were from the Holt Motor Company—both alike.

"Report back to work at once," they read.

Russ looked at his a couple of minutes and then let it drift to the table. I picked it up, gave it to Rita. She read it.

"Now let's see," I said, "what were you two arguing about?" .

They both stood there looking like a couple of spanked kids. Neither one said a word. I got my coat.

"We're going to celebrate," I said. "I'm gonna get a steak and some potatoes. Not a rib steak—a Porterhouse as big as a platter. And the potatoes are gonna be Florida prime—not number two U. S. spuds like they hand out to the reliefers. I'm giving you two thirty minutes to take back what you said to each other and make up. Hard times is over." And then I left.

And when I got back all was peaceful and sweet in the house. Russ had on a clean shirt and was shaved; she had powdered her nose and had on a clean apron. Everything was all hunky-dorry. I made some talk, just to be saying something.

"Butcher asked me," I said, "if I wanted a bone for the dog."

" 'Nah,' I said, 'we got rid of the mutt. The way we had to shove bones into him was a crime. He ate as much as a cow. He wasn't satisfied with just any old bone. There had to be meat on 'em or he'd sit up all night and howl.'"

I fried the steak. Russ cooked the potatoes and Rita put the stuff on the table, and to make it look like a party, she lighted a stub of a candle. Everything was just swell and we ate until we all liked to bust. And then Russ had to go and spoil it all by making a speech.

"Bennie," he said, "you did noble. I'm ashamed of myself for acting like I did there a little while back—getting mean—taking it out on Rita, just because things were tough and I couldn't see any way out."

"That goes for me, too," said Rita, going over and sitting on his lap. "I told Russ I was sorry—I lost my head. If it hadn't been for you —"

"Aw—forget it," I said. "It's all over now. If anybody gets any credit, it's Mr. Holt—for calling us back. You can't tell me it was an accident—those telegrams coming just when they did."

"Maybe," said Russ. "But dog-gone you, Bennie, I'll bet you used a little of that mental telepathy on Mr. Holt. I'll bet you broadcast a little message to him—let him know we were at the end of our rope."

"Maybe," I said. "I think I'll just let you guess."

Rita was fiddling around with his shirt collar—running her fingers through his hair.

"Well," I said, getting up, "I guess I'll turn in. Gotta get up early tomorrow, and besides, I got to write a letter yet to a man about a dog."

# CHAPTER XXVIII

IT WAS SURE GOOD, AFTER THE LONG LAY-OFF, TO GET BACK IN THE FACTORY AND BE WORKing again. It was good to hear again the slam of steel against steel; the whir of the high-speed machines; the purring of the motors pulling the conveyors. It was good to see again the faces of the old men who worked on the line; the sweepers; the crib-men who handed out tools and always bellyached when you asked them to do something. It was good, almost, to smell again the stink of the coal-tar disinfectant used in the toilets; it was good to read again the old signs that said "No Running," "No Smoking," "No Spitting," "No Sitting Down While Working."

Russ and me got our jobs back on the line, and Norm and Gus and Jeff and Jerry and most of the other old fellows were there, and they were all feeling good and raring to go, and every once in a while the whole gang, to let off steam, would throw their heads back and let out a long howl like a bunch of soul-tortured coyotes.

The first day a lot of the buggies were empties and the line was slow and irregular because there were a lot of new men all through the departments, and even us old men were slow and out of practice. After a long lay-off it takes weeks to get the new fellows broke in and the old men up on their toes so that production is normal. There were not enough helpers to break in the new men and the line bosses stepped down off the buggies and worked shoulder to shoulder with us fellows.

The motors for the new models, as far as we could see, were exactly the same. Same kind of crankshaft; same gray iron pistons; same kind of heads on the cylinders. In fact, it was hard to see where they could be improved because they were just about perfect. But there were plenty of changes and improvements in the machines and in the factory. There were more air-conditioned cages up high off the floor with colored lights that went off and on that showed where the conveyors were dragging; more glass rooms where the temperatures were controlled. And the automatics in our department that worked on the cylinder blocks were more up to date. Streamlined, these were, and beautiful to look at. There were no cams and open gears to catch the men's clothes; no belts or line-shafts to get out of whack and hold up the work. They were self-contained, each with its own group of motors, and all adjustments enclosed, so that the men were no longer able to

change the cutting speeds or controls. They were beauties. Looking at them working there in tight groups or long rows, you had the feeling that there was something mysterious about them because they were so complicated and swift.

The broaching machines had a place for the rough motor blocks to go in; a place for the finished work to come out. What happened inside—you couldn't see, but when the rough blocks came out they were broached.

The milling machines were like merry-go-rounds, set on edge to save space. The blocks took a ride, ten or twelve at a time—up on one side—down on the other. Cutting tools took off strips of hot metal. Rough and finish work in the same operation. When the blocks came to the end of the ride, they were milled.

Gus was back on the same boring machine. The ventilator fan was still up near the ceiling over Russ's head, and Russian Bill was still heaving the motors off the end of the line with a steel lever. These things were the same. But the power tools on the line—the wrenches and drills and the hammers, had more power and speed. All of them were driven by high cycle, high frequency motors. There were no more pneumatics to fuss and sputter and get out of whack and cut down the speed—electricity had taken over the job.

During the lunch period Amos and me went over to final assembly and had a look at the new models. When we got back, Russ was still sitting there on an empty box eating his lunch. Amos started telling about the new jobs.

"They got the battery under the hood," he said. "Every job's got two tail-lights."

"Big stuff," said Russ, peeling back a banana and sticking a long leg out into the aisle. "Kids will be selling extras tonight. They'll be hollering 'All about the new models! Two tail-lights!' You see if they don't."

"They're more streamlined," I said. "There's a little cabinet in the instrument board to put your gloves in."

"What's that amount to?" he said. "The new models are right here in the shop—the automatics. They're something to look at—something to talk about. They're faster this year. This year they'll flood the country with new cars quicker—we'll all get laid off sooner and there'll be a longer depression."

There were a couple of new fellows, all eyes and ears, sitting off to one side, eating meat sandwiches out of a big paper bag. Hill-billies, I figured. Russ looked them over and I guess he figured the same as I did.

"They don't want us to work steady," said Russ. "They want to speed up production—get out a year's work in three or four months—so they can close up the shops and kick us out in the streets. This yearly model stuff—this talk about the auto shows—is a lot of baloney. It gives em an excuse to shut down—lay us off and move in a lot of new machines to take our place and speed up things still more. It hurts us but at the same time it hurts them, too, but they're too dumb to see it.

They got the public educated into waiting for the auto shows to buy cars; they got the dealers educated to artificial depreciation so they'll take two hundred dollars off on a last year's model that's never been off the floor; they've got the workers educated to take it on the chin without squawking. They speed up production—work to beat the band for a few months—and shut down. We get laid off. The men in the steel mills, tire factories, cotton fields, saw-mills, railroads and coal mines get laid off, too. No pay checks, or if they're still working two or three days a week, they're too broke to buy cars. And then Mr. Holt and the others sit back and bellyache about hard times. They lay off more men—make it impossible for more men to buy cars."

"Yeh, but look at the wages we're getting," I said, "compared with the coal miners and fellows that work in the cotton mills."

"Yeh, look at 'em," said Russ. "Figure out the time you're laid off and look at 'em at the end of the year, like any fellow does that's in business. At the end of the year any man that works on production is broke."

"How they gonna run steady," said Amos, "when there's no sales."

"Make sales," said Russ. "Not by high-pressure selling and by telling dealers to burn up old cars, but by getting things running steady. Cut out the yearly model stuff and give us workers so much a year. They could do it, if they made up their minds to it. But they're scared. They're scared they won't get all the profits themselves, and so they move in more automatics to put more men out of work. Pretty soon they'll have us all out—even the sweepers. Pretty soon all the factories will be perfect—all the machines automatic. And there'll be no one left to buy cars, and some wise guy will come along and say, 'Business is rotten. Let's burn up the new cars, too. Let's have a burn-up-a-new-car week. Put ads in the papers—everybody burn up a new car.' There'll be radio speeches. There'll be pictures of Mr. Holt standing beside the mayor with a lighted torch in his hand ready to set the big pile a-blazing."

Fellows gathered around to hear what he said. Niggers—hill-billies—men new in the shop. I got his ear.

"Man alive, Russ," I said, "you're in the shop now, pipe down." He paid no attention.

"You'll see what'll happen," he said. "From now on we'll be getting into the swing. We'll go a little faster—production will speed up a little more each day. New men will be crowded and transferred; old men will be pushed; little kinks ironed out. In about a month we'll be getting out five days production in one. It'll go along like that for a while till high-pressure selling breaks down and the dealers' places are filled. Then we'll get cut from five days to four. But still it'll be 'hurry-up, hurry-up' till you'd think every man in the country was crazy anxious to buy a new car. And then we'll get cut from four days to three. And that's the time to pull out—not wait for things to get better, because they won't. That's the beginning of another new-model depression. I was pretty green when I first came here to work, I'd heard a lot of big talk about Mr. Holt—how swell he

treated his men. Now I know more. The other time I wanted to work for a roll. This time—all I want is enough to pay what I owe and get out."

Nice talk, I thought. Here we were back in the shop, earning good money. Everybody was happy to be back on the job—and Russ crabbing. The first day not hardly started yet—and already he was shooting off his big mouth, telling how he hated the shop.

The two-minute bell rang and the fellows started putting lunch boxes away and throwing papers into waste cans. Some of them hurried up to the crib and got tools, or paper cuspidors which cost a penny. Straw bosses hurried about giving orders. Russ got up from his box.

"It's all right," I said, "to shoot off your mouth when you're outside, but for the love of Mike—use a little judgment. There's guys here are liable to think you're trying to stir up a big bunch of trouble."

"Aw—nuts," he said, "I'll say what I want to."

And then the bell rang for starting and the line began moving and there was a rising burst of sound like a storm, as the electric motors set all the machines and conveyors in motion.

# CHAPTER XXIX

That first day ended up with Russ getting me into another mess. Coming out of the factory we noticed a bunch of fellows on the opposite side of the street hanging around a new eating joint. We crossed over, thinking we might get a free hand-out, and to see what the joint was like. It was a new kind of dump, run by a couple of Greeks, and it was called, "The Merry-Go-Round."

Through the big window we could see how it worked. Inside, there was a big circular oval around the outside of which the fellows sat. In front of the men there was an endless procession of trays that moved slowly around under glass covers. The fellows sitting around on the stools lifted the covers and took little dishes of stuff from the trays as they passed.

It was the grand opening. The front of the building was decorated with flags and a couple of yodeling cowboys were entertaining the crowd. A fat Greek went about handing out menus —"bill-o-ferries" he called them. He tried to get the fellows to go in.

"A'right, boys," he kept saying, "you get cop-koffie for nuttin'. Stap einsy, now. Today you get cop-koffie for nuttin'."

We took a menu. Meals were forty cents. Through the window we could figure out the whole system. You put down your money and got a plate with meat on it. Then you found a place in the circle and picked what you wanted off the trays as they came past your nose. Russ studied it carefully.

"Something wrong here, Bennie," he said. "What it is—I don't know. But something tells me these Greeks are using bad judgment."

"Looks o-keh to me. Let's go in—try their coffee."

"Idea may be all right," he said, "at a church sociable. But not here. They got the right idea in the wrong place. What's to hinder that gang in there cleaning out the joint? What holds 'em back?"

"Decent manners," I said. "Every time a man grabs something off that conveyor it leaves him with another empty dish. They got it fixed up so a man can't make a pig of himself without adver-

tising it. After he gets a couple of dozen empty dishes stacked up at his elbow he gets ashamed of himself and quits."

"Maybe—" he said, "maybe. Maybe you know this gang better than I do. And then again—maybe you don't. A man will do things in this dynamic Detroit that he wouldn't do in a good Methodist neighborhood. The dynamite sorta gets under his skin."

We went in to try out the coffee. The coffee was free, all right, but there was a catch. You had to put down the dough for a regular meal to get it.

It made Russ feel mean—I could see that—and I was for getting out. "Nothing doing," he said, "this is too good a chance to pass up."

After a man's been on a starvation diet for a couple of months it takes him a long time to catch up on his eating. In those first days we could have eaten a dozen square meals every twenty-four hours.

We paid our dough, got our plates with the meat, and were looking for places to sit when we saw Gus and Jerry. There were two empty stools next to them which we took, Russ next to Gus and me on the outside. Among the fellows opposite us sat Russian Bill, the fellow who heaved the motors off the end of the line.

We started in. Russ grabbed a baked apple, two tapioca puddings and toast. I took a potato, a dish of squash and two Jellos. That gave each of us four extra dishes. We looked around. Some of the fellows had empty dishes stacked up like poker chips. They weren't embarrassed. The only ones who were embarrassed of themselves were fellows like Russ and me who had just come in—got a late start. Instead of holding back, it was a kind of game—a game to see who could get the most empty dishes. Gus and Jerry weren't doing so bad. Jerry had empty dishes stacked up on both sides of his plate. Gus not so many.

The fellows were all feeling good. Russian Bill was loud-mouthed—trying to be funny.

"Speech!" Someone hollered.

Russian Bill got up to his feet.

"Ladies and Gents," he hollered, "I'm macking now a spitch. It is to tell you somethin'. It is to say—when Grik meets Grik dey stat a restaurant."

He sat down to loud cheers.

"Yah," someone hollered, "and hand out free coffee."

Russ was beginning to act funny. He piled Gus's empty dishes back on the conveyor.

"Listen, Gus," he said, "I'm sending these back to the kitchen. You didn't give Bennie and me a fair start—you got too many."

A short Greek in a black coat came up. ——

"Waiter," said Russ.

"We got no waites," said the Greek. "I'm de manaje. You kut it out—what you doing. I call poleets-manos—you get fonny —"

"I wouldn't," said Russ. "There'll be a riot in here if you do. You got a chance yet—to be a good sport."

The Greek hurried up front to the telephone. Someone from the other side of the room threw a bun that just missed his ear. Fellows were getting louder—calling across to each other.

"Speech! Speech!" they hollered at Russ. He got up.

"Gents," he said, waving a bunch of green onions in one hand, "I see fellows here that're not doing their stuff—that're trying to hold up the line. Not getting out production like they oughta. Gus, here's, only got ten empty plates. That's not enough—that's laying down on the job. Vas's de mather, Gus," he said, laying a hand on his shoulder, "can't you step on it en luddle? Can't you kip opp? You vant I shood gif you a tranzfere—dun't you? You vant I shood poot you on Blue Mass?"

The fellows were getting wild. Laughed at the way Russ imitated Gus's Dutch accent. The Greek hurried back and tried to get Russ to leave.

"You nice fellas," he said, taking Russ by the arm. "You go now—I give you cigarro."

"Nothing doing," said Russ. "You called the cops. Let them put me out."

A slice of toast sailed over our heads. The Greek gave Russ a jerk. He was showing bad judgment.

"Common now—" he said. "I gettin' med—now. You sonababits, I ——"

Russ slapped him across the face with a handful of onions. The Greek beat it.

"As I was saying," said Russ to the crowd —

I yanked his coat.

"Love of Mike, Russ," I said, "let's get the hell outa here. You're starting a riot."

"Sit down—you," a guy hollered. "The big guy is talking."

"As I was saying," said Russ, "we're not getting the jobs off the line. Take this model, for instance—" and he pointed to a dish of green Jello drifting by, "it's got no wheels on it."

He picked up a cookie and stuck it into the side of the Jello.

"En no head-lights," said Gus, who stuck in a couple of olives.

"And no bumpers," said Jerry, who added a piece of celery.

The idea caught like a house on fire and as the green Jello passed down the line, each man added something. A doughnut made a good looking spare tire, a piece of cake made a neat luggage trunk, a tooth pick was a radio antenna. By the time it reached the end of the line in the kitchen it was completely assembled. The fellows were clever. They built up sedans from baked potatoes; they used rolls to build coupes; dill pickles for long, sporty roadsters, whipped cream and catsup did nicely to touch up the trim.

The Greek was not long figuring something was hay-wire. He mobilized the help from the kitchen and came howling—headed for Russ. But he never made it. Some guy let out a yell —"Men do your stuff!"

The Greek and his crew were stopped by such a barrage of cream puffs, boiled potatoes, doughnuts, custards, dill pickles, and jelly rolls as you never saw in your life. They ducked through doors out of sight.

But the men didn't stop. They had got into the spirit of the thing, were having fun. They began heaving stuff at each other—one side battling the other. One guy, not knowing which side he was on, pitched cottage cheese salads into a revolving fan.

I began kicking Russ on the shins—trying to get his mind off the rumpus.

"The cops, Russ!" I said. "They'll be here in a minute—run us all in."

I knocked a dish of pickled beets out of his hand to the floor. Gave him a push through a door. We were in the kitchen, but even then he was for going back for more. We heard the siren.

"The riot squad!" I said. "Now or never." That got him started.

We ducked out of a back door and ran down the alleys. Then we stopped for breath behind an old shed to clean the mess off our clothes. Russ could hardly stand up for laughing.

"Judast, Bennie," he said between breaths, "you got egg in your hair—mashed potato all down your neck. Where's your hat?"

"You're a swell guy," I said, trying to dig a piece of hard-boiled egg out of my ear. "The very first day you try to act smart. Hadn't been for me you'd be spending a few days in the cooler."

"I wouldn't have missed it," he said. "Not for nothing. I got a sideache—from laughing. I'm weak."

He had his coat off. He was digging the remains of a baked potato out of a pocket.

"That guy," he said, "throwing stuff into that 'lectric fan—what a mess!"

"What's so funny?" I said, getting more and more peeved.

"What's so funny?" he said. "Everything. I got Russian Bill with a baked banana. He got you square in the neck with a big handful of mashed potato. That baked banana—it smeared all over his face—went smack. Didn't you see?"

"No."

"And the Greek—when he turned his head and we all let him have it—dog-gone, Bennie, I liked to died laughing. It was rich."

He went off into a spasm again. My coat was a mess. I'd lost my hat. I couldn't see anything funny to laugh at.

We began walking again, but hadn't gone far when he stopped.

"Wait a minute," he said. "You still got egg in your hair. I've heard about guys having egg on their vest, but you got it all over your hair."

And that started him laughing again.

"Bennie," he said, "you're a mess."

Once more we started. Once more he stopped me again.

"What's this," he said, "on your coat? Cottage cheese! I wonder who hit you with that? Not Russian Bill. Mashed potato—he had. Dog-gone—Bennie, why didn't you duck? He got you square in the neck."

Then he doubled up with laughter again.

I was mad.

"Blame it all, Russ," I said, "I'm getting sick and tired of the crazy-fool way you act. I don't see nothing to laugh at. I don't think it's funny to wreck a guy's joint—getting hit with that stuff—losing my hat. If I'd-a known what you was figuring on doing, I wouldn't-a went in. I''d-a let the cops got you. I'm fed up on that kinda stuff."

He was laughing so hard he was crying. I went across the street and walked home by myself.

# CHAPTER XXX

After a couple of weeks the engineers got things running smooth. A few machines were pulled out; a half dozen fellows were transferred, and some laid down their tools and walked out. And then the trouble-makers began to show up.

Gus, who ran a boring machine, got behind again and couldn't keep up with the niggers, and Jerry, who held his job on the line very well, began getting chummy with Gus. There was nothing on them—Jerry was too smart for that, but they were both queer; and the way they hung around together, getting off by themselves during lunch, made it look bad.

Russ got along fine for a while until production went up to seventy-five hundred motors a day, but when everything was going smooth and it jumped to eight thousand one day and the bosses were riding the buggies, trying to make a new record, he got into trouble. It was the belt again. He was back in the same old rut—taking it easy, day dreaming, not snapping into it like the others, but letting the belt set his pace for him—three hundred and twenty an hour. Three or four times, before lunch, I jumped in and helped him get up. The last time I lit into him.

"You wanna get fired," I said, "why don't you just go up front and ask for your time? Why drag it out? Why get a reputation for not being able to hold a job on the line?"

"Aw, Bennie," he said, "now you've got me balled up. I was trying to figure out a new drag —"

"Clamming!" I said. "Day dreaming! You got a wife and kid, Russ."

"I know it."

"Then why don't you step on it—snap into it?"

"Do we have to go all over that again?" he said, good-natured and easy. "I thought I told you once, Bennie, how it was. If I had to think about this measly, no-account job—I'd go nuts. Suppose you tell the big boss to cut down a notch on the rheostat under his desk? Go up and have a talk with him."

I was disgusted. I got him up in his station and then stood off near a fountain. The whole place was a-throb with the high beat of the machines. There was no joking—no talking—every man was bent down to his job. Except Russ. Smoke hung like a fog over the hot automatics. A cylinder bor-

ing machine had dull cutters and the whining cry of stellite against hot metal was like screeching brakes above the roar of night traffic. I watched Russ. He was outside of it all—cut off from the speed and sound of it all by the noise of the belt—the one-two-three-four of the slow beats of the thing over his head. Taking it easy—loafing, while good-natured Jeff, a nigger, had a fist full of nuts and was trying to help Russ keep up.

And then I saw Norm, standing near a pile of empty stock boxes, talking to one of the line bosses. Norm was watching Russ, too, and saw me and signalled for me to come over, and then the line boss left.

"I been watching your boy friend," he said. "All day he's been dragging over—bucking the line and stuff."

"I know it," I said, "I just been over there—talking to him."

"Didn't do much good, did it?"

"Well, no —"

"Listen," he said, "I'm gonna ask you somethin'. If you was in my place, trying to get out production, what would you do about him? You wanna be a straw boss some day—let's see you answer that question."

He had a sarcastic grin on his face that I didn't like.

"Gosh, Norm," I said, "I don't know. Russ is a good man—smart mechanic, and all that. Maybe we ain't got the right job for him." He laughed.

"We got the right job, all right," he said. "Don't worry about that. We got the right job. But we've got the wrong belt."

"You mean —

"You know what I mean," he snarled. "Or else, you're dumber than I figured you are. Why don't you tell me stuff instead of holding back on me? Instead of letting a dumb line boss show you up?"

"You know me, Norm," I said. "I've always worked with you, ain't I? Always told you things—even when it got the fellows sore at me."

"Na-a-a-ah—you ain't told me things," he said. "What're you tryin' to give me? Tryin' to tell me we ain't got the right job for that fellow just because he's got himself timed up with that belt. Get back on the job now. And tell your boy friend I'll have a belt for 'im tomorrow that's got a little more snap to it—that'll help him keep up with the others."

I didn't go near Russ all the rest of that shift. Didn't look at him even to see whether he was dragging over or not. And at night, when we went home, I didn't say nothing. What's the use, I figured. I didn't want Russ to think I'd had a hand in it. Didn't even want him to know what Norm had talked to me about it.

The next morning, when we came to work at the factory, there was another belt on the ventilator. Or maybe, it was the same old belt with more splices. The rhythm was changed—it was faster.

Instead of four beats, there were at least a half dozen each time the belt went around over the pulleys. Instead of four definite beats, they were all strung together—too fast to follow. Norm and the machine flunkeys had done a good job, I thought. I had to admit that Norm's idea was better than mine about getting Russ a transfer. It costs money to break a man in on a new job. I figured Russ would get straightened out now and be a regular.

Our shift went on and Russ took his place on the line. He noticed the change and looked up at the ventilator and his lips moved. If Norm saw the look on his face he must have had a good laugh.

The line was fast again, right from the start. I knew that it would be. Things were running smooth; all the little troubles that had been holding us back had been straightened out, and each day from now on the big bosses would be trying for a new record.

Figures would rise like the numbers on the chart of a boiler getting up steam. Eight thousand—eight thousand four hundred—eight thousand five hundred—eight thousand six hundred, maybe. Theoretically, production capacity of the line was nine thousand motors in twenty-four hours, but that figure had, as yet, never been reached. Maybe this time. For Mr. Holt and the engineers and the bosses it would be a big thing. Even us helpers would share a small part of the credit.

Russ got along swell. For once he was up on his toes, doing his share of the work, giving the job his attention. He had his feet wide apart, jaws set, and was facing the stream of motors coming down the line towards his station. He was the old Russ—Horatio on the bridge—doing his stuff—licking the tar out of a job that was tough.

I was beginning to think everything was going to work out nice, when along just before noon, he signalled me for relief. I went over and even before I stepped into his place, I could see he was mad enough to bite nails.

"Who squealed on me?" he said.

"You mean about changing the belt?"

"You know what I mean."

"Gosh, Russ—not me."

"Who then?"

"How should I know? Some line boss, I expect."

"Any idea which one?"

"Why, no, Russ. There's a dozen of 'em riding by here all day. They get paid, you know, for telling straw bosses things. Besides—how do you know it's a scheme? Belts don't last forever. Splices wear out—you know that."

"Aw—nuts," he said. "Don't talk like a kid. You know why that belt's been changed. And so do I. And I'd like to know the guy whose idea it was. I'd take one sweet crack at him—and get my time."

And then he left and he was gone a lot longer than three minutes. And when he came back he stepped in and I worked alongside for a minute or so, even though I knew Norm would be eyeing

us, because I wanted to talk to him and get him straightened out.

"You got a chance, now," I said, "to get into this job right. Forget about that belt—let yourself go along with the hum of the shop and you won't have no trouble. That one-two-three-four stuff pretty near got you fired. I don't know who changed that belt, and I don't care. But I'm glad of it because now you can straighten out and show Norm you can handle this job."

He threw a handful of good nuts into the scrap, and they stung against the metal side of the barrel like shot.

"Get outa here," he said. "You wear me down. Get outa here—before I step on you."

# CHAPTER XXXI

RUSS HAD NO MORE TROUBLE KEEPING UP ON THE JOB BUT AFTER THE BELT WAS CHANGED he started getting mean and bad-tempered. Coming home from the factory at night he'd play with the kid for a while, but after supper when the kid had been put to bed, he would be gloomy and nervous and aching to get into an argument, or else he would tear off to some beer joint and drink more beer and spend more money than he should have. Sometimes he dragged me along but nearly always I came home first and alone. Later, when he'd come into the house, like as not, Rita would be awake and would want to know how much money he'd spent and there'd be an argument and in the morning, when I'd get up, I'd find him asleep on the old couch. It got so he had to spend all his spare time doing something foolish and wild. There was no sitting quiet in the house any more after supper reading the paper, or telling Rita about things that happened in the factory.

Before the landlord was paid up he spent a whole pay check for an old car that wouldn't run, and when the guy towed it up we pushed it into the old shed in the back of the house and in three days he had it all apart. Rita wanted a coupe and she said:

"Why a touring car, Russ?"

"Haul more gear in it," he said.

"What gear?"

"The outboard and stuff."

A couple of days later he started hammering a trailer hitch out of some rough pieces of iron and she knew he still had his mind set on clamming. Sometimes I tried to figure out how it would end.

He was full of unrest—hated his job more than ever, and got into the habit of taking time off for job-hunting whenever he felt like it, or heard a rumor that some other factory was hiring. Always they asked him where he'd worked last, and always, if he told them the truth, a telephone call to the Holt Motor Company put an end to his prospects. It was foolish because the Holt

Motor Company has a reputation for paying good wages and giving steadier work than the others. It made Rita mad. The time wasted running around cut big holes in the pay checks.

And then, one day, when the February snows had all melted away and there was a balmy breeze off the lakes, he laid off a whole day for no reason whatever. Late in the afternoon we got home the same time. He came up to the house with river mud on his shoes and carried a bundle of green stuff that looked like spinach. Water cress—he called it. Rita knew he hadn't been at the factory and after sitting around awhile he said to her:

"How about supper?"

"I'm laying off today," she said. "I'm not working."

"That's too bad," he said. "Bennie and I will have to eat out."

We left the house and got supper in a restaurant and afterwards we walked until we found ourselves on a high bridge over the ship canal in the rear of the Holt plant. The night air was soft and damp, and there was a hint of rain in the air; and the whole vast plant with its hundreds of stacks and tremendously long buildings bathed in their own light lay there on the flat land against the black Michigan night. The whole sound was like the roar of a mighty river. Small blue lightning from the electric welding machines in the steel body plant flashed sharply; the sputtering glare from the Bessemers turned the sky a deep, rosy red. We could see plainly the towering shape of the blast furnace; the long darkish lines of the rolling mill; the hundreds of lighted windows in the final assembly plant. Nearest to us was the foundry and the glass plant and the rear axle building, and farthest away the coke ovens and the giant power house with its cluster of high silver stacks carrying the words—Holt Motor Company—in glowing letters fifty feet high. Piles of iron ore and coal stood out against the heavy darkness like mountains, and rolling billows of steam from the quenching tower drifted over them like masses of clouds.

The bigness of it all, seeing it all there, made me feel like a poet. I thought of a line from Mr. Holt's book.

"'With machinery,' I said, 'for its Messiah-America is safe.'"

"Sometimes," said Russ, "you make me very sad, Bennie. To me this is all very depressing. You think of the new automobiles being made in there tonight; I think of the thousands of men that will be pouring out of that place pretty soon with strained looks and dead faces—looking as though they had been released from a torture chamber. They'll go home with the sound and fury of the machines hot in their blood. I can be calm about it tonight; I got some of the strain out of my system today—watching a hell-diver. But other nights—I know what it is. I know what it is to lay awake nights with the noise in my head—machines pounding—not being able to get away from the thing. I see motors—hundreds of them—pouring out of the dark. The other night I had a dream. I was all alone on the line. I had my axe and the motors were pouring—coming at me, and I was smashing them up with my axe. Some night I'm liable to have a nightmare and wreck all the furniture."

"But work, Russ," I said, "work is basic. What would a man do if he didn't work?"

"Ah, Bennie," he said, "right from the book again, ain't it. You talk about work, but you don't know what it is. You think you do, but you don't, because what goes on there—on the assembly lines—at the automatics—is all that you ever learned. You're a part of it—you've been brought up on it—never been away from it—don't know any better. But it's not work, Bennie."

"Russ," I said, "sometimes I think you're plain lazy. Of course it's work. What else is it? Work is something you don't like to do—else you wouldn't get paid for it. I don't like it, myself, but you—you hate it. You'd rather hang around in a swamp, wasting your time—watching a hell-diver—getting your wife mad at you."

"I don't hate work, Bennie," he said, leaning his arms on the rail and talking calm. "I like work—real work. Real work is good for a fellow—it brings out the best there is in you. I've done real work in the woods. I was a faller. The boss would say—'Now this tree, Russ—I want down. Don't wreck the small stuff around it. Don't shatter the trunk—it's got two-three hundred dollars worth of clear bridge timber in it. Lay it so's the loggers can get it out of the brush.' He didn't have to put out a straw boss ro watch me. I didn't have to keep up with a motor. I gave him the best I had in me. And at night I could let down. Read, or sit around the old stove and relax. Didn't have to keep going. Didn't have to tear around—go to beer joints to get the crazy noise out of my system.

"Another time I ran a steam threshing engine. A big brute it was. After working all day the boss would come up to me and say—"'Tomorrow we're threshing for Bill Jones, three sections north. Move the rig over tonight so we can get started at the regular ume in the morning.'

"It sounds simple, Bennie—but it wasn't. It was work—a man's work and I liked it. There was nothing in it for me—no overtime—no extra pay.

"Behind the engine there'd be a string of stuff a block long. Water tank, separator, coal tender, cook shack and tool wagon. I'd get strung out and start down the road, headlight showing the way. There'd be bridges to cross. Not many bridges in that country are built to hold up under thirty-forty ton loads. I'd have to stop, grab a lantern and examine the stringers—use my own judgment. That's hard to do when you're anxious to get there and the timbers are not rotted all the way through and its a long way through rough stubble fields if you go around. Times like that it's easier to take a chance than not. But if you're a good man, you don't. You let down the fence and pull off the road through the fields, hoping you don't drop the engine into a coulee level full of brown tumble weeds. You bog down in soft dirt; uncouple; string out a long piece of cable and get the engine up on hard ground. Plenty of things to worry about. There's the danger of setting the stubble on fire; a leaky boiler flue getting worse; a balky injector that's probably got a duck feather in it; alkali water pulls over and shoots out of the stack. The water glass reads 'full'; but when you look again you see it's a bubble and you don't know whether your crownsheet over the top of the fire is wet or clean bare and ready to pop. All night it's a struggle; all night it's a fight against odds. But in the morning, when the blue light is breaking, you pull up to the stacks and you're through. That's

work, Bennie. The kind that leaves a fellow's manhood intact. Doesn't cramp his ego—doesn't screw him down and leave him feeling weak and mean and little at the end of the day."

"Why didn't you stick to your steam engine?" I asked.

"Why didn't I stick to the manipulator?" he said. "There are no more steam threshers. It's another case of where the automatics have taken a job over. Combines do the work faster. Get a job on one of those and you have to keep up with a gas motor—sewing sacks. The days of steam threshers, like the days of manipulators, are past. When I look at that bunch on the line—bell bottom pants, slick hair, twisted brains, and weak faces—I think to myself, this is the age of automatics and small men."

A lake freighter, leaving the plant, came slowly down the canal and boomed a signal for clearance. The bell rang and we left the bridge.

"You're hard to figure—" I said, "You and your ideas about machines. You love them—you love them not."

"I like machines," he said, "that I run. I don't like those that run me."

That night he was calm and strong—the old Russ. On the way home he stopped in at a chop suey joint and bought some chow mein for Rita.

"She likes it," he said. "I shouldn't have gone off and left her."

But when we got home she was in bed and refused to get up when Russ asked her.

# CHAPTER XXXII

Production stepped up, and Gus, who ran one of the boring machines, got into trouble. The niggers doing the same kind of work raised their figures to seventy, seventy-five—and then eighty—and got along fine, but Gus couldn't raise his production above sixty-five an hour. That made it look bad.

"What's the matter, Gus?" his straw boss would say. "Can't you step on it a little? Can't you keep up with the niggers? You want me to get you a transfer—send you to final assembly to work on blue mass production?"

Gus was always able to think of plenty of excuses. He tried, but he was too old, and the more the straw boss jumped on him, the oftener he had to take time off and go to the toilet.

At the end of the shift the niggers would punch out and start joking and kidding. They'd leave behind the strain of the job and their worries, but Gus would nurse all his troubles carefully and take them all home, and in the morning, when he'd come back to the factory, oxeyed and worried, he'd bring them all carefully back. He was little and bent. It seemed like his troubles were always pressing him down to the floor.

A bunch of us fellows were sitting around one day having lunch when Gus started to talk.

"I hed'n droom las' night," he said.

"Dream, you mean," said Amos. Amos was always pestering Gus. Not to be mean, but just to make us think that he was smarter than he really was.

"Ya—das vat I mean—droom," said Gus. "I hed'n droom dat I died en vent opp to heaven. En ven I got by de ghate—derr vas en long line en I vas on de tail end. En joost as I vas going to go in ——"

Amos interrupted again.

"A couple of H.P.'s stepped up and said 'Where's your badge?'"

"No—no—" said Gus. "I saw de Irisman."

"That was the Holt dream you had," said Amos. "That's a warning. We know the rest—how it goes. All the toilets were on conveyors and a big Russian heaved you off when your three minutes

were up. The angels had composition wings, like the stuff steering wheels are made of, and they played "Turkey In The Straw,' and you danced with a paper cuspidor on your head. You didn't go to heaven, Gus. You had the Holt dream—it's a warning. You better put in for a transfer—get a job sweeping the floor."

"I saw de Irisman," said Gus, "en he —"

"Wait a minute," said Amos. "I thought you killed him—flattened him out in that big machine?"

"Lay off him!" said Jerry, getting up to his feet. "Let him be! We all know you're smart."

"Nuts to you," said Amos.

Gus went on with his story.

"En I saw de Irisman," he said, "en he saw me at de same time.

"'Dar's a Dutsman in hier!' he hollowed 'Dar's a Dutsman in hier—poot him oudt!'

"In vun handt he vas vaiving somet'ing—a chemise. De peoples came running opp—stood all around me.

"'I didn't kill heem,' I said. 'I didn't know he vas in die oldt car. De boss say to me—"Pool die lever." I pool. I didn't know he vas in die oldt car—I didn't know.' But dey vouldn't belief me."

Nobody said a word for a second, and then it was Amos again.

"And then the H.P.'s came running up, eh Gus? And they hauled you away."

"No—" said Gus. "No—I voke opp. But I tell you—so shurr-rr-re I sit hier—I did not do it."

"Did—or didn't not?" said Amos.

"I didn't not—I tell you."

"Hear that," said Amos. "He says 'I didn't not do it.' That means that he did. Stands there and tells us he did. Good gosh—fellows—that's—that's awful!"

Gus threw a dumb look at Jerry. Jerry jumped to his feet and faced Amos. There would have been a fight, I think, but just then one of the timekeeps came up. He had a slip of paper for Jerry. We gathered round him to read it. It was an order, signed by one of the H.P.'s in the front office, and it told him to report at the plant hospital at twelve the next day for an examination.

Jerry forgot about Amos. He was excited. He doubled the paper up and stuffed it into his pocket. Then pulled it out; unscrambled it, and read it again. His hand trembled.

"What do they want to examine me for?" he said. "I'm all right. There's never been nothing the matter with me, fellows. What's the idea? I'm all right."

"Yeh," said Amos, "you're all right, Jerry. Nothing the matter with you—except you got a slight case of bats in the belfry. They'll probably have a look at your head."

The two-minute bell rang and the bunch scattered.

A lot of funny thoughts were mixed up in my head. All afternoon I was nervous.

# CHAPTER XXXIII

The next morning, when Russ and I came into the shop, we saw right quick that there was something hay-wire. Fellows were ganged up around the clock, there was running, and small bunches of men stood around talking and acting excited. Jeff told us the news.

"Jerry's done kilt hissef," he said, hurrying past. "Jumped into the blast furnace—dog-gone."

That much seemed true. For the rest, it was hard to tell what was true and what wasn't. Some said he'd ridden up the long incline in a skip car full of iron ore and coke. Others said he'd climbed the long ladder. One guy, who worked on the graveyard shift and said he'd got the dope straight from a foreman who had charge of tapping the furnace, told us Jerry had climbed up the highline. From there he'd made his way to the super-structure of the furnace where he'd hidden away among the steel girders and pipes all through the first part of the shift. At midnight, when the men were tapping the furnace and the whole sky was red, they'd heard a shout and had looked up. And they'd seen him there, on the very peak of the tower, with his arms stretched out and the red light on his shirt. For a short minute he'd balanced himself against the darkness while the men below were too surprised to even let out a yell. And then he'd raised his arms high over his head and dropped in.

They'd been pouring, then, and it would have been inconvenient to stop, but after the clay plug had been tamped in and the run was over, the foreman had called a couple of H.P.'s and they'd climbed up. They'd found his coat and in it a letter with directions that it be delivered personally to Mr. Holt.

Amos came up all excited.

"The crazy Jew—" he said. "Can you imagine a guy doing that? I always said he was cracked. Here he's been going around for years bragging about how he was going to shut down the plant. We were all going to lay off. It was going to cost Mr. Holt eight hundred tons of good iron. And they didn't even stop pouring."

The two-minute bell rang and the gangs sort of broke —, up. Russ and I walked towards the line. Amos followed.

"Imagine," he said, "a guy crazy like that—writing a letter to Mr. Holt. Mr. Holt won't even hear about it. They're tapping off another batch of hot iron right now. They're running old Jerry outa the spout. In another hour they'll be pouring him into a cylinder block mold. About two-thirty he'll be coming over the line. And here he thought he was going to lay us all off—shut down the shop so we'd have to take a cut on our pay checks. Instead of that, he'll be coming over the line this afternoon. We'll be running nuts on him—I'll be sucking cotter pins in the motor. Too bad he can't know about it. He'd sure be burned up." He laughed at his own joke.

"Lay off," said Russ. "Your jokes give me the shivers. I'm not in the mood for listening to your talk."

Amos and Russ went to their stations.

Norm came shagging up with a brainful of worries.

"Take Jerry's place," he said to me, as though Jerry were just laying off for the day. "I hate to spare you," he said. "It's gonna be crazy-wild today and I'm gonna need more helpers. Do what you can to keep down the gang-talk. We're gonna boost the line—break it up if we can."

"There'll be a lot of bum motors," I said.

"Don't I know it?" he said. "We got a heavy schedule. We gotta get out eighty-four hundred today. Why did that crazy Jew have to kill himself for right at this time?"

The bell rang and the shifts changed. It seemed funny, standing in his place—doing the very thing that he'd been doing a few hours before. He'd been doing this same little job for eight years—putting four bearing caps on each up-side-down motor that slid past. That was more than twelve hundred an hour—ten thousand each shift—three million each year—twenty-four million during his time in the factory. Twenty-four million caps on six million motors—that's what it figured up to in the long end. That, and two holes that his feet had worn in the hard concrete floor. I tell you—times like that, a man gets to thinking about things. He gets to wondering what life is all about—whether Mr. Holt's ideas about working hard may not be all wrong, and whether Jerry might not have been just as happy, if instead of doing twenty-four million caps, he had done only twenty million, or even only ten. But my thinking was not very clear. The line had started off with a bang and production was fast. Line bosses were riding the buggies and I heard one let out a yell at the top of his voice at a fellow that was standing on a box trying to look out of a window at the blast furnace.

That made me forget what I was trying to figure out. Maybe Jerry, too, had tried to figure out things for himself. Maybe, too, the same things had interfered with his thinking.

The line was confused. Men had their heads together, trying to talk and do their work at the same time. It was easy to guess what they were talking about.

Across from me, and a little below, was Russ. Opposite him was Jeff and next to Jeff, Amos. Unlike most of the others, Russ was giving himself to his job, but he acted gloomy and queer.

Even before lunch, rejected motors began streaming back from the run-in department. When the bell rang the tear-down line was swamped, and defective motors were stacked three high on the floor.

After lunch things got definitely worse. One motor came down the line without pistons; another had pistons but no valves. And still the bosses were afraid to slow down the line, because that would give the fellows more time to gang up and talk. Instead of dying down, the excitement got worse. A rumor would start near the front of the building, sweep down the line, and in twenty minutes it would be all through the department. One rumor had it that Jerry was really Mr. Holt's son. According to another, Mr. Holt was actually going to shut down and make us all go to a big funeral that he was going to pay for himself. Still another rumor had it that the chemists had found the motor block with Jerry's remains in it.

In a big gang like ours, where the men are all jammed up close, feelings and emotions are more catching than a bad case of measles, and two or three fellows like Amos can start a wild rumor going and demoralize the whole crew.

Fellows began taking time off—ganging up in the toilets, without asking for relief. I knew what that meant. Line bosses began losing control, shouting orders at men slipping away behind pillars and boxes. Two times I saw Gus with a dumb look on his face, leave his machine and sneak off. The third time his boss grabbed him by the collar and spun him around in his tracks—sent him back.

At two o'clock it looked like the bosses were not going to be able to hold things together until the end of the shift. The line was sull fast, but half the buggies were empties. That meant that the blocks were not coming off the machines up in front; that the gangs on the automatics where Gus worked, were breaking down. Line bosses were hurriedly transferred like shock troops in a battle. Orders flew thick and fast. Straw bosses tried to round up the men—tried to get every man back on the job.

And then a rumor came down the line that set every man's nerves on the jump. It was a rumor that the cylinder block, containing all that was left of Jerry, had arrived from the foundry and was being machined up in front. Tension built up in the men like a high voltage current. Conversation grew shrill and excited. Word spread to the toilets and the men hurried back to their stations, not wanting to miss out on a thing. Standing shoulder to shoulder with the other men on the line you could feel the tension build up.

Word came that the block was going through the broaching machine. Amos laid out eight nickel-plated cotter pins that he'd dug up from some-where. Jeff said they'd probably stick an American flag on the block like —they did when the twentieth million motor came over the line, only this time the flag would be at half-mast.

A little later we heard that the block was being milled on one of the merry-go-rounds—it was getting nearer. The fellows were getting more excited—the tension more strained.

A little later still the cylinders were being bored out. And then honed. A minute later—they'd found a porcelain tooth in the gray iron.

Men forgot what they were supposed to be doing. They craned their necks and raised up on their toes. One motor came by without a crankshaft—another with a speed wrench stuck upright on a main bearing nut.

One more machine operation to go—boring the holes. Maybe Gus would do it—Jerry's one friend. Then it would be clamped on a buggy and start down the line. Men's faces were white. There was no talk. The whole gang on the line surged forward.

There was a yell. Once—and then again and again. It rose high above the noise of the shop—like a man hurt—badly. It was Gus. Every man dropped his job and ran up towards the front of the shop. They jumped over tools and machines—around pillars and boxes. It was a stampede—a riot. And there was Gus—we saw him. Crazy-eyed, he was, standing away from his machine, pointing at the base near the floor.

"He's in dar!" he hollered. "He's in dar—I couedn't halp it. Jerry's in dar—I tell you! I kilt heem!"

Four or five of us fellows held him—tried to make him shut up. The others grabbed steel bars, power drills, and hammers, and tore down the machine. In no time it was a wreck—pieces scattered wide over the floor.

The automatics were down. The assembly line, of course, stopped. Someone had turned in an emergency call and two orderlies in white clothes came running up with a high-wheeled hospital cart. It took a half dozen men to strap him down, and when they wheeled him away, going swiftly down the long aisle, he was bucking the straps, trying to sit up, and hollering —

"Och Herre—Herre—I couedn't halp it. I couedn't halp it. I kilt heem!"

Motor assembly was shut down for the day. All of us fellows went out of the factory and slunk home like a bunch of whipped pups.

# CHAPTER XXXIV

That night, after supper, we sat around in the house. It was raining outside and we had a fire in the stove and Russ was down in the dumps and quiet, and I was telling Rita about the day in the factory—sort of stringing things out in slow talk; telling about Jerry committing suicide and Gus cracking up, but leaving out the part about wrecking the machine, because I thought it would get on Russ' nerves. When I finished she said:

"Those two guys—you've told me about them before. They were screwy. I don't see why Mr. Holt lets fellows like that work in the plant."

"That's what makes them screwy," Russ shouted. "They're all screwy. All the fellows that work on the line—except the niggers—all the whites on the automatics are queer. Go ahead," he told me, "go ahead—tell her what happened this afternoon. Tell her how you helped wreck the machine."

"You were in it, too —"

"We were all in it," he shouted. "All except Jerry. Jerry's the only one that had sense. He made an end to it—a hot breath and it was all over for him. He's out of it. You and I—we've gotta go back in the morning."

"What else?" she said. "Men are supposed to grow up. After all—you can't play hookey all your life. But tell me about wrecking the machine."

"You tell her," said Russ. "I'm trying to forget it."

So then I told her, making it seem as logical as possible. But without giving her an idea how the excitement built up throughout the whole day, it was hard to make the story seem real, so that I don't know whether she believed it or not. Telling it that way, to her, it all sounded so crazy.

"How funny," she said, when I finished. "Why didn't they get a light and look in the machine?"

"They wouldn't-a had to," I said, "if they'd only stopped to figure a minute—used their heads. In the first place, there wasn't room for a man to get in the machine, and in the second place—why would any man want to?"

"Why try to explain it?" Russ said, acting as though he was sore. "Why try to make it sound as though it was something we tried to figure out? We were all wild-eyed crazy. The next time— We would have torn up a man just as quick. It gives me the jitters."

But Rita wouldn't take it serious. She got up, walked around the stove, and sat down on his lap.

"Poor old Russ," she said. "The blue debbils got him, tonight. He's got the jitters and he's awful discouraged."

"Don't bother me," he said. "Get up."

"I don't want to," she said. "I'm going to sit on your lap. I guess I've got a right—if I feel like it."

She fooled around with his shirt collar. Unfastened the button and then tried to fasten it again.

"Come to bed, Russ," she said. "Forget about the factory—tonight."

"Don't," he said. "You're pinching."

"But I want to," she said. "I want to fuss around with you."

I got up.

"Well—" I said, "I guess I'll get me a drink and go into my room. I've gotta write a letter to a man about a dog."

I went to the sink, let the water run for a minute. She said something more and then he. His words were sharp. She came back. He got up quick—gave her a push, and she half rolled and half fell to the floor. She got up and struck him a stinging blow along side the face. Came at him again but he grabbed her by the wrist and spun her away. She was mad clean through. She grabbed the poker—cut the air—missed—and then threw it, hitting him in the face. She tried to get it again but he caught her. Held her arm like a vice.

"Now do you understand?" he said. "I don't want to go to bed. See?" There was a little trickle of blood from his lip.

"You're no good," she screamed at him, "you're a fake. You're impotent! impotent! impotent! Do you understand that? That means you're no good, Russ—no good."

For a second they stood looking hard at each other—their faces white. Her eyes blazing. Then he spun her half-way across the floor, got his coat, and went out the door. She flopped down on a chair and threw her head on her arms on the table—she was crying.

I went up to the table. She raised her head and dabbed at her eyes with her apron.

"He hurt me," she said. "Look at that."

There was a red circle around her arm where he'd held her.

"Why you little hell-cat," I said, "he shoulda busted it. He shoulda took you over his knee and paddled you good."

She looked up at me. Her eyes wide and the tears cold on her cheeks.

"Get out!" she said, standing up and stamping her foot. "Get out!"

"I'm gonna," I said, getting into my coat. "I'm gonna get out fast as I can and follow your husband—see he don't kill himself. He's nervous tonight—got the jitters. You heard what he said about Jerry being out of it all. He's liable to do the same thing if I don't stop him. I told you some of what happened today in the factory. But not all. I didn't tell you how the guys hollered—how they looked—what a job we had to strap Gus down on the cart. I was telling it easy—trying to make Russ think it wasn't so bad, trying not to stir up his feelings. You had to go and spoil it all."

I went out. Russ was a long way down the street, walking fast. I hurried after, trying to catch up. Then I decided to follow—keep out of sight. No use getting excited, I thought, if he's only going to the beer joint—only going to get drunk.

Where there were stores I kept close to the buildings. Where there were street lights I kept in the dark. He neared a corner where I knew he would turn either to the left or the right. To the right was the beer joint; in the other direction was the factory. He turned left.

I walked fast. Near the corner I ran, not wanting to lose him. From the corner I looked down the street. For a minute I didn't see him. There were other men walking, fellows going to the factory, who worked the graveyard. Then I saw him again, coming into the light. He had no hat. I followed again. A bunch of fellows got on a street car, but he continued to walk. No use spending good money for car fare, I thought, when there's no hurry—when all you're going to do is jump into a blast furnace, maybe. I remembered again what he'd said "A hot breath and it's all over." Simple as that, in his mind—the way he was feeling. Think of a woman trying to make love to a man when he's feeling like that.

I remembered a piece I'd read in the Sunday paper about favorite suicide places. One was a volcano in Japan. People had to climb a high mountain to reach it. Another was a high bridge near Los Angeles. "Suicide Bridge" it was called and there'd been a picture. More than a hundred people had jumped off into the canyon beneath it and they had to put up a high fence over the railing. Maybe they'd have to do something about the blast furnace, I thought.

There were more men on the streets. I walked faster. Near the gate, in the crowd, I'd be able to walk right behind him. There was no danger of losing him now; no danger of his seeing me in the crowd. Blindfolded, I'd still know the way.

I decided not to call in the H.P.'s unless I had to. I'd wait till he got near the furnace. Then I'd talk to him. Step out of the dark and put my hand on his shoulder.

"You got a job, Russ," I'd say. "Think of all the poor bastards in the streets of Detroit looking for work. You've got a wife and kid—they need you."

He went in through number two gate. Besides the guard, there were a couple of H.P.'s. They noticed our badges, but they were interested mostly in the stream of men going out, noticing pockets—coats that bulged out too much in the wrong places. It was easy to stick a Bendix gear under your hat—a roll of soldering wire inside your shirt. In Detroit, these things are like cash.

Through the wide alley between the high buildings I followed. Past the power house; the glass plant; the spring and upset building. Then he turned left—unexpected. I couldn't figure it out. He was going directly away from the blast furnace—over the railroad tracks—past final assembly —away from the noise and the lights.

Ahead there was nothing but dark acres of corded steel; the boneyard; the field full of old cars waiting their turn for the crusher. Beyond that, a high fence. I had to walk faster to keep him in sight. Now the roar of the plant was behind us; ahead, the boneyard under a few open lights that swung crazily in a blustery sky. He went in among the old machines. The manipulator was still there in the mud. He went up to it; pried open the rusty tool-box; took out a rag and began swiping.

I leaned weakly against the dark side of an old welding machine. Weakly, I said to myself, over and over again "Well I'll be—I'll be a son-of-a-bitch."

I watched him a while just to see what he would do. His big hands curved over the brasses; his fingers touching and feeling; the tips of his fingers sensing the feel of the metal that was cold and dead. Along the smooth shafts his hands slid, gentle and yet strong in their motions; firm and gentle; flowing along the cold steel, except when they rested a moment, cupped over a brass journal, like a man's hand on a young woman's breast. Continually in motion, along the easy curves of gear housings; on bare iron; along naked steel—exploring, as if trying to draw strength from the cold metal. He climbed to the controls and let his hands flow over the dead levers; levers that his hands had once known so well; touching each one—sliding his hands along the smooth metal—feeling them—trying to understand them with the tips of his bare fingers. And then down again—swiping away 2 bit of rust—reaching a hand into a nest of cold gears; leaning the while against the base of the machine—one hand exploring and touching, the other pressed against the bare, unpainted steel.

It came to me, all of a sudden, that what he was doing was sort of saying farewell to the machine—getting up nerve to pull off some desperate act. But I was wrong again.

I stepped up into the light and he saw me. He came out of it, then, like someone waking up from a dream.

"You here?" he said.

"'What's the idea?" I asked. ""What's the idea, coming out here like this?"

He stood there in the mud to his ankles, twisting the rag.

"Why don't you leave me be?" he said. "Why did you have to follow? I had to get away by myself. Old Betsy here—to see her again—I thought it would do me good. I was mixed up—feeling low."

"You feel better now—since swiping around on that thing?"

"I don't know."

"Judast, Russ," I said. "What's the matter with you? I never saw you acting like that. When I think of the man you was in the drop forge and then look at you now—slobbering—standing there in the mud —"

"That's why I came out here," he said. "Old Betsy here—I thought I would get some of my old strength back. But it's no good, Bennie. No good."

"Come on," I said. "All you'll get out here in this mud is wet feet and a dose of pneumonia."

I grabbed his arm. Made him walk fast. Neither one of us said a word till we got outside the plant. Then I talked to him again. Tried to get him straightened out.

"You gotta snap out of it," I said. "You gotta get ahold of yourself. The way you been acting lately is something fierce. Today was bad in the factory, but tomorrow everything will be running along smooth again."

"I gotta get out of it," he said.

"Get out of it? How you gonna get out of it now? You still owe me thirty bucks. You ain't got no money saved up. All you got to get out with is a half-interest in the outboard and an old jalopy that won't run."

"Ain't you gonna pull out with me, Bennie?"

"I'm used to Detroit. I'm not saying I'm gonna pull out—I'm not saying I won't. I don't want to talk about it now."

"I don't wanna pull out alone. Not alone—Bennie."

"Alone? What about your wife and the kid?"

"We'd make a place for 'em," he said. "Then get 'em to come. Build a cabin—not wait till we get enough money saved up for a trailer. I know a place near a river where the grass comes down to the water—tall trees behind for the wind to play in. We'd make a low fence to keep the kid in—paint it white. There'd be wild morning-glory vines by the windows and a bunch of hollyhocks near the gate. Do you see how it'd look, Bennie? She'd like it. There'd be no more arguments—no fights."

"And use what for money? Blame it all, Russ, I don't know why I bother about you. I should have stayed in the house. The way you talked—about ending it all—I thought you was going to jump in the blast furnace."

"No, Bennie—no. Not that."

"You ain't got the nerve—have you, Russ?"

"Not even to think about it," he said. "Think what would happen! Think what happened to Jerry!"

"I wish now," I said, "I'd-a let you gone out by yourself. Instead of that I got in an argument with your wife and got put out of the house. Dog-gone you—you're gonna apologize for us both. And then you're gonna make a new start. Cut out the beer joints and stuff—work steady—be decent to Rita."

"I don't want to go back to the factory," he said. "I don't want to ever put another nut on a bolt."

"Well, you're gonna," I said. "You're gonna go back and like it. You're not gonna let a little thing like what happened today get you down. You're gonna get ahold of yourself—make a new start. And the way to do it is not to run away from it. The way to do it is to stick out your chest and raise up your chin and lick the tar out of any man that says you can't hold down a-job on the line."

When we reached the house it was dark. We went in and Russ turned on the light. We hung our coats up on the wall behind the stove. Russ went into the bedroom and came out.

"She's gone," he said in a whisper. "The kid too. It's my fault, Bennie. What'll I do?" He had a scared look on his face.

"Do nothing," I said. "Go to bed."

"I can't. I've got to know where they are."

"I'll tell you," I said. "They're at the Old Man's house."

"I've got to get them," he said, making a grab for his coat. But I stopped him.

"No you don't," I said. "Try to talk to her now and there'd be another argument. Let her alone. for tonight. It'll give you a chance to figure out what a sap you've been. It'll give her a chance to cool off her temper. In the morning you can tell her you're sorry—ask her to come back."

I took his coat and hung it back on the nail. Then I tarned off the light and we went into our rooms. I heard one of his shoes drop to the floor, and after waiting till I almost fell off to sleep, I heard the other.

# CHAPTER XXXV

In the morning we left the house early and stopped at the Rettinellis' on the way to the factory. The Old Man had already left for work but Mrs. Rettinelli was there and came out before we had a chance to knock. We should have throwed our hats in through the door even before going up on the porch to find out how she felt, because she was on the war-path. Her elbows stuck out and she cut loose on us with some high-tension Italian so fast that we couldn't understand a word that she said. But even so, it was easy enough to figure out, in a general way, what she meant.

Rita was nowhere in sight, but her kid brother was, and he poked his nose past the Old Lady's elbow and when she ran out of breath he made things additionally clear.

"Sis is mad at youse guys," he said. "And Mom says to get off our porch and we changed the baby's name back to Tony—like Pa's. Bennie's too sissy."

"Well—that's that," I said to Russ. "Let's go."

We retreated as far as the sidewalk.

"Wait a minute," said Russ. "Maybe we oughta do something more."

"That's right," I said. "What we oughta do is slap that kid's ears down for him."

That started them both off again and then there was nothing for us to do but clear out, because the neighbors were beginning to take notice of the argument and it was easy to see where they stood. Russ didn't know what to do. He couldn't make up his mind about nothing.

"If I could see her," he said.

"But you can't. Didn't you hear what the Old Lady said?"

"If I could talk to her —"

"You can't do that either—until she gets over being mad at you."

"Maybe I oughta stay home? Maybe she'll come after her stuff—and I'll see her."

The kid kept a sharp eye on us from the porch. The Old Lady watched us through a window.

"Don't take it so serious," I said. "Give her time to get over it; let her alone for a couple of days. After the Old Man pays for a can of that high-powered baby food he'll be glad to ship them both

back."

We went to the factory. While going through the gate he was still trying to make up his mind whether we should have taken the street car or walked; whether he should have come to the factory or stayed home; whether to buy his lunch outside the gate or in the shop. I was getting more disgusted with him all the time.

We were two minutes late. It was the first time that year I'd had red ink on my card. Russ took his place on the line; I stepped in beside a new fellow who was taking Jerry's place and showed him what to do. The fellow took a hold good, and being a nigger, I knew he'd get onto the job without tying himself up into a knot.

The line was slow and quite a few of the old fellows were absent. There was still some talk about what had happened the day before but there were no more rumors and the men were no longer excited.

About ten in the morning a bunch of H.P.'s with polished shoes came down from the office and stood around the bare spot on the floor where Gus' machine had been, and looked wise. They talked to Norm and then pulled some of the fellows off the line to ask questions. They didn't bother Russ or me and I was glad when they left.

And then, shortly after, Russ started dragging over and getting into trouble. I hurried over to see what was the matter. He was fighting the job—not working quiet and smooth like the others—and although the line was not fast, he looked tired and worried.

"Listen, Bennie," he said, when I stepped in beside him, "do you hear what it says? What that belt says—up there?"

"No. What?" At first I didn't take him serious.

"It keeps pounding at me," he said. "It keeps pounding—IM-PO-TENT—IM-PO-TENT—IM-PO-TENT—over and over. It's been going like that all morning. All morning I've been trying to shut it outa my ears. But I can't. Don't you get it?"

"Aw-w—nuts, Russ. Lay off."

"But I'm telling you—Bennie—it's so. There it is again. Hear it?"

"No."

"It's louder now. There it goes—IM-PO-TENT—IM-PO-TENT—IM-PO-TENT—. One heavy beat—two slow—over and over. And it's so, Bennie—I'm no good—I'm impotent! She was right—when she said it. I've been no good ever since they changed the belt on that motor."

"Love of Mike, Russ—you want the fellows to know all about your wife troubles? Pipe down."

He'd been talking loud—holding a handful of nuts—letting me do the job. Amos was edging up close. He had a nose for anything that made talk. Already he sensed something funny. He had a grin on his face and his ears fairly stuck out.

I had Russ back where he belonged.

"Now stay up," I said. "Tend to your job. If I see you getting behind again I'm going to tell Norm. Cut out that crazy talk."

"I can't stay up," he said, "not with that belt, Bennie. I've got the willies. That belt's the cause of it all. I was all right till they changed it."

"That belt stuff," I said, "is the bunk. It's giving me a bad pain in the neck. I don't wanna hear no more about it."

"See Norm," he said. "Talk to him. Tell him to take it off and put on the other. I'll be all right with the other. I'll promise not to drag over. I'll keep up on the job, Bennie."

"No—by Judast!"

"You've got to, Bennie. This one is driving me nutty. I've got the willies. It's been the cause of all my trouble with you—with Norm—and with Rita. I'd be all right with the other."

I had to step in again and do three or four motors. He didn't have his mind on the job. And talking to him, I could see, wasn't going to do any good.

I stepped out and left him. I figured I'd have to do something quick—get him transferred, if possible. I decided to have a talk with Norm right away. If a line boss came to Norm first—Russ would go out through the door. I got a hold of Norm just as the bell rang for lunch.

"Norm," I said, "Russ has got himself tied up with that belt again."

"That crazy lumber-jack," he said. "Get me his timecard. I'll fire him."

"But listen —"

"Listen, nothing," he said. "I'm gonna fire him. After what happened yesterday I ain't taking no chances."

"But I'm telling you, Norm—that guy's a whizz. He can run anything that's got wheels on."

"Who'd want him?" he said. "I can't give him no recommend."

"He was a good man in drop forge. He'd be good again—around big stuff, where there's hard work to do. The tougher a job is the better he likes it. That's the kind of guy he is."

"Yeh? Don't make me laugh. It's the old buddy stuff again—ain't it, Bennie? All right—get me a transfer slip from the desk. Make it snappy."

I got the slip and Norm made it out.

"Give it to him," he said. "And tell him to punch out—now. We'll get along without him this afternoon."

I started away when he called.

"Better go with him," he said. "If they got no place for him—don't bring him back."

Russ was lined up behind a big nigger at the ptomaine wagon, waiting his turn to buy a carton of beans. I pulled him out.

"Come on," I said. "We gotta get you a transfer. You're all through in motor assembly."

I was expecting an argument, but he said nothing.

We went to the clock and punched out his card and took it up to the desk. Then we went to the transfer department, and all the way through the plant, instead of walking up beside me, he trailed behind like a tired pup.

In the transfer department he acted as though he didn't know quite what it was all about. I talked to the clerk.

"What you got for this man?" I asked.

"Final assembly," he said, "blue mass."

"That all? Nothing else?"

"Rolling mill."

"What kind of work would he be doing there?"

"How would I know? I don't own the place. I only work here."

"You wouldn't kid me, would you?" I asked.

"Maybe you think it ain't work," he said, "standing here listening to you guys all day asking them kind of questions."

"Maybe we oughta come back tomorrow," said Russ. "Maybe they'd have something better."

"What kind of job you looking for, Buddy?" asked the clerk, turning his high-powered attention to Russ.

"I'd kinda like to get a job sweeping," he said.

"We got more sweepers now'n we know what to do with. Come back tomorrow, there might not be anything at all. Your card says you worked in the drop forge. I'm going to send you to the rolling mill," he said, starting to fill out the slip. "Big fellow like you oughta get along good there. Report four-thirty, this afternoon. You're on the night shift."

He gave Russ the card and we left. Before separating, near the motor assembly building, I gave him another talk, telling him things that I thought would do him some good.

"You were lucky," I said, "getting that job in the rolling mill. There's big machines there—the kind of stuff that you like. You shoulda jumped at the chance. Instead of that you stand there and tell the guy you'd kinda like to be a sweeper. Kinda—. What's the matter with you, Russ? I never see you act that way before."

"I don't know," he said, acting sort of nervous and queer. "I don't know. I keep thinking all the ume I'm no good. I keep hearing that belr—what it said. I keep hearing it. You and Norm shouldn't have changed it, Bennie."

"Me and Norm? Where do you get that me and Norm stuff?" I said.

"If I fall down on this job—hear that noise in my ears ——"

"Aw-w-w for the love of Mike, Russ, cut it out. Forget about that belt—can't you? Try to act like a man. You got a new job. You're starting all over now—see? You'll be around big machines—hot steel. It'll be like it was in the drop forge—big jobs going on all the time. And there's no belts."

"No belts?"

"No belts."

I heard the two-minute bell ring and remembered I'd had no lunch yet. Men were hurrying past where we stood.

"All right now," I said. "Go home—get some sleep. Get going."

I put my hand on his shoulder and gave him a push and then left him.

From the wide door of the building I watched him. It was a minute or two before he started moving off towards the gate.

# CHAPTER XXXVI

When I got home that night the house was cold and dark. Russ had already gone to the factory and the dirty breakfast dishes still littered the table and the alarm clock had stopped and behind the stove was the outboard motor in a wooden box. Russ must have packed it that afternoon with pieces of used lumber that he'd probably got from the hardware store. There were chips and pieces of wood on the floor and across the top of the box in mutilated letters was stenciled: "F. O. B. Detroit."

I looked into their bedroom and saw in a minute that all of Rita's things were gone. Even the red box in which she had always kept her black velvet dress and silver dancing shoes was no longer up on the shelf in the closet and I happened to think that not once in all the time she'd been married to Russ had she worn them. One of the Rettinellis, the kid brother I figured, had probably come for her things in the morning.

I cooked me some hamburger and potatoes and ate, and then washed the dishes, and the fire went out, and the tea kettle puttered a couple of times and then stopped, and the excitement dropped to an all-time low in that house.

I thought some about going to Rettinelli's to try to have a talk with Rita and then remembered that the Old Man would be there and that he'd probably be drunk and pretty sore about things in general, and I decided that when Russ braced up again he would be able to handle things better than I. And then I thought about Russ and wondered what kind of job he'd got in the rolling mill and right then I got up, put on my coat, and left the house for the factory to see how he was making out.

The rolling mill was at the rear of the plant about a mile away from the main gate. Outsiders and those not working there were not allowed on the floor because the work that went on there was big stuff and dangerous. But there was a small door at the side of the building through which in the day time the guides led the long strings of visitors. From this door a long stairway led to a steel walk high up above the ground near the ceiling and from this point I saw the whole vast floor spread out below.

There were three mills in the building and two were running, rolling out long red snakes of steel, and beside each set of rollers stood a man on a platform with a pair of long tongs to seize the heads of the red snakes to guide them into the grooves. On the whole wide floor there were only these two and one of these two was Russ.

Often before I'd stood up on the high bridge watching the work, but never at night. Now the vast interior of the building lay in semi-darkness except where a giant crane lifted glowing ingots of steel from the "soaking pits"; where the red snakes flowed, and where the high spot-lights stabbed through the dark at the two men below.

In spite of his six feet two and magnificent shoulders the distance and the size of the machine at which he stood made Russ look small and insignificant and puny. He was like a puppet in a floor show. Here the machines were all giants—electric motors with ladders for men to climb; drive shafts of polished steel as big as a man's waist; rollers so large that the bearings alone weighed tons. Here the whole process of rolling steel was so nearly automatic that you had to look for the operators—the men in glass cages, suspended between the floor and the ceiling, who played with rows of small levers that controlled the motion and speed of motors whose horsepower was rated in thousands.

The whole business of the plant was to change short, heavy pieces of steel into light ones; short, fat snakes into long, thin ones. They came out of the darkness on long tables, heads bobbing and weaving. They came with incredible speed—slowed up a little as they came up to Russ standing on a steel platform beside the big rollers.

There were different grooves in the rollers—big ones and little. Russ seized the heads with his tongs—got the snakes started into the right grooves. Then the rollers got in their powerful work. A fat snake went in—a slim, angry snake squirted out on the opposite side, its head bouncing away into the darkness.

. Water sprayed over the hot rollers and for a minute or two Russ would be lost to sight in the steam.

The snake having passed through, the big rollers would come to a sudden stop and reverse. The snake would stop, too, and return. Russ had to be quick, because what had been the snake's tail was now its head and came bouncing back to be seized again and once more passed through the rollers.

If you looked close you saw what it was that made the snakes stop and dart back and forth. In the beds of the long tables there were hundreds of spinning feed rolls. These were controlled by the operators in the steel and glass cages.

I watched Russ awhile. I thought he was getting along all right. He was not yet as expert in the job as the other fellow—more excited. The other fellow refused to let himself be hurried. When the red snakes came too fast he shot a hard-boiled look up at the cage over his head. Once he leaned on his tongs and forced the operator to bring the spinning feed rolls to a complete stop.

Being on a new job Russ was naturally excited. He swung the tongs about more than was necessary, and each time one of the long snakes darted towards him he flinched back as though fearing that it might not slow up. Then it shot through the rollers and was coming back at him again almost, it seemed, before he had recovered his poise.

I could see it was not exactly the kind of job that he would have liked. "I like machines," he had said, "'chat I run—not those that run me." Well, he wasn't exactly running this one, but at the same time, he was doing his part on a big job.

Working there, a tiny black shape on the floor, he had his back towards me and not once had he looked up. I had a notion to let out a yell and shout down 2 word of encouragement. And then I decided it wouldn't be a wise thing to do.

ing a job like that a man has to keep his wits about him. A sudden turn—or jerk—and he might easily slip off the shiny steel platform. Those big motors could stop and reverse quick—but not quick enough, if a man should happen to lose his footing and fall down in front of the rollers.

I went down the long stairs and walked home, thinking that Russ was all straightened out and that he was going to get along swell.

I went home and to bed and it seemed like I'd only just got to sleep when there was a loud knock on the door. I jerked on my pants and went out.

There on the porch stood an H.P. with a flash light —in his hand and he wanted to know if he'd come to the house where Russ lived and asked if Rita was home. He'd left his car running and lights on, and the way he stood there and the way his heavy words came out of the dark—I knew what he'd come to say. If he'd hollered out at me at the top of his voice, "There's been an accident —a bad one!" he couldn't have made it any plainer to me.

"Did it kill him?" I asked.

"They had to take his legs off," he said.

I went into the house and while putting on the rest of my clothes I thought those dry words would never stop floating before me.

I came out again and explained how it was that Rita was not at the house.

"We'll have to find her," I said.

We got into the car and I told him which way to go and after a bit my brain started working again and I asked questions. The H.P. didn't know all the details, but somehow, he told me, Russ had got into the machine. Before the operator could stop the rollers, both legs had been crushed. They'd amputated above the knees.

At Rettinelli's the house was dark but after pounding the door the Old Man stuck his head out of a window. Rita was not at home, he said. She was at the dance hall. He grumbled something more in Italian and then pulled his head back into the house and slammed down the window as if he was burned up about something, and if Rita was at the taxi-dance place, I guess maybe he was.

It didn't take us long to reach the dance hall and while the H.P. waited I went upstairs to get Rita.

About fifty couples were dancing to swing music and I saw Rita with a tall sailor who was trying to do the Big Apple, and a guy dressed like a waiter tried to stop me from going on the floor. The music and everything seemed far away and all I could think of was what the H.P. had told me and when I came up to Rita and she stopped dancing, I blurted out—"They had to take his legs off—Russ."

She looked at me hard with scared eyes and grabbed my shoulders and said "Bennie! What do you mean, Bennie?"

"Russ," I said. "He's had an accident."

The sailor jerked her arm.

"It's a gag," he said. "Come on, baby—let's dance."

"Don't," she said. "It's my husband." And to me, "Where is he?"

"In the hospital," I said. "There's a car waiting to take us. I thought maybe —"

"Of course. Quick, Bennie—let's go."

She got her wrap and threw it over her shoulders and we hurried down and got into the back of the car. While driving, the H.P. repeated what he'd already told me, which wasn't a great deal, and then I told her about Russ getting transferred to the rolling mill and how I'd watched him at work in his new job that very night.

aes?

"It's my fault," she moaned, "it's my fault, Bennie. I shouldn't have acted the way I did. Oh, why didn't I talk to him this morning? Why didn't I talk to him, Bennie?"

"Why didn't you?" I said.

"I don't know, Bennie. I wanted to—but I was still mad. I wanted to teach him a lesson. I wanted him to see how it felt to be left alone. Always there was his talk about clamming—about going away. And I couldn't—not after we had the baby. His talk frightened me—I loved him so. Always—I'd put my hand out in the morning before waking—I'd feel him, and wake with a prayer. 'Thank God,' I'd say, 'he's still there.' I wanted him to come for me tonight—to the dance hall. I wanted him to dance with me again—see me again in this dress. Oh, Bennie—why did it have to turn out like this? Why can't we turn time back like a clock? Why can't we live one little day over again to correct our mistakes?"

She broke down and cried and I sort of put my arm around her shoulder.

"It's not your fault," I said. "Lately he's been acting nervous and sort of funny. There was a belt over his head. He blamed it on that. And then, during the last couple of days—he was worse. That's why we had to get him a transfer. I thought being around big machines—working hard—doing tough jobs, he'd come out of it all right."

She was silent, except for her sobbing. There was a red light and the car rolled to a stop.

"Ain't that the way it is?" said the H.P. "When you're trying to make time every signal gives you the laugh."

I didn't answer. I guess he was only saying something to make talk. The idling motor turned over lightly; a lake boat sent a booming note out of the night fog. The lights changed and we started. I drew my arm back.

"Better get a hold of yourself now," I said. "We're getting near the plant."

She braced up and dabbed at her face with a small handkerchief. I could see she was trying to steel herself for something that would take every bit of nerve that she had.

"Was he running the machine—the machine that hurt him?" she asked.

"Well—no. Things are pretty automatic in there. There were a couple of fellows in a glass cage pulling levers, but you couldn't tell which one was doing what."

"I thought so," she said. "He used to tell me 'I like machines that I run—I hate those that run me.'"

"He could run anything that had wheels on it," I said. "He was a good mechanic."

"Good at anything," she said, "where he had a chance. He would have been a good clammer, perhaps. You were friends—you and he were always together. But there were things about him you didn't understand—didn't know. I didn't either—but I do now. And now it's too late."

"Not too late," I said. "You're talking as if he were dead. There are lots of good jobs in the factory that a man without —"

"Don't say it," she screamed. "There are no more good jobs for him. You don't understand yet, Bennie. He needed the wind in his hair—the rain in his face. Don't you see—we were all three against him. You and I and the factory. On the other side were the woods—the rivers—the blackbirds building their nests in the swamps. We won, Bennie. Don't you understand? I see it all, now—why didn't I before?"

To tell the truth about it I didn't see. But I didn't argue with her because she was letting herself get worked up again. Besides, we had reached the factory.

The H.P. waved to the guard and we drove in through the gate. In a minute we'd be at the hospital. Too soon, I figured, because Rita was shaking.

"We want to walk," I called to the H.P. "Let us out here. A little walk before we go in will be good for us."

"Sure," he said. "I know how it is. It'll give you a chance to pull yourselves together a little."

He pulled up alongside the front of the final assembly building and stopped and opened the door for us like a taxi-cab driver.

"I'll go with you," he said. "It's my orders, you know. If we go through the building, here, we won't have to go over the tracks. Tracks are dangerous at night."

He led the way. I took Rita's arm and we went into the building. The burst of noise as we stepped through the door was like an ocean wave that rolled over everything and went on and on. I

liked the smells and the sights and the speed of things. The Cooper-Hewitts shot their bright lights against the glistening sides of new cars; pneumatic hoists purred as bodies swung down to meet chassis at just the right moment; electric wrenches whirred continuously; there was the energetic beat of air hammers on steel. It was too noisy to talk.

We walked in the wide traffic aisle that ran through the length of the building. Tractor drivers pulled their loads to one side and stopped; swampers and stockmen moved boxes of stuff out of the way and stood respectfully to one side while we passed. It reminded me of the times I'd seen an English actress come through the plant with two special guides.

Rita tried to hold her dress from the floor as she hurried along. I held her arm and watched where we walked. She carried a beaded bag and had some kind of sparkling ornament on her head that shimmered and danced as she walked, and the smell of lilacs seemed to come from her hair. She wore earrings that looked like diamonds and the skin of her neck was snow-white against the edge of her black velvet dress.

Hundreds of fellows stopped their work for a second or two and stared as we passed, and I was glad that I had thought to put on my good suit in the hurry and excitement of leaving the house.

It must have been an unusual sight for the Hungarians, the Polacks, the Italians, the Russians, the Hollanders, the niggers, and all the others working there on the graveyard shift in the loneliest time of the whole night—to see a beautiful young girl in a floating wrap and evening dress come through the shop.

Many of them had probably never seen a woman dressed like that in all their ordinary lives. Some of them must have thought she was a movie star and that she was my wife. Not many would have guessed that she was only a taxi-dancer hurrying to the side of her husband who lay crushed and mangled in the Holt hospital and who until that very night had been a Holt worker like themselves; not many would have guessed that her earrings were glass and that there was probably nothing in the beaded purse but a couple of dimes.

There are lots of good jobs in a place like the Holt factory for a man without legs. That's what I was going to tell Rita when she stopped me.

Russ would be a Holt worker again. The company would find a place for him. I'd help.

That was one of the advantages of working for a big outfit like the Holt Motor Company—they took care of their men. They didn't have to kick out their cripples like the smaller outfits that didn't have the jobs nor the money to carry them.

I thought of the salvage department on the top floor of a high building where the factory visitors never came—a whole department where every man lacked a leg or an arm or a nose or an eye; where the floor sweepings were dumped on a long belt, and the men sorted out bits of brass, cotter pins, bolts, lock washers, small pieces of copper, etc. The bosses had things fixed up for them. The men without hands used steel hooks instead of fingers; those without feet used chairs with wheels on them. Some of the old men with good feet were even allowed to sit down at their jobs.

But I couldn't see Russ working up there. He'd get bored with the jobs up there—they'd be too easy—too simple.

And then something happened that gave me an idea all of a sudden. We came to the place on the line where they put on the fenders and I saw the man without legs who shot across the floor and under the cars on a scooter and put in the bolts. Rita saw him, too, and she stopped and put up a hand as though she had suddenly seen a ghost there in the factory.

"What's the matter?" I said.

She made a sound and said something but I couldn't hear what it was and we started walking again.

She was excited and you couldn't blame her. All she saw there was a man without legs.

What she didn't see was that the man was clever; that he was doing his work twice as well as the man on the opposite side of the car whose legs, as long as he was on the job, were only a nuisance. She didn't know that the engineers had rigged up a special chromium-plated scooter for him with ball bearings, and that the straw boss was not allowed to fire him without an o-keh from the safety department. She didn't stop to figure that the man was pulling down the same dough as the rest; that he was hanging onto his job for dear life, knowing that if he was fired for being absent without cause, he'd never be able to get back in the shop.

The man was probably saving his money—not buying outboard motors and old cars—not running around to beer joints at night. She had said "There are no more good jobs for him."

She didn't know that when the man without legs had worked on the day shift that the crowds of visitors coming through the factory had watched him in openmouthed wonder.

Somewhere in his book Mr. Holt says "If there's one thing the American worker lacks—it's discipline." Russ never had any.

Thinking about all those things—letting them run through my mind—I got to thinking about what I'd tell that fellow up in the transfer department when the time came.

We reached the hospital. It was a squarish, two story building in the heart of the plant.

On the ground floor were the first aid doctors who took care of small injuries.

Above, was the operating room and two rows of small rooms with high beds in them. Here, in a long hall with dim lights, a doctor in a sleeveless white gown came up and the H.P. went back down the stairs. The doctor spoke to me first.

"You Bennie?" he said, poking a finger in the direction of my stomach.

"Yeh," I said. "And this is his wife. Tell us about him."

He looked at Rita in a kind, gentle way. He was about the same age as her father.

"I guess you know we had to amputate," he said.

"Both legs?" she asked.

He nodded.

"Above the knees," he said. She turned her head as though trying not to look at his bare arms and hands.

"We never like to do those things," he said, "but sometimes we have to. And when they have to be done—the quicker we do them the better. We tried to call you."

Opposite us a door opened and a nurse came out into the hall. When the door closed again I had the feeling that he was behind that door—in that room.

"Is there danger?" I asked.

"Not much," he said. "Some loss of blood, of course. But they had him up here in no time and he has a physique like a bull."

"Let me see him," said Rita. "Please—now. Let me go in."

"In a minute," he said, putting his hand on her arm. "But I want you to promise—no emotional stuff while you're in there."

"I promise—if I have to bite off my tongue."

"And about the amputation—he doesn't know."

"Doesn't know?"

"Not yet. He's had enough shock for one night."

"How could he help but—how could you keep it from him?"

"He's had an anaesthetic. And a couple of shots. No feeling—you know. Not yet."

The nurse came back down the hall. He spoke to her.

"Let these people see the patient," he said. And to us "Go in now—make it short."

The nurse opened the door—the same door—and we saw Russ. His face was white and the old fighting spirit was gone. Knowing him—it was a shock just to see him lying there flat and helpless on a hospital bed. I had expected to see the bottom part of the bed smooth and empty, but they had arranged some material under the lower part of the sheets to take the place of his legs that were not there.

Rita threw herself forward and covered his face and his hair. She held his head in her hands and kissed him over and over. Tight little sobs came from her throat, and there were tears, I guess, but no wailing and moaning.

"I'm so glad—I'm so glad," she repeated.

"You went away," he said, looking at her with troubled eyes as though trying to recall something he couldn't quite remember. She brushed at her eyes.

"But I'm back now, Russ," she said, trying to smile.

"Why did you go away?" he asked. "It's such a long time —"

"It doesn't matter—now," she said, kissing his mouth and his cheeks. "All that matters now is that I'm back—that I'll never leave you again—that I'll take care of you, Russ. Take care of you always."

"What are you glad about? You said you were glad."

"That I'm here, Russ. That I still have you—to love and take care of."

"Oh."

Then he was quiet a minute while she stroked his hair and whispered something that I couldn't hear. The nurse remained near the door and I stood at the foot of the bed and I couldn't keep from looking at the long bump under the sheets that were supposed to be his two legs. It pulled at my eyes like a magnet. Russ put out his hand and touched Rita's dress.

"You were dancing," he said.

"I was hoping you'd come," she answered low. "I was hoping you'd come and dance with me and take me home—like you used to."

"But I didn't."

"You were on the night shift," she said. "And I didn't know."

"I was on the night shift," he repeated. "In the rolling mill."

And then for the first time, it seemed, he noticed me. He tried to raise himself up on his elbow and his eyes opened wide as though he were coming out of a sleep.

"Bennie," he said, "where was you when I called? Why didn't you come? I was in the mill—now I'm here."

I put my hand on his arm. The nurse stepped forward.

"You're all right, Russ," I said. "Take it easy, old boy."

"I'm not all right," he shouted. "Something's happened. There's been an accident—my legs are all numb. I was in the mill, Bennie—fighting long pieces of steel—trying to make them go in. They were like snakes. They kept coming at me. They were like the motors—there was no end—I couldn't stop them. And then something happened. I called you, Bennie—I yelled. Why didn't you come?"

Rita and the nurse tried to quiet him but he pushed them away with his arms.

"They came at me," he shouted. "Out of the dark—bobbing their heads. They never stopped —never gave me a chance —"

"Calm down," I said.

He relaxed. His head dropped down on the pillow.

"Russ—" said Rita, in a voice that was husky with pain, "don't carry on so. Please don't —"

The doctor hurried back into the room. He motioned for us to get out quickly. I took my hat from the bed. Russ saw me turning to leave when he spoke.

"Wait!" he said. "Don't go!" He sounded like the old Russ again; like the old Russ who had not been afraid to tell Johnson where to head in; who had turned the tables on Norm when Norm had taken him for a walk; whose word had been law among the niggers at the house-wrecking. What there was in the sound of his voice or the way he looked—I don't know. All I know is that while he talked not one of us in that room moved a muscle or spoke.

"Bennie," he said, "it's spring now. I can feel the air from the lake. In a few days now the wild geese will be flying. It's time to pull out. I know a place where there's a bend in the river—where old trees—soft maples and elms—hang over the water. We'll build us a cabin there with windows that swing open like doors—make a path winding up to a spring. When the first dandelions come we'll be all ready to move in. We'll get her and the kid—Little Bennie. They'll come. We've got to go now—not wait for another depression—not wait for summer. I've got the outboard all packed. They can't keep me here in this dump—on my back. I'll be outa here —"

He stopped short and looked at our faces.

"What's the matter?" he said. "You all look so dumb."

Rita hurried out of the room sobbing loudly. The doctor followed and the nurse motioned for me to go, too. Russ made an effort to raise his head from the pillow.

"Bennie," he said, "are you going with me? I want to know—now!"

"Sure, Russ," I said. "You know me. I've always stuck with you—ain't I?"

Then I went out, too, and the nurse closed the door.

THE END